Fidem et proditionem (Of loyalty and treason)

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Fidem et proditionem (Of loyalty and treason)

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

The world of Etheria is full of secrets. Some, darker than others. But most importantly, there's a very delicate balance keeping the world from falling into a bloody war. The people privy to such secrets usually learn very quickly why they have to keep their mouths shut. And so, for decades, Etheria has been in relative peace…
However, rumours began circulating five years ago. People speak about vampires and hunters; the names "Horde" and "Alliance" start floating around… They aren't scared, as one would presume, but rather interested; people seem allured by the stories of new vampires appearing left and right in recent years, and of said vampires being hunted down under the cover of night…
The police chief of Bright Moon and an ordinary physician of Mystacor's floating medical institution will discover just how delicate Etheria's situation is, and the fate of the world may be in their hands.



Notes

A little thing: The first 3 chapters will be posted one after the other, one each day, but then the updates will be weekly :D

And second, I'd like to clarify this, to make sure my way of writing is clear enough. I don't write in the English format.
That would be
"Character's direct speech" narration.
E.g.: "Hello!" they said.

Instead, I write in the Spanish format
Which would be:
—Character's direct speech— narration.
E.g.: —Hello— they said.

I hope everyone can read it with no problems :)

Finally, but not less important: The cover art was created by the talented Eme! Here's the original post! Go show her some love!!

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

—I don’t know, Doc— the blonde woman said. —Are you sure this is normal?

—I am— the Head Physician briskly replied, her voice perfectly audible despite the physician’s mask covering her face. —Do you need anything else, Chief?

—No, that was all— she denied, and cordially nodded. —Thank you, Doctor Weaver.

—You can thank me by coming less to this institution, Adora.

—I’ll try— she chuckled.

With a wave, she finally made her way to the door and walked away into the night, adjusting her vest and keeping her jacket tied around her waist.

Adora was the Police Chief of Bright Moon, a prosperous kingdom she loved dearly. However, her life had recently taken a turn for the unexpected. Her work had never been easy, but since the recent wave of reports filling her office due to the mass hysteria regarding vampires, everything had become much worse.

And that night, on her way home, she had a violent encounter with *something*. She couldn’t see who or what it was, she just felt a scratch on her right arm, now patched up, and fired twice towards the dark alley into which the thing escaped. Normally, she would have bandaged herself, but this time she preferred to visit Mystacor’s medical institution as she suspected that was *not* normal…

Yet she had nothing to worry about, it seemed. Doctor Weaver, albeit ominous and scary, was a trustworthy physician. If she said it was nothing, then it was nothing… Right?

Upon arriving home, Adora opened the door and turned on the lights out of habit, closed behind her, and threw the keys inside a bowl to her left.

—Adora— a voice called her, finally making her really *see* the room.

—Ca-Catra!— she stammered, as she rushed to the couch where her wounded fiancée lay down, wearing only her white shirt and black pants from work. —What happened!? What’s all this blood on the floor!?

—It's mine, silly— she tried to joke, but her voice betrayed her. She was breathless and sleepy, yet still said —I'll be fine, I need to rest…

—No! You need medical attention!

—Dor… Listen to me— she begged, her voice a bit louder. —I need you to calm down.

—Bu-but you're…

—Hey, do you think I would let myself bleed out?— she asked, smirking. —I know I look like shit, but trust me, Adora…

—What happened?— she still asked, kneeling next to her.

—I was careless— Catra replied.

—No, no. *What* happened!? How did this happen!?

—Let me tell you in the morning…

—Love, please…— Adora pleaded, on the brink of tears.

—It's too much to explain now, and I'm tired.

—Dammit— she muttered, before kissing her forehead. —Alright, let me carry you to bed, yes?

—I'll stain it all with blood…

—I-I'll just… get you out of these clothes, wash you a bit, and take you to bed— Adora decided, picking her up.

—Fine… I can't exactly fight you now— she agreed, chuckling. —But… remember to close the curtains, alright?

—Okay?

Once in the bathroom, Adora discarded the torn, bloodied shirt, took off her pants with care, and threw them with the dirty clothes. She then washed Catra's body, noticing circular scars she could have sworn were *not* there before, and finally laid her on the bed before closing the curtains, as her fiancée requested, despite finding it quite strange.

Afterwards, she returned to the lounge to clean everything, picked up the discarded garments Catra had left on the floor, and once done washing everything, she sat in front of the table, pensive.

Adora had no idea, but she was about to fall into a world wholly unknown to her…

Even after an hour of pondering, her mind kept returning to Catra's scars.

Those looked healed enough to be months old, yet she was *so* sure they weren't there that morning.

And the fact that whatever wounds she had sustained now were nowhere to be found!?

It made no sense.

How could it be?

The only thing that kept popping up inside her head made her laugh bitterly.

It couldn't be! How would the only "reasonable" explanation be that she was a vampire!?

No, no.

Those reports were getting into her head.

She would know if that were the case…

Wouldn't she?

Castaspella

This one promised to be a long night for the physician. Her brother had just left for the day and only a handful of her coworkers remained, along with the feared Head Physician, of course.

There were just a few patients left in the institution, mostly people under observation, but she wasn't tasked with taking care of any of them. Hence, she busied herself cleaning and organizing supplies, on her homewear instead of her light-blue physician robes.

As she took a few things back to their respective places, she walked past a room where she saw Chief Adora, without her uniform jacket, waving at her cheerfully despite her bleeding arm. She was about to wave back when she noticed the one tending to her was someone in burgundy clothes.

It was the Head Physician.

It'd be better for her to continue with her work before the woman saw her…

So she immediately went on with her little chores while reflecting. It wasn't strange to have Bright Moon's Police Chief there, yet the fact that Doctor Weaver herself was tending to her wounds picked her curiosity, as she only handled the most difficult cases.

Surgeries, strange illnesses, things like that…

Her thoughts led her to recall the few times she had crossed her at the library or the apothecary, how they barely spoke except to discuss medicine-related topics.

For weeks now, she had been meaning to ask her brother about the things she found *so* weird about Doctor Weaver, but she never could because they both were always too busy with their patients…

—Oi, Castaspella!— someone suddenly exclaimed, startling her as she walked into a room. —Stars! What are you doing!?

—Oh, sorry, sorry— she quickly apologized. —I didn't mean to walk in here…

—I *know*! You need to pay more attention to reality— her coworker reacted.

—I already apologized…

—Don't. Just leave. My patient needs to rest.

—Yet you're the one yelling— she muttered, turning to leave immediately.

—Are you *serious*!? What's your problem!?— they cried out, following her out of the room.

—*My* problem!? I just made a mistake! You're the one being a jerk!

—No, no. You just think you can do whatever you please because Micah is your brother, isn't that true!?

—What!? No!

—Oh, really!? Because I think…— they were insisting, invading Castaspella's personal space, when something, a sound perhaps, made them stop mid-sentence. —What was that?— they asked, obviously scared, and starting to retreat to the room instinctively. It made Castaspella nervously look around and back at her coworker. —You heard that!? I-I'm out…

They soon disappeared behind the door, and she kept scanning her surroundings yet noticed nothing strange.

She was completely at a loss.

And yet…

Before she could so much as think about what they could mean, fear crept into her heart and she dropped the supplies to start running away.

She wouldn't dare look back, she refused to, yet she could still notice a flicker of glowing eyes in the corner of her sight.

So she just ran.

And ran.

Ran through dark corridors…

She didn't stop until she reached the corner, and pressed herself against the wall, readying a spell. Hearing her heart beating fast and feeling her chest tight, she made an effort to focus on her breathing.

Her palms were sweaty, her body shaking, yet she couldn't hesitate now.

Out of instinct, she raised her hands in time to protect herself from the figure that tried to jump on her.

Castaspella fell to the ground with a muffled scream yet managed to keep her shield up.

Terrified, she could only stare and, despite the faint light coming through the windows, she struggled to distinguish who was attacking her.

Other than a pair of fangs and violent claws occasionally illuminated by the moonlight, it was nothing but a dark figure hitting her shield.

Over and over again.

Whoever it was didn't show signs of stopping…

She had few options and little skill for offensive spells, but what else could she do?

Castaspella let that *beast-like* thing ram against her shield while taking a deep breath to order her thoughts.

She couldn't keep that up all night, she couldn't "hope" someone would appear to help, and if she wanted to attack that thing, she would have to drop the shield…

—I-I will probably re-regret this…— she uttered with a shaky voice, and closed her eyes. She knew she had little to no chance of beating that thing, but if she didn't try, she'd eventually exhaust herself and would be doomed regardless. So why not give it a shot? — Ugh… Stay… back!— she yelled, casting the new spell as quickly as she could.

There was a flash of light, whoever was attacking her was pushed back against the opposite wall, and Castaspella felt her hands burn.

Had she cast it correctly, the beast would be engulfed in flames.

But her hands were burning because she *failed*…

Or did she?

—Was that… supposed to be… fire?— a deep voice asked, breathless, before letting out something akin to a laugh.

—That voice…— Castaspella exhaled, standing up. It couldn't be, but there was no denying… She carefully approached the dark figure lying against the wall and knelt in front

of it, asking —Do-Doctor… Weaver?

But there was no reply.

Hoping she was knocked out, Castaspella reached out and moved away her hair, just enough to confirm her suspicions…

It *was* her.

But without her mask…

For once, she wasn't using it, so she could clearly see Shadow Weaver's scarred face, and a pair of fangs showing between her split lips.

Could she be a *vampire*?

Chapter End Notes

That's all for today!

See you tomorrow in Chapter 2!!

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Hello, hello! We're back with more!

I hope you're enjoying this Big Bang fic, and, in case you haven't yet, go check out the other works that are being posted this week! Every day until the 18th, new works will be popping up! Make sure you don't miss them and their fanarts!

You can find everything here, in the Spop Big Bang Tumblr Blog! There's also the Big Bang Twitter acc!

Adora

When morning arrived, Adora had managed to sleep a few hours. She was holding Catra protectively between her arms, and woke up as soon as she felt her stir.

—Catra?

—Hm… Hey, Dor…

—Oh, you're awake— she sighed. —I was so scared…

—I'm not that easy to kill, silly…

—Can you tell me what happened now?

—I just need a moment to wake up— Catra pleaded. —Then we can… talk— she promised, interrupted by a yawn.

—A-alright. Let me prepare you some breakfast…

Adora carefully unwrapped her arms from around her, stood up, and threw a long gray shirt on. As soon as she left the room, she could barely hear as Catra let out a pained sigh and groaned against the pillow.

She couldn't even imagine what her fiancée had to tell her…

Her mind kept coming up with all kinds of scenarios of how their conversation could play out, but she knew well that it wouldn't go as imagined. Forcing herself to stop fantasizing, she rushed to put together a good breakfast and promptly returned to the bedroom with a full tray.

—Adora… I-I'm not sure how to explain what happened last night— Catra began.

—Don't worry, take your time. We'll just eat in the meantime, yes?

—You're being too patient with me— she mumbled, sitting up on the bed.

—Why wouldn't I be?

—Your arm— she replied, pointing at the bandage wrapped between Adora's shoulder and elbow. Apparently resigned, she sighed as she revealed —I did that…

—What? No! Don't be silly, that wasn't you…

—I'm not joking— Catra assured her. She laid back against the wall and let out a longer sigh. —I don't know where to begin…

—I'll regret asking this, but… I saw you have two scars on your side… And I'm sure they weren't there yesterday morning— Adora decided to say, sitting next to her with a mug of coffee. —Can you begin by telling me what those are?

—You mean to tell me you don't recognize *bullet scars*?— her fiancée asked back, with a sad smirk. —That was *you*.

—I don't follow— she replied, frowning, after gulping a long sip of her coffee.

—Adora, I need you to trust me— Catra stated, turning to fully look at her. After a moment of hesitation, she began —The four slashes on your arm…

—How do you know there are four!?

—I'm telling you! It *was* me. And the two bullet scars on my side… that was you.

Unable to believe what she was hearing, she looked down into her mug, mind reeling.

It would explain why she didn't find any new fresh wounds on her…

Yet she still couldn't accept it.

—That makes no sense… The-they look months old!

—Adora— Catra called, reaching for her mug to put it back on the tray so she could take her hands instead. —I'm so sorry… I don't know how to say it in a way that won't be shocking to you, but… I'm a… a vampire— she eventually managed to say.

—You're joking…

—No.

—You must be! You can't be a vampire— Adora insisted, earning a look of consternation from Catra.

—No, no. It's true!

—You're just playing with me because you know I'm flooded with vampire attack reports…

—No, no. Wa-wait. You are!?

—I told you yesterday morning!

—No, Adora. It's not the same as the exaggerated reports you receive. I *really* mean it— she insisted. —I… Ugh… It's recent, alright? Ki-kind of… I would have told you sooner, but some really powerful people don't want you to know about the Horde— Catra finally explained.

—Really powerful people!? Like whom?— she laughed, still unable to believe it.

—Uh, like the Queen? Like *my boss*!?

—Wait, Queen Angella!? A-and Judge Hordak? Why would he…

—He's a Vulture, Adora. He leads the Horde, which is a whole society of vampires— she further explained. —I need you to trust me, please. Keep the secret.

—Okay, okay. Let's say that's all true…

—It is.

—Why would you have attacked me last night!?

—I don't know what happened. I can't… explain it— Catra sighed, looking down and letting go of Adora's hands. —All I know is that I was returning here, then *something* blinded me, and I heard the shots… I saw you wounded and realized I had attacked you— she recounted. —I didn't mean to make a mess of the lounge, but even when I heal super quickly, it wasn't fast enough. I lost a lot of blood, and *what wouldn't I give* for some of it right now…

—Okay, miss Vampire… Where do you normally get blood from if that's the case?

—Again, my boss. Hordak has a lot of blood slaves; we're not allowed to attack people, under any circumstances, because it would expose us— she explained. —Oh, and a "blood slave" is just someone who offers their blood in exchange for some powers, alright? Not a literal slave…

—I'm sorry, I don't think I get it, my Love— Adora admitted, with a sad smile. —I just got attacked last night by someone with some *sharp knives* or whatever… Doctor Weaver assured me it was a completely normal wound!

—What!? She… said that?— Catra asked, frowning. —I don't trust that woman… and neither should you.

—Why?

—There's something… about her that you don't know. I will explain it later. And if she even said those slashes are normal, yeah, no… more reasons to suspect her— she insisted.

—Alright, alright… Let's just…— Adora began, but interrupted herself to shake her head briefly. —I think I'll take the day off today…

—With that wound, you should.

—That's a great excuse, yeah— she agreed, her tone casual but her expression awkward.

—Hey, Love, listen to me… I would never lie to you— Catra promised. —I just kept this from you because they had told me it was for your own good… So, whatever you wanna know now, just ask me, alright?

—I have a lot of questions then… But, well, you probably need that blood first, right, Miss Vampire?

Castaspella

Shadow Weaver woke up with a confused look. She appeared lost and clearly didn't recognize where she was, but her instincts seemed to quickly kick in because it only took her a second to find the bowl filled with blood on the nightstand to her left.

She gulped it down as if it were soup, didn't let a single drop fall on her clothes, then rested back on the bed with her eyes closed, never noticing Castaspella's watchful gaze was on her.

Or so she thought.

—Was that yours?— Shadow Weaver suddenly asked, eyes still shut.

—Yes, I thought you might need it— she immediately replied, slightly startled. —And I thought you hadn't seen me— she admitted.

—I don't understand how you could do this— the vampire condescendingly uttered.

—I'm a physician!— Castaspella scoffed, offended. —It's not much different from extracting blood for a transfusion. I *literally* work here with you!— she insisted. But then she recalled she wasn't using her physician robes and added —I-I'm just not… dressed like it.

—We're at Mystacor?— Doctor Weaver asked, ignoring everything else and finally looking around in realization.

—Yes, I couldn't move you too far…

—Anyways… I didn't- I wasn't talking about the blood— she said with an annoyed tone. —*Why* would you help me? After what I did, how could you help me?

—So you remember you attacked me?

—Yes… And about that…— Shadow Weaver began. —Whoever you are, you need to be more careful walking around.

—"Whoever"!? A-are you serious!? We spoke last week, at the greenhouse, because neither of us could find that *one* ingredient for the health potion at the apothecary!— Castaspella reminded her, indignant once again. —We even discussed for *hours* whether healing spells or healing potions are most efficient.

—Ah… Micah's sister…— she mocked her.

—I can't believe I just… Ugh! Last night, I didn't even *believe* the stories about "vampires". I had to wrap my head around that and *accept* the fact I don't know a lot of things, just to *help* you! Why? I don't know! But I did! I even gave you *my* blood! And you don't fucking know my *name*!?— she blurted out, reproachingly.

—Are you done?

Castaspella was breathing heavily, angry beyond compare, and yet Shadow Weaver had the gall to mock her even more.

If the woman- the *vampire* was thankful or not, she would never know.

—Oh, yeah. I'm *so* done here— she let out. —Good luck.

—Wait.

—No!

She knew she'd regret it, but Castaspella still left the room, slamming the door shut behind her. Stalking down the corridors, she didn't stop until she had reached the gardens.

What was she doing!? And why!?

If Micah ever learnt what she had done…

No, no. She was definitely not telling him.

He'd lose it if he knew his master is a vampire…

—Any more drama and I'd recommend you a change of career— Shadow Weaver's voice said from behind, startling her.

—How on Etheria did you arrive here already!?

—You have no idea what I can do, do you?— she asked, smirking. —You certainly don't know the first thing about vampires or you would have asked how I'm standing here under the sun, instead…

—I don't care. I don't- I don't want to know anything other than *why* you attacked me last night— Castaspella managed to say.

—I meant it when I said you need to be more careful walking around…— she began, and raised a hand to keep her from interrupting. —Something happened last night, I can't explain it *yet*, but it made me go blind, and you *happened* to be the nearest source of blood around…

—I-I don't understand. What do you mean?

—Something or someone must be messing with our vampire senses. After all, I wasn't the only one affected, either— she went on. —Chief Adora came with a severe wound; I told her it was normal, that it was made with some sort of sharp weapon… but I lied— she admitted. —None of us is supposed to attack her, yet that was a scratch from a vampire— she sentenced.

—Why would you lie to her?

—Because she's not supposed to know about us. Or about the hunters— Shadow Weaver explained. —The Police Department is part of the Alliance, you know that, right?

—So are we, what's up with that?

—The Alliance, the real Alliance, is a society of vampire hunters.

—What!? But… if that's true, how is Adora the Police Chief yet doesn't know?

—Because she's only supposed to protect people, mortals, from *other* mortals.

—So the cover for the Alliance is not *just* a cover…

—Precisely.

—Alright, I get it. I think— Castaspella sighed. —What you mean is… whoever attacked Chief Adora last night was affected by the same thing that made you attack me?

—Exactly. And I plan on finding out what it is as soon as possible— she replied, seething and looking to her left.

It was, in all honesty, difficult for her to comprehend.

Everything the vampire had explained sounded so much like literal mental gymnastics… Especially the bit about Adora being part of the Alliance but oblivious of the real Alliance.

And then, if Mystacor is *also* part of the Alliance, how come she works there and didn't know!?

Another cover that isn't just a cover?

This was too frustrating to think about, and she wanted nothing more than to demand she made it make sense.

Instead, she went with a more general question that was confusing her just as much.

—Why are you telling me all of this?

Shadow Weaver must have noticed her posture, arms folded in a protective gesture, establishing a physical barrier between them, and realized she was afraid.

Or perhaps she could smell fear?

Whatever the reason, she took a step back as she replied —I'm returning the favour.

—Helping you or the blood?

—Both.

—That's not nearly enough.

—What else would you want?— Doctor Weaver inquired with a scowl.

—You mentioned this thing of… standing under the sun. Meaning vampires can't… normally do that?

—No, we can't.

—Then how?

—A powerful spell of my invention, of course— she proudly stated. —Is that enough?

—One last question: your mask…

—What about it?

—You wear it *all* the time. Is it to cover your fangs?— she tentatively asked.

—No. My species has fangs, I don't need to hide them— Shadow Weaver explained. —But if you're so interested, I prefer using the mask at all times for various reasons; hiding my scars among them…

—What's so bad about a few scars?

—You can't seriously look at my face and think I shouldn't hide it…

—Um… Why not?

—Never mind…— she sighed. —You're too naïve…

—What!?— Castaspella scoffed.

But Shadow Weaver ignored her and walked away.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Welcome once more!!
I hope you're enjoying the Spop 4th anniversary Big Bang!!

This will be the last chapter I post this week. Subsequent chapters will be posted weekly every Wednesday, until all 12 chapters are posted :D

~~Sorry for the cliffhangers~~

Ahem, hopefully this chapter comes with a great reveal that I made sure not to spoil in the tags, and from here on the story shall move on from introductions to *action*

I don't know what else to say here, so, without further ado, please enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Chief Adora was still nervous.

She *understood* Catra could handle herself perfectly fine, as she had been doing for about a year now, but she couldn't help worrying regardless.

Hence, when her fiancée decided to go to “work”, Adora drowned her in questions out of concern she never thought she'd ask.

How would she go under the *sun*?

What if she came across a hunter?

And what if her boss already knew what had happened the previous night and demanded some sort of proof that Adora was still oblivious to her vampire nature!?

But this wasn't Catra's first time dealing with such a situation…

Within an hour, she was back home, looking refreshed.

—So… are you feeling better, Love?

—Much! I got the day off too and Hordak has no idea anything happened last night— she replied, stretching a bit and taking off the top garment before throwing herself on the large couch. —I told you that you had nothing to fear…— she reminded her, eyeing Adora in such

a way it reminded the Chief that she hadn't even changed into proper clothes and still wore that gray, short-sleeved shirt from earlier.

Catra probably guessed that she sat in front of the door until just now.

—Does that mean you're going to explain stuff?

—I promised I would. And I will— she assured her, serious. —I don't wanna keep anything from you anymore. But *promise me* you will behave as if you still knew *nothing*.

—Yeah! O-of course! I promise.

—Then relax and come sit with me— Catra smiled, inviting her with a gesture as she moved her legs away to make some space for her. Adora sat there, offered her fiancée to rest her feet on her lap, and nodded at her to begin. —What do you wanna know first?

—How do you… move around all day, under the sun, without being suspicious?

—Ah, that's a bit tricky— she admitted. —It's "simple" when I explain it, but in practice, it's a skill I had to develop— she explained. As Adora silently nodded, she disclosed —Remember how we used to joke about these clothes we use at the court being "too much"? Especially the full-body robes? Well, it makes a lot of sense once you learn the court is a cover for the Horde.

—You mean…

—Almost everyone is a vampire, or a blood slave, so our clothes are meant to keep all our skin covered— she further explained. Showing her hands, she added —See? We even use these white gloves so we can cover *everything*.

—But, your faces…

—*That's* why I say it's tricky in practice. We can't let the sun touch us, but we can't be too obvious about it.

—You said it was a skill you had to develop… How long did it take?

—Hah! Months!— Catra laughed. —Gotta thank the speedy healing.

—Right— Adora nodded, pensive. —I have a lot of questions, but… can you tell me why you refused to… um, drink *my* blood this morning?

—Are you *nuts*!? I'd never forgive myself if I somehow hurt you in the process!— she immediately exclaimed, sitting up to hold Adora's hands between hers. —I- Listen, I know what you're thinking, but no, I didn't reject you. I just… can't stand the idea of accidentally drinking too much or, I don't know, biting too hard…

—Okay, okay. Calm down— her fiancée told her, smiling softly. —I felt a bit rejected, yeah, but I see your point— she assured Catra. Her expression then changed as she asked —But do you mean you wouldn't mind hurting one of those blood slaves you spoke about?

—No! Well… I mean…— Catra hesitated, suddenly sheepish. —I haven't really hurt any of them… yet?

—Wha-what does that mean?

—Look, they *know* the risks, and they still offer their blood in exchange for powers— she clarified. —We're not saints, we're not doing them a favour, but we aren't the ruthless beasts the Alliance makes us out to be, okay?

—I don't think I get it…

—You're too lawful good, Love— Catra sighed, laughing slightly.

—Since when is that a bad thing?

—It's not bad, but you have a view of the world that goes from one absolute to the other— she explained. —We are not good, but we're not straight-up bad, either… We just mind our own business.

—Okay? But then… what about the reports I get? If vampires are real, then those reports I thought were just people being paranoid or hysterical were actually true!

—Listen, Dor, as they are quite exaggerated, I'd love to say we have no relation, but…

—But?

Catra looked down at her hands and took a deep breath.

—It may be too difficult to understand— she tried to argue.

—Try me.

—Okay. Let's just say… our only feud is with the Alliance's hunters. So, if any mortal other than them gets hurt, that's not *just* our fault— she said. —Again, we're no saints, but we're not trying to target oblivious mortals either. The hunters just won't leave us in peace! They consider us heartless monsters, think the blood slaves are "suffering" and "brainwashed", but I swear, it's *not* like that.

—Alright, alright— Adora accepted. —It's a matter of communication then! Why don't I talk with Glimmer? Her mom is head of the Alliance, right? You could reach an agreement…

—Woh, woh, woh. Stop right there— Catra interrupted. —Agreement? You must be joking— she scoffed. —If you tell Sparkles *anything* related to the Horde, you're done for!— she warned her.

—Why!?

—First of all, because you're *not* supposed to know, remember? If they ever learn that you know, they will freak out! They'll probably force you to become a hunter, and they *know* how to play with your morals, Adora. You'll hate me!— Catra sentenced.

—I would *never*— she immediately countered, cupping her face to calm her down. —It'd be *just* Glimmer…

—Listen, you *can't*. I won't tell you to stay away from the Alliance as a whole, of course, but you need to be careful about what you tell the Princess.

—But she's your friend too!

—It doesn't… matter— Catra sighed, looking defeated. —Even if she sided with us, it's dangerous to let her know.

—Why?

—Because her father is a *hunter*!

—Ki-King Micah is a… vampire hunter!?

—Yes— she nodded, looking down again. —Several times I've… had to boycott a few traps Hordak set for him— she admitted. —I've risked my neck enough for Sparkles already! Don't make things more difficult and keep her *out* of this.

—I… get it now— Adora muttered, looking away. —What else should I know?

—I don't know, um…— Catra began, hesitant, until her eyes landed on her bandaged arm. —Oh, I know. Yeah. You have to stay away from Mystacor's health institution.

—Because Micah works there?

—That's his cover, yes. But that's not why I say it— she denied. Placing her hand on Adora's arm and caressing it tenderly, she said —I need you to stay away from Doctor Weaver. Remember what I told you this morning?

—I know the woman is creepy, but she's reliable, Catra. She didn't even recognize the slashes had been done by a vampire— she argued.

—Yeah, again, that only makes her *more* suspicious and *less* trustworthy— Catra insisted.

—You said it before, but why? She probably doesn't know about vampires!

—She most definitely does…

Her sardonic laughter made Adora realize she was missing something.

—Hold on. Is this about keeping me in the dark!? Is Doctor Weaver… a vampire too!?

—What!? No!— Catra reacted, indignant. —Adora… Shadow Weaver is Micah's Master.

—Yes? We knew that.

—Not just in the medical field— she clarified. —She's a *hunter* too.

Castaspella

The physician was unable to get Doctor Weaver out of her head.

It was so annoying!

She couldn't stop thinking about this secret world she had just learnt about, and the fact that their Head Physician was part of it and *no one* knew.

How did this whole thing work?

Alright, about the sun, she said something about a spell of hers.

About her fangs, they pass as her species' feature.

But what about drinking blood?

Did she attack people?

Did she take advantage of unconscious patients, maybe?

Perhaps she simply drank from blood donations, just enough that no one would notice any was missing…

In any case, it's not like she knew how much blood a vampire needed.

She just had so many questions!

And she didn't care how risky it was to know…

Invaded by curiosity, she began following the woman around and got the feeling she was purposely staying away from her. Whenever Castaspella walked into a room where Shadow Weaver was, the woman would immediately leave; once or twice it could be a coincidence, but *every time*!?

It was so frustrating…

She kept following Doctor Weaver around all day, many times trying to start a conversation, but she couldn't get a word out of her.

Yet she didn't give up.

Her shift finished at the same time as Shadow Weaver's by mere chance, and she was able to follow her out of the island. With cloaking spells on her, she went after the woman until she reached Bright Moon's library.

At the entrance of that majestic place, she met Micah, who seemed to be waiting for her with some odd black coat on, and both walked inside.

Now the physician was definitely curious.

She *had* to follow them into the library…

But that would probably be the most stupid decision she could make.

It always impressed Castaspella just how big and old that library was. Enough to get lost between unreadable, dusty tomes.

But Shadow Weaver and Micah didn't seem to be looking for books. Instead, they went to the deepest part of the library, where a tall, winged woman in a lilac dress received them.

Queen Angella.

As head of the Alliance, she was in charge of the forbidden section; the library was practically the headquarters of the Alliance after all… Castaspella never understood why the organization even existed, or rather, why it had such headquarters if it was supposed to be a simple Princess association for political decisions.

But now that she learnt there was a *secret* Alliance within the one she knew, it slowly started to make sense. Especially the part of the "forbidden section" which, as she could overhear, was actually filled with supplies for the hunters.

Oh yeah, it's all coming together for the physician.

Castaspella stayed inside for a *very* long time, waiting for her brother and Shadow Weaver to return from the forbidden section, and couldn't notice night had already fallen.

Besides, she was so focused on reviewing everything she knew about the woman and her own brother, that it didn't hit her at first…

So the forbidden section wasn't filled with cursed books or forbidden sorcery tomes, as she thought, but rather… weapons? Stuff for hunters?

Which would mean Micah is a hunter.

That would explain *a lot* of things about him: his night outings, his frequent visits to the library, which Castaspella first attributed to his wife working there, and the many injuries and scars he had…

He never wanted to speak about them, after all.

Alright then, he was here and had entered that section because he was a hunter.

But, what about Shadow Weaver?

Micah obviously didn't know she was a vampire; this confirmed it.

Especially since he's her apprentice at the medical facility, and all.

However… why was she reuniting with him here and allowed into the forbidden section!?

Unless…

—She's a hunter too!?— Castaspella gasped, immediately covering her mouth.

She didn't hesitate to put on a cloaking spell again as she heard Angella stand up, dragging the chair.

Then, her heels against the floor.

Closer.

Closer each second.

Step by step, the click of her heels got louder and louder.

Just as she was about to reach the bookshelf that covered the physician, they heard the sound of the entrance to the forbidden section opening.

Angella halted, and Castaspella held her breath, hoping the Queen would return to her desk now.

And she did.

She waited until they began speaking to let out a sigh, and once again paid attention.

—…because the magical items have restrictions, instructions, and require a load of documentation to be filled— Angella was saying.

—Which *I* have filled— Doctor Weaver stated. —You haven't, meaning you *cannot* use it, Micah.

—But it's just holy water! How does that count as a magical item!? I-it didn't when I was training!

—That's because twenty-five years ago it wasn't, my Love— the Queen explained with a gentle tone.

—A-alright. Then why can I use weapons imbued with holy water, but not carry a bottle of it!?

—That's a loophole— Shadow Weaver pointed out. —Every time it's been brought up, the conclusion was the same: some weapons are useless without it.

—Exactly! Like smoke bombs and blinding grenades!— he argued. —Or the pocket knives I carry; if I can't dip them in holy water first, they are useless too!— he added, indignant.

—They are silver knives, Micah. It burns them and slows down their healing— Angella reminded him.

—But- Ugh… fine. Then I'll start filling those documents as soon as I'm back.

—You mean as soon as you finish the specialized course— Doctor Weaver corrected him.

—The *what*!?

—Alright, you two. Stop losing time now— the Queen interrupted. —Night isn't eternal and we caught word of a large vampire nest towards the east.

Well, they both were *definitely* hunters.

Even Shadow Weaver.

A vampire… yet also a high-ranking hunter, it seemed!

Micah couldn't possibly know.

Right?

Yet another question was more important for Castaspella: why had *he* never spoken to her about vampires and hunters!?

Chapter End Notes

Did I just pull an Emperor's New Groove reference?
Yes, yes I did



Ahem! But jokes aside, I hope you enjoyed the chapter, that the reveal wasn't that obvious <("^_^)

See you next week!! Please keep enjoying the rest of the Big Bang posting week!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

^_^ Welcome back!
I hope you're enjoying the works of the SPOP 4th Anniversary Big Bang so far!

It is now time for yet another chapter and, while short, I hope you enjoy it!

There will be new revelations, a bit of development in certain dynamics, *and a bit of blood*

Anyways! Without more introductions, please, let's get started!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

A few days passed, and Chief Adora struggled to hide her anxiety. Fortunately, it was mostly believed she was just overwhelmed by the *increasing* amount of reports they were getting.

In reality, however, she was overly concerned about Catra's safety, about her *own* safety, and afraid of the truth being discovered…

And it didn't help, at all, that Princess Glimmer had been visiting her almost every day lately, always with a different sparkly dress in pink or purple tones.

—We should have dinner together again, some time— she proposed.

—You mean at the palace?— Adora asked, fidgeting with the left sleeve of her uniform. When Glimmer nodded, she explained —I don't know… I don't think it's appropriate for us to go.

—What!? But we've had dinner there before!

—More than a year ago— Adora pointed out, immediately realizing that must have been *before* Catra was turned.

—Exactly! It's been so long!

—Why don't we have dinner at our place instead? Just an informal dinner.

—Well, that's better than nothing— Glimmer accepted. —Oh, but Mom misses you!

—I'll try to visit the Queen as soon as I'm free…

—Please do.

—I could visit her at the library, right?

—Yeah. She's always at the back doing paperwork on her desk.

—Alright, I'll… go one of these days— Adora promised with a smile.

—Other than that, how have you two been!? Any date for the wedding already?

—Not yet— she lamented, shyly looking away.

—Aw… why!?— Glimmer inquired, looking disappointed.

—Both of us have been very busy, so we rarely have time to talk about it, much less plan it, you know?

—Bummer…— she lamented. —Hey! What about *I plan it*, and you tell me if you like it or not? You could point out things to change, and I'll do it all for you! Oh! I can get my aunt to help me too!— she excitedly proposed.

—What!? No! I-I really appreciate the offer, but you haven't even planned *your* wedding!— Adora reminded her.

—Because Mom insists on doing it herself… But also that it's "too soon", so she'll start when she considers things are "calm and peaceful enough"— Glimmer explained. —I don't even know what she's talking about! What isn't peaceful about this town, huh!?

—Hey, Sparkles!— Catra called, apparently back from work, and being more friendly than Adora expected after all she had told her. —What's that about the town being peaceful? You better be praising Adora for keeping it that way— she added, jokingly.

—Oh, of course it's thanks to her! But I was talking about Mom not wanting to let me and Bow marry until things are "more peaceful", which makes no sense!

—Well, the Queen is *probably* talking about the whole kingdom, not just this town, you know?— Catra pointed out.

—Oh, please. As if there were any issues in other towns or other kingdoms…— Glimmer dismissively replied.

—You're joking, right?

—What do you mean?

—Remember how I work for Judge Hordak?

—Yeah?

Glimmer's expression was both confused and fearful, which was telling enough of how oblivious she was. So Catra's resigned sigh was no wonder; Adora knew she was trying to be patient with her.

—The court handles issues from *everywhere*— she began. —We have cases from Salineas and Plumeria that could end very badly if we don't solve them. But, that's not all. If other kingdoms start having internal wars, or between each other, your mother will be forced to take sides— she pointed out. —So, I have to suppose the Queen is currently keeping an eye on those affairs and would rather not be distracted by a wedding— she went on. —And before you say that you can organize it, I'm sure your mother doesn't want anything to interrupt your happy day either, Sparkles.

—Yeah! That's right!— Adora agreed. —Just, be patient, alright?

—Fine…— Glimmer gave in, folding her arms. —Well, but I still want to have dinner with you two, please.

—As long as it's not at the palace, sure!— Catra agreed.

—Yeah, I said she and Bow can come home.

—Sure! Just tell us when so we can prepare— she smiled.

—Of course! I'll see when Bow has time— the Princess happily told them. —He's been so busy every night with his new job…

—New job? Didn't he work at the academy with his dads?

—Yeah! But he was offered a free course to learn a profession and graduated about two weeks ago!— she proudly explained.

—Oh…— Catra let out, hiding her fear.

She and Adora exchanged a worried glance, guessing what that could mean.

It was as if she could read what Catra was thinking just by looking at her eyes alone. When she made a little gesture with her head, like a warning, Adora hesitantly nodded, trying to control her breathing so she wouldn't reveal her anxiety.

—Can you two stop talking with your eyes!?— Glimmer suddenly interrupted, stomping her right foot on the ground. —You *always* do that! What can't I know!?

—Come on, Sparkles. It's nothing— Catra tried to dismiss it. —If anything, you're the one who's not telling us things!

—Ri-right! If we hadn't asked, you wouldn't have told us about Bow's new job! By-by the way, what *is* that profession he learnt?

—Hunting!— she cheerfully said. It froze them both, and Adora could feel Catra's tail wrapping around her leg under the desk, probably more scared now that it was certain. For a

moment, Adora thought that, maybe, Glimmer knew about the real Alliance. However, the princess promptly added —Apparently, there's a hunting party that braves the Whispering Woods, catches beasts, and gets paid for it…

—Re-really?— Adora stammered. —I never heard of that.

—Yeah! Dad sometimes participates too when he's not at Mystacor's health institution— she added, fully confirming their suspicions. —But I'm sure Bow will have a free night one of these days! So we'll see you soon!— she told them, happily bidding them farewell.

Once she was out of the office, they looked at each other, worried and sorrowful.

Their lifetime friend, Bow, had become a vampire hunter too.

Castaspella

The physician never stopped following Doctor Weaver, but now would also spy on her brother.

For days, she practically became their shadow, and all the information she could collect was then carefully arranged in her apartment.

Alone with a cup of alcohol, she looked at her notes and deductions, resting back on a chair, almost naked. She was waiting for nightfall, specifically for the time at which her brother always went to the library, so she could follow him again.

Each night, she had to choose whether to stalk him or Shadow Weaver… but there wasn't much more she could learn about the vampire. Whenever she wasn't on a hunting mission, she'd go to some dark alley behind a tall building near her place, pay someone for some blood, and return before sunrise.

That was all.

Her brother, on the other hand, was more complicated to unravel. And if that wasn't enough, as of late, Castaspella had been seeing another familiar face among the hunters: Bow, her niece's fiancé.

From what she had heard, Glimmer didn't know about him or her dad being vampire hunters, and probably had no idea about her mother's involvement either.

Well, it was time to get more intel on Micah…

She left the cup on the desk, put on a long dark-blue dress, and promptly left.

Upon arriving at the library, cloaked by a spell as usual, she sneaked in before the door was closed, and quietly approached the back.

Shadow Weaver wasn't there; she had to be feeding that night then…

However, Micah and Bow were both speaking with Angella, so she had to forget about the vampire and pay attention.

—It will be a simple mission, alright? A good test for you— Micah told Bow.

—Bu-but I'm not going alone, right?

—No, of course— Angella promptly answered. —Right?

—Yes, don't worry. You can choose two of your fellows to go with you. But it will be *you* leading, alright?

—But none of the other apprentices are ready— Bow countered. —If you put me in charge and something happens to them…— he went on, but trailed off. —No, no. I can't accept that. If they will be my responsibility, then I refuse to take them with me.

There was a moment of silence only broken by some rustling.

—Alright, that's… actually very sensible of you— Angella had to accept.

—Who do we have on duty today that can be reliable enough?— Micah asked.

—The- Um… the Butcher brothers…— she hesitantly answered.

—Why are they called that?

—They are very… bloody, usually dismember vampires— the King explained. —But if you order them not to, they won't. They are quite obedient.

Castaspella heard someone take a deep breath, presumably Bow.

—I'll take them— he accepted. —Where are we going?

—This is the alley— Micah said, after moving some papers, which Castaspella supposed were maps. —It's dark and secluded, and we got intel that a vampire has been making deals there, paying for blood.

The physician immediately covered her mouth, muffling a gasp, and risked taking a peek in the hopes of seeing the map.

But it was hardly necessary.

It *had* to be Doctor Weaver's spot.

Just how many "dark alleys" were there? How many vampires could be dealing for blood at a place like that?

It was *too much of a coincidence*.

Castaspella had to run if she wanted to warn Shadow Weaver in time. But she couldn't leave until someone opened the door…

While Bow went into the forbidden section to get the Butcher brothers, she retreated to the entrance of the library, hoping someone would soon walk in.

But no one did.

Only when Bow and the Butcher brothers left, could she sneak out.

She began running at full speed, wishing she recalled the spell for swiftness, but she was too anxious for that.

She *knew* the hunters would arrive first in their vehicle…

Just as she thought, by the time she reached the alley, there was blood *everywhere*.

It was too dark to know who was who; only a pair of glowing eyes were visible, moving far too fast to follow.

However, she could clearly distinguish Bow trying to escape, standing on the edge of the wall at the back of the alley, his silhouette visible under the moonlight. He had shot up an arrow with a rope and was trying to pull down a metallic stairwell a few meters above him, to no avail.

Castaspella didn't hesitate to use a spell to make it fall for him, and he managed to reach it right before a set of glistening claws could touch him.

A second later and his leg would have been shredded.

Once he was gone, probably back to the library in the vehicle, there was utter silence.

But only for a moment, until a dull sound startled the physician.

Someone had fallen, likely Shadow Weaver; seeing her claws reach for Bow had made it obvious she was still alive.

But for how long?

—Do-Doctor Weaver?— she stammered, casting a light spell, which she quickly regretted.
—What- How- What happened here!?

Everything was covered in blood. The floor, the walls, the dumpsters…

—Why… are you… here?— the vampire asked, with a strained voice.

—I…— she began, but the vision of the Butcher brothers' bodies cut open, each against opposite walls and sitting on a pool of their own blood, almost made her throw up. She had to

force herself to stop looking at their terrified faces to focus on Shadow Weaver instead. —I tried to- I couldn't arrive in time— she managed to say.

—You knew… they…

—Yes. I was- I've been spying on Micah…

—You're a *fool*.

Castaspella finally reached Doctor Weaver and kneeled in front of her, assessing her wounds.

—You're not healing— she noticed.

—Silver…

—I see— she sighed. —Well, *this fool* will now save your sorry ass— she stated.

It would be morning soon enough and Shadow Weaver was in no condition to cast her "powerful spell". She had to take her away before sunrise.

Fortunately for the physician, the vampire was too weak to oppose any resistance and allowed her to help her up.

—What… ever.

At some point after reaching Castaspella's apartment, the closest place to go, Shadow Weaver fell unconscious. Her wounds still wouldn't heal, so the physician decided to examine her more closely, and realized there were shards of silver stuck in her skin.

That vampire was too lucky…

Chapter End Notes

:D

I know, I know. That was maybe brutal.
But, hey! Bow is fine!

In any case, I guess you can imagine who's gonna have to deal with this in the morning/next chapter <("^_^)

Like I said in the initial notes, dynamics will change from now on.
And yet, there are still many more things to be revealed, and quite a lot will change too!
After all, the first third of the fic is already done!

But I'm rambling.
See you next week! And don't hesitate to leave your thoughts if you want!! ^_^

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Welcome once more!!
I hope you're enjoying my little fic ^_^

So, new chapter, this one pretty bloody and graphic at the beginning, gotta say. *But*, I'm pretty proud of that scene so (UvU)

A note: I investigated different kinds of cuts and lacerations to properly describe the differences here, so for that I can say I *know* what I'm talking about. *However*, I also mention the silver shards thing again, and what the hunters do to leave them, but like… in that case I am making shit up. I absolutely don't know if it works like that <("^_^) Be nice, please

In any case!
I hope you will like the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Early in the morning, Chief Adora had to run without having breakfast. She almost forgot to put on her uniform and left her Glock firearm at home, so she only had her backup weapon, a fairly old aluminium revolver, when she arrived at the scene.

—What on Etheria happened here?— she asked, completely shocked at the amount of blood staining the ground and walls.

She was suddenly missing her Glock more than usual…

—Chief— one of her subordinates called. As she approached, he explained —Last night, someone reported a ruckus back here, but no one came to investigate because…

—Because?

—They mentioned vampires again— he sighed. —Anyways, this doesn't look like someone we could have stopped— he commented. —Ah, and we recovered their identifications. It seems they are brothers, surname "Butcher". Ever heard of them?

—No— Adora replied, looking between the pictures and the terrified faces of the corpses. —But I don't want to hear any of that ever again.

—Any of what?

—That we couldn't have stopped whoever did this. It's our job- out *duty* to try.

—Right, Chief. Yes, Chief— he nervously nodded. —What should I do then?

—Take those to the station and start looking for any information we may have on these two — she ordered.

—Right away, Chief.

Careful, she approached the bodies; while already used to gruesome scenes, she couldn't help feeling afraid.

What if…

No, no. Of course not.

She would just… ask her once back at home. Most likely, she'd have some useful information.

But for now, Adora had to handle this investigation as any other and look for a suspect *without* letting the vampire allegations hinder her work.

—These cuts…— she noticed, immediately remembering the ones on her arm. —Damn it— she sighed, now convinced it was *definitely* related to vampires.

—Chief?— someone called behind her.

—Ah, Detective Trouble— she greeted them.

—Please, it's *Double* Trouble— they corrected her, tipping their bowler hat.

—We're on duty— she pointed out. —Now tell me what you've got.

—Fine…— they dramatically gave up. —Well, this is pretty simple— they began, opening their coat to get a cigarette from an internal pocket. Moving it around as they rolled their eyes, they began —If we ignore all the vampire nonsense people have been talking about…

—Yes, we are ignoring it— Chief Adora assured them, offering Double Trouble a lighter.

—Much appreciated— they thanked her. —So… It would seem like some psychotic maniac attacked these men— they pointed out.

—That much is obvious, and I hope that's not the language you will use in your report.

—Of course not! But you're no fun, Darling. Calm down a bit, will you?

—Trouble…

—Right. Here's what you *don't* know: these men were attacked with sharp objects, but not just any: there are traces of silver on the singular gashes on their necks, while the four parallel cuts on their torsos have none.

—Meaning?

—Meaning we either have two killers, or these men were armed too and got attacked with their own weapons— they explained.

—Alright, I don't think I get it— Adora admitted.

—Let me show you— they proposed, approaching to kneel next to one of the bodies. —See this cut on the neck of your victim?

—Yes.

—It's clean with straight edges. A sharp blade does that. But we're talking about a silver blade in this case because, if you look at it under the sun, you can see shards glistening. It's not only a silver blade, it's one that has recently been sharpened— Double Trouble explained. —However, these four are lacerations, with small tags of skin where the surface was irregularly torn…— they went on. —That was *definitely* not a blade. I'd even guess these were made by something… like a hook.

—With a hook?

—No, no. *Like* a hook, or like claws, if you may, because it's something that had a strong grip, enough to tear the skin like this.

—I see…

—That makes it quite difficult to beat the vampire allegations after all, I believe— Double Trouble said with a smirk. Right after, she could have sworn they sniffed her before saying —Unless you believe some cat did this?

—No! No… Of course not— Adora quickly denied, inevitably thinking about Catra again. —It could be… you know, a set of four, uh, hooked blades? Like-like a karambit. But four…

—Used as artificial claws?— they reflected. —Yes, absolutely. I don't know who would be able to make such a gadget, but it's a good explanation. Well thought, Chief.

—Alright. That's all, Detective Trouble. I expect your report as soon as possible.

—Right…— they sighed, exhaling some smoke. —I'll try to have it for tonight so you can read it in the morning.

As Adora returned home that night, she promptly took off her jacket and unbuttoned her white shirt.

She felt destroyed…

—Catra?— she called.

—In here!— her fiancée replied. —Give me a second.

—Of course— Adora agreed, sitting at the table.

Once out of the bathroom, apparently having taken a shower as she was wearing just a bathrobe, Catra sat at the table next to her. She placed a hand on top of Adora's while wrapping her tail around her leg under the table.

—Bad day?

—Worse than bad…

—How so?— she asked, concerned.

Adora used her free hand to get a copy of the crime scene's pictures and showed them to Catra.

—Do you know who they are? Or who could have done that?

—I…— she hesitated, but finally gave them a careful look. —These… faces— she muttered. —Holy shit! The Butcher brothers!

—You know their names!?— Adora asked, now anxious.

—They are *very* famous hunters. The-they are known for slaughtering vampires!

—What!?

—Whoever did this… Yeah, a vampire, I mean… must have been self-defense.

—What about those cuts in their necks? The detective noticed silver shards— Adora commented.

—Their own weapons against them?

—So those *were* theirs?

—Yeah. They purposely sharpen them before each hunt in such a way they leave silver shards on us if they cut us— Catra explained. —That keeps us from healing and can only be removed surgically.

—Well, damn… I'm screwed— Adora lamented.

—I can't believe those two were killed. Good riddance…

—So this was a vampire… using those guys' weapons?

—Probably— she agreed. —It's very rare though, because it burns us, so none of us would be able to hold them for long— Catra explained.

—What about… Well, I've had to do this a few times: I was stabbed and shouldn't remove the blade, but I did regardless to immediately stab my enemy before they could move away. Only needed to hold it for a few seconds— Chief Adora explained. As her fiancée hummed in agreement, she realized —But then… *Where* are the silver blades?

—If I had to guess… I'd say the hunters recovered them already.

—Then I have absolutely no way to solve the case— she growled. —I can't catch the culprit if it's a vampire, and even if I did, or-or if your society of vampires- the-the Horde did, it would be dismissed as self-defense, no?— she asked. Catra nodded and she added —On the other hand, that would mean accusing the hunters. Even if I could, even if I had a logical way to trace the silver blades back to them, as I'm not supposed to know about them, I wouldn't be able to explain any of my deductions!

—Dor…

—I have no case!

—Adora! Calm down— her fiancée gently said.

—I'm sorry…

—Don't be. Let's just have dinner, and I'll take these pictures to Judge Hordak tomorrow— she suggested, picking up the photos. —Maybe we can do something, make up an excuse to take the case off your hands, and it won't be your problem anymore.

—And if he asks how you got them?— Adora pointed out.

—He knows I'm your partner. I just have to say I stole them from your office.

—You better not have done that before.

—I swear, I haven't— Catra laughed, leaning forward and pulling her closer.

Once their foreheads rested against each other, they both took a deep breath together and sighed in relief.

Castaspella

Before Shadow Weaver woke up, Castaspella had made sure to close the curtains, left her a bowl of fresh blood, and then went to cook some breakfast.

She couldn't hear when the vampire woke up, only realized as much when she felt someone walk into the small kitchen.

—Damn it!— she exclaimed, almost burning herself. —My Stars!

—What a scaredy-cat— Shadow Weaver mocked her. —I suppose you expect some gratitude for saving me once more, but… I would rather you *stop* doing that— she told her, squinting.

—Why!?— Castaspella asked, turning around to face her.

—Because you're still behaving like a fool— she replied. —I bled out last night. You have no idea how much blood I require, much less how much *more* I would need this time, yet you didn't fasten me to the bed to make sure I wouldn't attack you— she pointed out. —And, of course, simply approaching me last night, so carelessly… that was so stupid of you. If I didn't have enough self-control, I would have drained you right there and then— she warned her.

—Insult me all you want, but if it weren't for me, you wouldn't have survived— Castaspella rebuked.

Shadow Weaver sighed and Castaspella noticed her eyeing the long dark-blue dress she had used the previous night, which hung from a chair; she had forgotten it was there.

As she had yet to wash it, a few blood-stains were visible despite the colour… A testimony to the massacre she had witnessed.

—Even in my state, I could have escaped to the shadows until I healed— the vampire argued, looking back at her without commenting on the dress.

—Wouldn't have happened— the physician confidently told her.

—What do you mean?

—Come with me, I'll show you something— Castaspella told her, leaving the kitchen and returning to the room. —Here. This was on the edges of your wounds— she explained, giving her a little round Petri dish filled with thin shards of silver.

—Did you… get those out of me?

—Yes.

—*How*?

—It's far easier than an open-heart operation, you know?— Castaspella explained, mildly offended and folding her arms.

—Well, look at that… You're more capable than I thought— Shadow Weaver commented, interested, shaking the little container to see the tiny shards better.

—You can't keep praising me while insulting me…

—Can't I?— the vampire asked, returning the Petri dish.

Castaspella growled angrily and turned around to put it inside a drawer. Once she looked back at Shadow Weaver, she was startled by her proximity.

—Fuck! What are you *doing*?— she asked, confused and leaning back on her desk, as she couldn't backtrack.

—I’m just trying to figure you out…— the vampire said. —You're not what I expected, or how I reckoned.

—What does that mean?

—I’m not stupid. I know you've been following me— she severely said. —And yes, I have been avoiding you. For your own good, which you don’t seem to understand. *But* I’m now considering letting you come as close as you dare— she admitted, with a tone that seemed challenging to the physician.

—It’s the least you could do after I gave you my blood *twice*— she rebuked, pretending to be offended.

—I suppose— she sighed, finally backing away. —Now, I’m interested in your little investigation— Shadow Weaver recognized, looking around the apartment. —I suppose you have many questions.

—Sure, but I’d like to have breakfast first— Castaspella dismissively said, walking past her and into the kitchen.

She could see from the corner of her eye that the vampire’s expression was notoriously shocked, and had to hold back a laugh.

After a moment, she heard Shadow Weaver follow her into the kitchen to ask —Any chance I can get some of that?

—Didn’t you already have your fill?— she asked back, with a neutral tone.

—Funny… We also eat food, you know?

—And why exactly should I give you *my* food too?

—While quite amusing, I *know* you’re not making me watch as you eat. After all…— she began, speaking with a condescending tone. —I can see you have made more than enough for you alone.

—Ugh— Castaspella huffed, slumping over.

—You already planned on giving me some, didn’t you?

—Yeah…— she had to admit. —But you woke up earlier than expected.

That day, the Head Physician sent a notice to Mystacor’s health institution, explaining she had a mild sickness and needed to rest for the day. Castaspella herself delivered it, and it was Micah who received it.

—She’s sick, you say?

—Apparently. I happened to, uh, cross her on the way here. She looked dizzy, I could tell she wasn't feeling well, and suggested she return and rest— she explained, barely hiding her nervousness. —Although she didn't like it one bit that *I* told her so, she really seemed about to pass out and gave in. A-and asked me to give you that— she concluded, gesturing at the note.

—I see.

—Actually, Brother, I was hoping I could take the day off too?— she finally dared to ask. —I've been having issues sleeping lately…

—Are you alright, Sis?

—Sure! It's just… my insomnia again— she assured him.

—I see. Yeah, better rest before you accidentally fall asleep here— he joked.

—Thank you.

—Oh, and…

—Yes?

—Be careful in the streets. Don't go out alone during the night— he warned her, expression somber.

—I… heard the news. Some people were gossiping about it— she lied.

—Then you know…

—Of course. I'll be careful— she promised.

When the physician returned home, she found the vampire sitting on the chair in front of her desk and let out an amused sigh while shaking her head.

—I see you managed to get the day off too— Shadow Weaver commented, smirking. She probably had been skimming the notes and pictures Castaspella had put together, and was, perhaps, waiting for her to return until then, sitting on that chair, leaning back against the desk. —Did you have any problems? The last we need is someone noticing the "coincidences"…

—Well, I delivered the note to my brother, and he seemed convinced when I told him I hadn't been sleeping well because my insomnia was back.

—If he knew about your little expeditions…

—I've been getting enough sleep regardless— she argued.

—No, you have not— Doctor Weaver refuted. —Unless you have some infection or chronic illness that may be causing systemic inflammation, I'd venture that the high levels of white cells I noticed in your blood, compared to the first time I tasted it, are caused by sleep deprivation.

—You- How- What!?

—I'm a physician. I notice things in the blood I drink that other vampires don't— she casually explained.

—A-alright. Perhaps I haven't slept enough…

—Well, stop playing detective and be more mindful of your health. You *are* a physician, after all— she condescendingly said.

—Oh, so you want to talk about *health*!? Then let's talk about how you've been getting blood from drug-addicts!

—That's none of your business.

—No, no. Because, according to you, I should know better because I'm a physician, but then *you* should know better because you're a vampire *and* a physician!

—And what else would you suggest?— Shadow Weaver asked, rolling her eyes.

—Just… Why don't you…

—What?

Looking away shyly, Castaspella finally dared offer —I'll give you mine. Just… I'll extract it and give you as much as you need.

—Why?

—Be-because… Ugh… I don't want to-to deal with the aftermath of you being discovered due to that-that poisoned blood affecting you!

The vampire couldn't help but chuckle before saying —I see… I'm surprised you're so careful.

—Of course I am!

—Alright, then. Let's begin— Doctor Weaver decided. —First, tell me what exactly you've figured out about me.

—In short, you're a vampire *and* a vampire hunter— she began. —I see you keep the first of those things secret from everyone, as no vampire seems to know you're one of them, while no hunter even suspects you could be a vampire— she went on. —However, what I cannot, for the life of mine, figure out is who you're betraying.

—I don’t plan on betraying anyone— Shadow Weaver replied with a neutral tone.

—Where do your loyalties lie?

—*Nowhere*. I’m loyal to myself and only myself.

—I supposed as much, but… I don’t… get it— Castaspella sighed. —As a vampire, you’ve been *hunting* your own, right?

—Yes?

—Yet, as a hunter, last night you *killed* two of your own too…

—Exactly.

—Make that make sense!

—Easy: I only think about *myself* and *my* well-being. And before you ask, yes, this little deal with you is *obviously* something I consider necessary for my well-being— she explained.

Castaspella raised her brows for a second, surprised, yet couldn’t help blushing slightly and looking away.

—Suddenly I’m… useful to you?

—That’s a way of putting it.

—How would you put it?

—You help me, I help you: that’s how it works— Doctor Weaver summarized it. —It’s as beneficial for you as it is for me. I need you to help me, so I need you *alive*.

—So…

—You can rest assured you’ll have nothing to fear, either from hunters or vampires. Convenient for you since you've decided to stick your nose into this dangerous world…

The physician remained silent for a moment, looking at the ground and deep in thought.

She didn’t know what to make of that comment…

—Alright. I don’t see why it wouldn’t benefit me, indeed— she had to admit.

By nightfall, Castaspella had relayed all the information she gathered and could fill in the gaps with answers from Shadow Weaver.

Their unlikely partnership had begun quite well for them both.

Around midnight, the vampire left the apartment and returned to her place, leaving her to sleep… or to try, at the very least.

Chapter End Notes

Like with what I clarified at the beginning, I also made my research on how insomnia can affect the blood, and found that a rise in white cells can be caused by the three things mentioned here. So, in this case too, I kinda know what I'm talking about.
Can I be wrong? Yes. I didn't find that much info like for the wounds thing, but… I trust it's not that wrong either

Again, please be nice if you find something u know about that I obviously bullshitted. I welcome the criticism as long as it's respectful :)

Hope to see you again next week!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

Hello, hello! Welcome back!

I certainly hope you're enjoying the fic, and are ready for one of my fav chapters XD

We have some BFS focus in Adora's part of the chapter, and quite a reveal from SW in Castaspella's part!

So, without much more prelude, let's get started!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

By the end of the week, Glimmer finally confirmed Bow would have time to visit them and have dinner. So that weekend, on her way back home, Chief Adora bought all the ingredients she wanted to use for the meal.

When she arrived, Catra was already preparing the table to cook there, and helped her with the bags of groceries. They assisted each other with every step of the recipe and finally left everything to simmer in a large pot.

Once able to sit back and relax until the food was ready, they went to the large sofa on the lounge. While Adora sat on the left side, Catra instead lay across it and rested her head on Adora's lap; she kept slightly brushing the tips of her fiancée's ears, making them twitch.

Giggling, they both spent a few minutes until it was time to turn off the flame. And just as Catra was on her way back to the couch, they heard a knock on the door.

—Girls! It's us!— Glimmer's voice exclaimed.

—I'll open— she chuckled.

Adora stood up from the couch, only then noticed she was still wearing her uniform, and facepalmed right as they walked in.

She cleared her throat and said —I-I should change. But come in! I'll be ready soon!

—Stars, Adora! Just go, you can greet us later— Glimmer laughed, shooing her.

While rushing to put on something more decent, she could still hear them chatting loudly in the lounge.

—I'm sorry, we completely forgot she only took off her jacket to cook— Catra apologized.

—It's fine. We can wait— Bow assured her.

—And, let's see… That's a nice outfit!— the Princess commented. —So much for informal…

—Look who's talking… You and your sparkly dresses? Bow in a suit?

Ah, yes, Catra had dressed before cooking and they both had been very careful not to stain her clothes. She was wearing black pants up to her waist with a row of golden buttons on each side, along with a red top with a *very* deep neckline and white lace adorning it as well as her wrist cuffs. All under a long black coat that combined with her pants.

So now she had to put some effort into it.

Or she could go with that red dress Catra liked so much?

By the time Adora finally returned from the room, her friends and her fiancée were just sitting at the table, speaking in a lower tone.

—Oh, shit— Catra blurted out.

—Oh…—Glimmer let out, extending the word.

—You want to give me a heart attack!?

—Sorry, Love— Adora laughed. —I couldn't decide what to wear— she apologetically explained.

—It's perfect, Dor.

—Aw, you two are so *cute*!— Bow exclaimed.

—I'm not cute!— Catra rebuked, baring her teeth.

—He meant your relationship— Glimmer clarified, holding back a laugh.

—Why don't we serve the food now? I'm frankly starving— Adora admitted.

—You sit down, I'll do it— her fiancée offered.

Catra promptly handled everything and returned to the table with two servings of fish stew for Bow and Glimmer, and then another two for Adora and herself.

—Oh, wow. I haven't had fish stew in a long time!— Glimmer commented. —Since, like, when my family and I visited Salineas.

—Hold up. Mere-folk eat fish?

—Why wouldn't they, Dor?

—Not all of them, of course, but some do, just like some marine fauna does— Bow pointed out.

—I feel so stupid now— Adora shyly admitted.

—Don't worry— the Princess laughed. —I said the same the first time.

With very light conversation, the night went on, the food disappeared, and Adora decided to prepare some coffee. She poured everyone a cup, and they returned to their conversations on how each one was handling their work.

Catra had told them only known things about the court and excused herself from saying more because she "can't disclose any information about ongoing cases".

Then Bow spoke very vaguely about hunting, how he could now use his archery skills, and how the last time he almost got killed by something a bit more savage than expected.

It was concerning, but he assured them they were being more careful now.

And finally, it was time for Adora.

Glimmer seemed too excited about it and immediately jumped to ask —Can you tell us about that mysterious murder case you're working on!?

—I-I'm sorry?— she reacted, just as both Catra and Bow choked on their coffee.

—Oh, Stars! Guys, are you alright?— the Princess asked.

—Yeah, yeah. Just… don't you think it's… *not right* to discuss bloody murders while eating?

—That's why I didn't ask before— she excused herself.

—Even if I *could* talk about ongoing investigations, I actually have very little information— Adora explained.

—Yeah, that— Bow quickly agreed. —Bu-but why do you… Why are you asking, Love?

Catra gave her fiancée a quick look, like a warning, realizing that his nervousness meant he knew something.

—Ugh, because Mom has been crazy about it!— Glimmer replied.

—Really?

—Maybe you shouldn't know about this, Sparkles. Otherwise, your mother would have explained it to you.

—Of course not! She never tells me anything! She just locks herself up with Dad and they discuss stuff without telling me *anything*!— she complained. —That's why I didn't know about the conflicts and all you mentioned the other day!

—Listen, Glim— Bow began, serious. —Some things are… not for everyone to know, alright? And this is one of the things you're better off *not* knowing about— he said.

—Hey, do *you* know something you haven't told me!?

—I… No, no. I just… I think those are the, uh, guys from the hunting party that went missing this week— he nervously explained.

Adora knew that was a lie.

Unless he meant those were vampire hunters he worked with!?

She already knew they were hunters, but it completely slipped her mind that *Bow* could know them.

—Ah, yeah. So, from the hunting party that goes into the Whispering Woods?— she began, fishing for information. When he nodded, she further asked —But then, if they were supposed to be with you, guys, how come we found them in the city?

—No, well- I-I mean…— he stammered, probably looking for something feasible to tell her. —They never showed up a few nights ago, and we supposed they had abandoned us or something— he explained. —But they were very eager hunters, you know? So we then considered they actually went missing, that something had happened to them, and I was sent to, uh, fill a report at your-your station. But you weren't there and they- I was told you were investigating a murder.

—And who told you those were the hunters from your party?— Catra pressed on, following Adora's lead.

—We just supposed that until their names- I mean, their descriptions were leaked— he replied, fumbling with his words.

—We have a breach? I must investigate that— she let out.

—I heard people talking, and they said it was in some secluded alley?

—Oh, oh! I heard that too! Actually, Dad almost went insane cause it was near Auntie's place. Oh, *and*, people were saying it could be a drug deal that went wrong— Glimmer commented.

—What!? No!

The three of them gave Bow a curious look.

—And how do you know that?— Catra daringly asked.

—I- Well- I-I know those guys wouldn't do that— he managed to say.

—You never fully know people— Adora sighed, shaking her head and pretending disappointment.

It seemed to get to him because she noticed the sorrow on his face.

—Sorry, guys… Pe-perhaps we should leave— he uttered.

—What? But…

—You can stay if you want, Glim— he interrupted her. —But I think *I* should leave.

—Hey, Arrow Boy…

—Yeah?— he answered, looking back at Catra with clear shame.

—We can… just change subjects, you know?

—Thanks, but… I think I ruined the mood— he declined. —And it's getting pretty late already. I have to check in for work early tomorrow— he added.

—Aw, what!?— Glimmer asked, indignant.

—Yeah, I got the night free because I promised to help your dad with something early tomorrow.

—Bummer!

Adora and Catra couldn't help chuckling at Glimmer's expression, and it only made her mad, which Bow seemed to find pretty endearing…

Castaspella

By the time the weekend arrived, Castaspella was more than tired.

Not so much from the blood extractions, as she thought at first, but rather because it was *very* stressful having to lie so much.

Sneaking around without anyone noticing that she had been interacting more with Doctor Weaver, or that she now seemed less wary of her and more so of her own brother… It was exhausting.

Normally, Shadow Weaver was the one to go to Castaspella's apartment, as she insisted her cloaking spells were far superior to those of the young physician. However, after almost being caught by a "surprise" visit from Micah, they decided it would be better to change the location of their meetings.

—I'll let you in on a little secret of this institution— the Head Physician told her. —Not even your brother is aware of the *many* passages that lead to Mystacor's underground chambers.

—There are… secret passages and chambers?

—Indeed.

—How can it be that only *you* know about them?

—Let's just say the information died with the last director of the institution…

—That's… not ominous at all— Castaspella sarcastically replied. —You wouldn't happen to know anything else about it, right?

—Very funny. But I wouldn't say I do…

—Look, I *promise* I will keep the secret. I swear. So… can you at least tell me the truth?

—Why do you think I'm lying?

Castaspella had to look away to hide a faint blush.

—You have a tell… But I'll only reveal it if you tell me everything— she bargained.

Squinting, after a moment of hesitation she let out a resigned sigh and reluctantly accepted, ordering her —Fine, then follow me. Once we're safer, I'll tell you.

At that time in the afternoon, most physicians were busy with their assigned patients, and during weekends like this, Micah was already gone by noon, meaning they wouldn't be seen accessing the secret passage.

—It's… just a wall— Castaspella said with confusion.

—Follow my moves— Shadow Weaver ordered, guiding her through a weird spell that made the low reliefs of the mural glow brightly for a moment before a section of the wall moved away like a door. Gesturing at her to go first, she said —You could trust me a bit more…

The physician rolled her eyes as she walked in, muttering —Sure…

They traversed dark corridors, through which Doctor Weaver had to guide her so she wouldn't walk into a wall, until they reached a large area. Castaspella was confused when the vampire made her stop, but the reason soon became obvious as a faint light appeared and gradually increased until it illuminated the whole room.

—Much better— Shadow Weaver sighed.

—What is this place!?

—It used to be some… private lounge for the directors and their confidants.

—Impressive— Castaspella admitted, looking all around her.

There were beautiful couches all around, in purple tones with golden details. The room was round, which made the few bookshelves populating the place look quite awkward against the walls. And the vaulted ceiling seemed covered in beautiful light-blue and pink crystals which, combined with the magical light Shadow Weaver had cast, reflected gorgeous patterns on the ground.

—Breath-taking, isn't it?

Castaspella nodded absentmindedly despite feeling the vampire's sight on her.

After a moment, she finally looked back at her and asked —So this is a "safer" place?

—It is— Doctor Weaver sighed once more, apparently anticipating her next question.

—Meaning now you can tell me what happened with the last Director?

Grimacing, she muttered —Sure. Take a seat.

—A-alright— the physician accepted, sitting in front of a short table. Much to her surprise, Shadow Weaver sat right next to her, but kept her sight on the ground, slouching over, and supporting herself with her arms on her knees. —Is it a difficult subject?

—Not exactly— she denied, shaking her head. —But your reaction to it might be.

—And if I promise not to "react" or anything?

—You can't promise that— she assured her. —You're just like your brother in that sense. Too sensitive, too passionate. And too good for your *own* good.

—Whatever I might think of it, I won't… take it out on you, alright?— she promised once more, looking away. —I asked, I want to know about it, even if it's *not* pretty.

—Very well…— the vampire finally accepted, never looking back at Castaspella. —To begin with, his name was Norwyn. He was a hunter, introduced me to the Alliance, the real one, and trained me— she first explained. —However, the one who… *killed him*, was also *me*.

Castaspella barely held back a gasp and made a huge effort not to lean back, away from Shadow Weaver.

—Why?

She took a deep breath, closed her eyes a moment, and finally explained —I had recently been turned. And he found out. He called me a traitor, and with all due reason, I suppose. Then, he tried to kill me, despite all the help I had been providing the hunters.

—But, i-if you hadn't betrayed them, then why…

—He *never* listened to me— she interrupted. —Even when I tried to help, even when I offered solutions!— she went on, raising her voice, clearly angry. —Of course he would try to kill me!

—So you did it first— Castaspella reflected.

—Yes, but not before he could spray me with holy water— she clarified, letting out a sardonic laugh as she finally sat up and leant back on the couch. —That's why I have these scars…

The physician immediately opened her eyes widely, understanding everything, and had to ask —But then, how did no one ever know about that!?

—Remember the story of the Lunarium for magical recovery?

—Yes? It… burnt long ago and had to be rebuilt- Oh, shit…

—Indeed. *I* burnt it down to cover everything, and to pretend the wounds I sustained were from the fire— she explained, guessing Castaspella's thoughts almost exactly.

—Alright, but… We-we're physicians. How did no one notice the thermal injuries you sustained weren't from fire, which would be a hot local environment, but rather from hot *liquid*!? The-they don't look nearly the same!

—I'll stop you there, *nerd*— Shadow Weaver light-heartedly mocked her. —You could say I sustained both kinds of burns, but only the ones from holy water remained, as any second-degree burns would in a mortal— she explained. —When I was "rescued", I *did* have fire burns. I kept them hidden under gauze until enough time had passed, and pretended the scars left on me were from the accident. Everyone believed it because they had healed enough to look like mere second-degree burns…

—Except those patches around your eyes… That's third-degree; you even lost your eyebrows.

—Can you stop being so brainy for a minute?— Shadow Weaver let out, perhaps annoyed, perhaps impressed. —If you had been there when it happened, I would have been done for…

As she rolled her eyes, Castaspella folded her arms and sat straight, smugly saying —I'm taking that as an *actual* compliment.

—Ugh… You better keep your end of the deal and never say a word about this— she reminded the physician. —And now, what exactly is this "tell" you say I have?

Castaspella had to bite back a smirk; she had hoped the vampire would forget…

—It's quite silly… I don't think anyone else notices it— she first said, shyly looking away.

—You noticed. That's enough reason for me to know.

Shadow Weaver was serious about it; she *had* to tell her.

—Fine… It's just… Something you do with your eyes? Like, you look to the left when you make something up, and to the right when you're recalling…

—Damn it— the vampire muttered. —You're observant… How didn't you find out about us before?

Taking into account that Shadow Weaver is both a hunter and a vampire, Castaspella knew she meant both.

And, in truth, that was a good question…

—I don't know. I wonder the same— she admitted.

—And you didn't have your memory wiped, that much I know.

—Wha-what!?

—I am the one who handles that— she casually explained.

—That's not… I- Ugh…— she stammered, raising her hands a bit and making a gesture of utter annoyance. —That's *not* what I meant, and now it's going to keep me awake all night.

Shadow Weaver chuckled as she stood up, offering the physician her hand to help her stand too.

—Then we better distract you a bit— she said, once Castaspella was up. —Interested?

—Depends on your definition of "distraction".

—How does some dinner sound?

—Good— she admitted, looking away with a blush and feeling her stomach rumble. —But if someone sees us…

—Worry not. There's a backdoor here that leads to the market— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —As you've proved to be quite reliable, I'll get some food for us and keep us covered.

—Fi-fine— she nodded. —Do we go to my apartment?

—It's the closest to the market, so it's the best option.

—Lead the way then…

Chapter End Notes

That was all for today!

As you can see, things are ✨developing✨

Hehe, I hope you'll enjoy the chapters that remain! We're exactly halfway there! ~~And I haven't written the last few chapters yet~~ 💀

Ahem!
So! Thank you very much for reading! If u haven't, I encourage you to go check out the other Bug Bang fics! U can find them in the collection linked in this fic's information!

See ya next week!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

Welcome back!!

So, today's chapter may be a bit short, BUT it's *the turning point*! One of my fav chapters!!
You'll see why

So, without much more introduction, enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

A hectic week passed before Judge Hordak's order to take charge of the murder of the Butcher brothers was accepted by Queen Angella.

Just as Adora supposed, the Alliance had no "mundane" reasons to reject the request; without exposing the truth, they simply couldn't refuse to hand over such a severe case.

The Police Department never liked it when their cases were snatched from them but, this time, they all anxiously awaited the Queen's decision, hoping the court would take it off their hands.

—It still maddens me when *our* cases are taken over by the court without any explanation, but at least now I understand *why* they do that— Adora told Catra, sharing a drink with her, both in their nightgowns. —I suppose it's been for the best. We wouldn't have solved them anyways…

—Yeah. You always got so angry that I really wanted to tell you— her fiancée admitted.

—That's why you always told me not to take it personally?

—I knew you felt like they were doubting your abilities, Dor— she nodded.

—Exactly.

—And you have no idea how desperately Queen Angella tried to reject our request this time — she scoffed, smirking as she shook her head. —But, as she doesn't know that Judge Hordak is a Vulture, she couldn't really dispute this. Her arguments were so ridiculous!— she laughed.

—And how will you handle it?

—We'll have to find the vampire responsible, reach an agreement, then plant evidence to prove it was them but that it was all in self-defense— she explained. —The tricky part is how to explain the wounds on their torsos…

—Did you read the file we gave you?

—Nope, not my job.

—Well, I came up with an idea when our detective pointed out that those gashes were difficult to explain if the vampire theory was ignored, and included it in the report. It might help.

—Who's your detective?

—They go by "Double Trouble". They're extremely good, very observant, but also a bit over the top— Adora replied.

—Oh, shit…

—"Oh, shit"?

—That damned shape-shifter is quite the mercenary— Catra muttered. —They work for us too. They know about vampires and hunters. What did they tell you, exactly?

Surprised and quite confused, she recalled —They explained the difference between the wounds, proposed the theory that the brothers were armed too, with silver blades, and that the attacker must have had something like a hook or claws to make those four gashes… Then they pointed out that it was difficult to beat the vampire allegations and asked if, instead, I thought *a cat* did that. You know, because of the claws…

—That little…

—I panicked because the comment made me think of you, and that's why I suggested a completely plausible possibility: a gadget like a gauntlet with some sharp blades, karambit-style, like artificial claws.

—And that was smart. Thanks, Dor. But, I still can't believe they really said "cat"— Catra let out.

—Detective Trouble is like that. Just… does and says strange things sometimes— Adora assured her.

—Like what?

—Well, right before that comment, I could have sworn they sniffed me.

—Fuck!

Catra immediately stood up, stepped away, and seemed furious as she paced around the lounge.

—What happened, Love?

—A few days ago, we called Double Trouble to help with the investigation to find out who was the vampire the Butcher brothers were after— she explained. —And they kept speculating that it could have been me! They asked where I was, who I was with… a-and all in front of my boss!

—But you were with me since the afternoon!— Adora argued. —Ho-how is this related to Double Trouble sniffing me, though?

—They smelled my scent in you— Catra shyly explained. —They must think you're covering for me, which necessarily implies that you *know* about us! And if they so much as *suggest it*, then all eyes will be on you until it's confirmed or denied.

—But why? Our compromise isn't exactly a secret. Of course I'd have your scent!— her fiancée pointed out. She then stood up too, approached her, and placed her hands on Catra's arms, trying to comfort her as she gently inquired —Don't you think you're, perhaps, a bit paranoid? I'm sure they did it on purpose, just to get on your nerves and see how you react…

—They do that a lot, yeah…

—Then don't fall for it, Love.

Adora gave Catra a loving look as she cupped her cheeks and, seeing her sorrowful expression, leant forward to kiss her face. The vampire giggled as she kissed her freckles, and playfully gave her a push without really trying.

—Get off me!— she laughed.

—Nope.

Laughing together, they eventually reached their room and got ready to sleep…

Or so they intended, but there was a knock on the door, and Adora had to put her robes on again to open it.

—Good evening, Chief— an unknown individual said. She had no idea who this was, but her gut feeling told her this was *nothing good*. —Apologies for the late call, but I bring a message from Her Majesty, the Queen.

She hesitantly accepted the letter and answered —Am I expected to reply now, or…

—No. It's an invitation. You're only expected to attend— the messenger said.

It sounded… more like a threat than an actual invitation.

—I see. Thank you. Go-good night.

As Adora returned to the room, where Catra waited for her with a mix of confusion and suspicion, she quickly read the letter.

Her eyes opened more and more with each line.

—Dor… I don't like that expression…

—And you shouldn't— she eventually breathed out.

—What is it?

—This… I-it's not direct, but… it's pretty much an invitation to the *real* Alliance…

—What!?— Catra shrieked, pushing herself up.

—They want me… to join the hunters— Adora uttered, letting the piece of paper fall from her hands.

Castaspella

The following week was quite a nightmare for Castaspella.

The night Shadow Weaver invited her to have dinner together was fantastic; they talked about different subjects, shared some anecdotes, the physician learnt a few secrets, of both vampires and hunters, and a few tricks of magical medicine.

After Doctor Weaver left, she managed to sleep better than ever, and woke up refreshed, happy, even excited to see the Head Physician again. She arrived at Mystacor's health institution in the best mood, but it got ruined in seconds…

Between the previous night and that morning, the vampire's attitude had changed drastically.

Like the first few days after Castaspella discovered her real nature, Shadow Weaver was avoiding her. If it was completely necessary to speak to her, then she would say just the bare minimum and in the coldest tone she had ever heard.

In a way, it was even worse than before.

If the woman was just pretending, to "keep appearances", it was an exaggeration. But it soon became clear it was more than that because the vampire only went to see her to get her fill of blood and didn't answer when Castaspella asked her if there was something wrong.

For three agonizing days, the physician was drowning in anxiety, racking her brain to figure out what she could have done to upset Shadow Weaver.

Had she said or done something bad during their dinner?

Had she been disrespectful?

She didn't look irritated or anything when she left, so when could it have happened?

Or perhaps the vampire learnt something about Castaspella after leaving her apartment and instead of speaking with her decided to give her the cold shoulder?

Whatever it was, she couldn't figure it out…

And yet, the next day, Shadow Weaver wanted to see her at the secret chamber under Mystacor; as if nothing had happened, they were sneaking around once again.

The physician was extremely confused, but she hardly said anything because she thought the vampire would explain herself eventually… or at least apologize.

Yet the week ended and she never did.

Once again, after Micah's shift ended, the two of them met up like the previous week. This time, however, they were at the supply room; Shadow Weaver had dragged her there without a word, but notoriously indignant.

—Didn't I tell you *not* to follow your brother last night?— she questioned her, after taking off her mask.

Castaspella pulled her arm free from the vampire's grasp and asked back —What was I supposed to do after you told me what he planned to do!? I *had* to go! And good thing I did or he would have…

—Micah isn't that easy to kill; he didn't need your assistance— Doctor Weaver interrupted. —And he isn't stupid, either. He *noticed* he had magical help— she added. —Now I have to convince him it was his imagination so that he doesn't look too much into it, lest he discovers your involvement! How am I supposed to keep you safe if you don't follow simple indications!?

—How will you "keep me safe", you ask!?— Castaspella scoffed. —You know what!? *Fuck you*! I don't want your protection if you'll only play with me!

—What on Etheria are you talking about!?

—I am talking about the bullshit you pulled this week!

—*What*!?

—First, you invite me to dinner and act all friendly with me. Then, you behave coldly for three consecutive days before *finally* treating me better again!— she began. —The last two days, you acted as if nothing had happened, never apologized for being a jerk nor explained *why* you were like that!— she then reproached. —Do you have any idea how anxious I've been, thinking I did something wrong!?

—Aren't you exaggerating a bit?— Shadow Weaver asked, condescendingly towering over her.

—I am only telling you what you did!— she retorted, standing her ground and holding her sight. —Do you think I'm just some naïve mortal you can use as your personal blood bag and only treat me like a person when you're "in the mood" for it?

—*You* offered *me* your blood. I'm not *using* you— the vampire first pointed out. —And I believe you're taking it too personally. I was, in fact, not in the mood to interact with *anyone*, not just *you*.

—Then why didn't you have the decency to tell me that and apologize, at the very least!?— Castaspella questioned her, indignant, grabbing her by the collar and pulling her closer to her face. Feeling on the brink of tears yet refusing to cry, she angrily muttered —And now you say you want to *protect me*!?

Shadow Weaver hesitated to answer. She could see the vampire was genuinely surprised, seemingly struggling to understand.

And when she finally opened her mouth to speak, someone came through the door and they both looked that way.

—Oh, ex-excuse me!— the nurse apologized. They were the same one who accused Castaspella of doing whatever she wanted because her brother was Micah; they were absolutely *not remorseful*. They were only scared of how the Head Physician would react. —Sorry for interrupting…

—This is exactly what it looks like— Shadow Weaver smirked, surprising Castaspella's coworker.

Startled, the physician immediately let go of her and denied —What the- No, it is not!

Unfortunately…

With a grunt, she aimed for the door, yet the vampire tried to stop her, saying —We're not done here…

—Fuck you!— she yelled, without looking back, stalking past her very confused coworker.

—I… will return to my duties— the nurse awkwardly said, loud enough that she could hear them.

She couldn't care less…

They were *surely* going to use this against her. Yet she absolutely did *not* care.

Castaspella only walked down the corridor, aiming for the break room, where she hoped to find some solace.

She didn't know why she was reacting like that, or rather, didn't want to think about it; she just needed some silence to go over everything and make up her mind about that vampire.

Eventually, she arrived but, before she could open the door, a firm hand grabbed her shoulder and made her turn around.

—I do not care what you want to say— Castaspella immediately began, knowing it was her. Furious, yet opposing no resistance, she went on —I am not going to…

—Then *don't*— Shadow Weaver interrupted her, rolling her eyes. —Just shut up for a second, will you?

The physician was ready to talk back, yet a sudden kiss stopped her.

It tasted… different from what she expected.

Her eyes fluttered shut as she surrendered and kissed her back hungrily.

It was surprising for a moment, but she'd be lying to herself if she pretended she hadn't been waiting for this exact moment.

Castaspella was barely starting to sink into the passion of the unexpected kiss when a voice brutally forced them apart.

—What the *fuck* is going on here!?

Chapter End Notes

:D

What do you think!?

If it was a ride, it's cause I intended it to be lol

First part, building tension for the cliffhanger
Second part, introducing a sudden change only to cut it short even more suddenly
<("^_^)

Hehe, well, I hope you enjoyed it, and see you next week!!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

Welcome back, everyone!!

It's finally time to reveal what happened with the Queen's invitation for Adora, and with the little impromptu kiss Castaspella got XD

I certainly hope you enjoy this chapter ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

—I am *absolutely* not going— Adora sentenced.

—What? A-are you *nuts*!? What excuse do you have to reject a formal invitation from *the Queen*!?

—I don’t want to join them!

—But they don’t know that you know! They don’t even make it obvious in the letter, you only know what they plan on offering because I’ve told you everything!

—But…

—Listen, Dor. You *have* to go, hear her out, and unless she spells it out with all the letters, then be vague and tell her you’ll think about their offer— Catra instructed her. —If they don’t make it obvious, if there’s no mention of hunters or vampires, then you can be sure they aren’t ready to risk it yet, and most likely still consider you should remain out of our conflict overall. Alright?

—And if they make it evident? If they drop the façade and tell me everything?

—Then you can be honest. Whatever it entails— her fiancée nodded. —If the worst were to happen, I can get you protection…

—Then it better not happen— Adora sighed. —So… they want to see me in like… twenty minutes.

—Get ready. I’ll wait for you here— Catra encouraged her, smiling faintly.

Chief Adora arrived at the library close to midnight, wearing a semi-formal suit, and carrying her weapon just in case. She was welcomed by a nightwatchman and escorted to the back of the library, where Queen Angella expected her.

—Good evening…

—Oh, welcome, Chief Adora.

—I had promised Glimmer I would visit you soon, and I'm so sorry I couldn't come before. I always wanted to visit the Library!— she casually said, trying to hide her nervousness.

—Oh, well, I'm glad we could have this chance, then. And I *sincerely* apologize for the time, Adora.

—It's alright, your Majesty. I understand you have a busy schedule— she replied, as formally as possible.

—A bit, yes— the Queen nodded. —Well, I hoped my husband would be here for this, but he seems to be late, so I'll start— she decided, resigned. —Adora, you're the best Police Chief Bright Moon has had in a *very* long time. And I believe it's safe to presume this is because you deeply care for our people's well-being. Isn't that right?

—Absolutely— she nodded, serious. —I care for *every* individual living in our kingdom— she assured her, wording it in a way that made it inclusive of vampires.

She wasn't sure whether the Queen had caught it or not, but if she did, she didn't show it.

Instead, Angella just said —Then, if you had the chance to make a greater change, if you could… let's say, prevent crimes before they happen instead of solely dealing with the aftermath, wouldn't you take the chance?

—I- We-well, that… sounds a bit like this science-fiction novel I read…

—But I mean in reality, if it were possible, would you accept doing what's necessary to protect everyone?

—What would the threat be?

—Something more out-of-the-ordinary than your usual criminal, Chief— the Queen insisted.

—I don't think I understand what you mean, your Majesty— she lied, with her best innocent look.

—Right. I suppose I could be specific… Ah…— she contemplated, sighing. —I could *really* use Micah's help right now— she uttered.

—We can always wait, if so you prefer— Adora offered, hoping to get enough time to come up with a *good* excuse to refuse if they actually reveal everything.

—I wouldn't want to keep you this late, Chief…

—It's no trouble at all— she insisted.

—Then, please, just five more minutes— she requested, apologetically.

—And!?

—And the King arrived just in time— Adora explained, taking a sip of her coffee.

—So?

—He didn't let her tell me— she chuckled. —He said he had only considered the idea but that it wasn't yet their intention to "bother me" with such matters— she elaborated.

—Stars, Adora! Why didn't you tell me before!?

—You were asleep on the table when I arrived! I didn't want to wake you up.

—You should have, really— Catra insisted, still quite shocked as she bit her toast. Once she swallowed, she asked —Okay, so, what else did the King say?

—Not much, at least nothing related to the hunters or any references to vampires either. He just… I *think* I heard him mention something about his sister, though— Adora replied, pensive as she tried to remember. —I was leaving, but I heard something about how they now have to put some vigilance on his sister; that she's in danger…

—His sister is… Castaspella, a physician in Mystacor's medical facilities, right?

—Exactly. Glimmer's aunt.

—Of course, she's mentioned her sometimes. How could she be in danger?

—Well, he didn't say, just seemed a bit panicked. Actually, I think I could listen to what he was saying because he was too indignant to keep his voice down— she replied, thinking aloud. —I guess that's also why he arrived late. Something about his sister and his master, and… Oh!

—"Oh"?

—You said Doctor Weaver is a hunter, right!?— Adora asked, suddenly hit by an idea. Catra nodded, and she asked again —And she's Micah's *master*, right!?

—Yeah?

—Well, what if that's what he meant?

—I don't follow.

—The King mentioned his sister and his master, and that his sister, who is *not* a hunter, would need vigilance because she's *now* in danger.

—Aha?

—And he sounded indignant!— Adora went on, excited. —Don't you understand!? His sister and Doctor Weaver!

—Wait, you mean… they're *together*!? What!? Ugh, not that— Catra shivered. —But… I guess you're right, that would make him indignant and would mean that the sorceress is going to need vigilance; Hordak's strategy is always going for the heart, which usually means whoever the partner of the hunter is… But, wow… We *literally* had Shadow Weaver as *the heartless* hunter! It's insane!

—If that's the case… then even more reasons for me to reject the offer. If I… No, no. I don't even want to think about it— Adora sighed, shaking her head. —You're my fiancée, and if they were to put vigilance on you, they'd find out you're a vampire!

—Dor…

—I need to come up with some way to reject their offer!

—Dor! Please, calm down…

—Sorry, sorry… I'm calm.

—You're not, but it's enough… Listen to me: from what you said, it seems like the King doesn't want you to know yet. That is, doesn't want you to join the hunters or know of our existence, either.

—I understand, but what if he finally accepts!? What if they- What if they know about… *you-know-what*!? A-and what if today or tomorrow I'm called again!? I don't know what to say!

—Alright, alright— Catra sighed, placing her hands on Adora's shoulders as she tried to stand up from the bed. —Stay here, careful not to spill your coffee, and let's think about something, okay?

—Okay…

It took them a while to finish their breakfast while brainstorming but, by the time they were doing the dishes together, they already had some pretty solid strategy.

—So…— Catra began, drying her hands. —Let's go over it again. Suppose you get another invitation…

—And they low-key reveal the existence of the hunters' Alliance and the vampire Horde…

—Even if they *officially* reveal it all. What will you say?

—I- Fo-for starters, I cannot believe vampires are real— Adora began, serious. —But, if they were, I would simply renounce my job.

—Why?— Catra encouraged her to continue, nodding.

—Because I could never condone killing people under the *suspicion* of them potentially hurting "mortals"— she firmly replied.

—Perfect. And if they argue we're not people?

—I said last time that I care for every individual who lives in the kingdom. If vampires are real, then they are also individuals living here, and it should be part of my responsibilities to look after them too.

—Beautiful. And any reference to your secret?

—I don't acknowledge it. There's *no secret*.

—Precisely— Catra smiled. —You'll be fine, Love— she assured her, grabbing Adora's waist and pulling her closer. —We'll be fine…— she muttered, as they both rested their foreheads together.

Castaspella

The physician waited outside of Doctor Weaver's office while hearing the faint voices of her brother and the vampire arguing inside.

It was close to midnight and it was the weekend, so *why* was her brother there in the break room!? He should have been gone since noon!

It looked like he was sleeping, probably, from his messy hair, but he certainly was *very* awake when he caught her kissing the Head Physician.

She now felt like some… little kid.

It was exasperating.

If she weren't so correct, she wouldn't be "patiently waiting" for them to decide her fate.

Why should those two be the ones to decide, anyways!?

—Say whatever you want, Micah, but she's not a child. She's a woman and has the right to defend herself!— Shadow Weaver finally said, after what sounded like her slamming her hands on the desk.

—Don't you drag her into *our* discussion!

—She's *part* of the discussion! You cannot leave her out like this! It's disrespectful!— she insisted.

—*You* are talking about respect!?

—It should be telling enough— she replied with a snide tone.

—You know what!? Fine! Let her come in! I'm *dying* to know what exactly led to what I saw!

What led to what he saw!?

What on Etheria could she possibly say!?

She didn't even know why Doctor Weaver had kissed her!

It could have been a simple strategy to shut her up, for all she knew!

As for the discussion that *somehow* led to the kiss… Well, how to explain it without revealing the woman's vampire nature!?

She could say she was being a jerk but… He wasn't even supposed to know they had been spending so much time together!

The real problem is the *reason*…

Castaspella stared in shock as they opened the door, noise filling her head as she didn't know what to say or do.

—Come in— Shadow Weaver gently invited her, offering her hand.

Hesitantly, the physician took it and walked in, yet she didn't know what to do beyond that.

—So? Will you explain to me *what* happened just earlier?— Micah inquired, severe but calm.

—I…

—You're not in trouble, alright?— the vampire assured her, giving her a gentle look and squeezing her hand reassuringly, which caught her by surprise with how unusually nice she was behaving.

—I just need to know what happened— her brother insisted. —Why were you- How- *What* happened?

—I… Micah…— she wavered. Unable to hold his gaze, fearing he'd read her mind or something, she instead looked at Shadow Weaver, and their hands still joined. Trembling, she forced herself to let go and stammered —I don't know how to explain it…

—Just tell me what happened.

—But…

—I need to know if she's coercing you in any way— he clarified.

—*Micah*!— Shadow Weaver let out, offended.

—No, no! She's not!

—Then what led to… *that*?

—We were arguing…

—About?

—No-nothing…

—It was obviously *something*.

—Brother, please…

—Just tell me the truth, and I'll let you go back to your duties— he promised, as if that were a "good" thing.

—The truth? Or whatever *you* think the "truth" is!?— Shadow Weaver accused him.

—Stop!— Castaspella immediately exclaimed, hands in fists and eyes tightly closed. —I-I did everything *wrong*— she finally let out, afraid of what any other answer could cause. Afraid of making everything worse for the vampire. —I'm sorry…

With that, she turned and left the office.

She heard rushed steps behind her and only pressed on, trying to put as much distance as possible between her and the office.

Whoever was following seemed to have stopped at the door…

—Wait! Casta!— the Head Physician called. So it was her. —*Please*, stop!— she insisted, but Castaspella didn't; she had to be *desperate* to have used that word, but she was determined. With firm steps, she was eager to get away, making as little a scene as possible. —Castaspella! You did *nothing* wrong!— she called out once more, her voice sounding… imploring. There was also a hint of hesitation, like the vampire was struggling, a step away from breaking. Yet the physician refused to turn around, reply, or halt. Until… —Stop! Just-I-I… Ugh! Fuck! *I love you*!

She… *what*!?

Castaspella finally relented, slowly turned around, and saw the vampire frozen at the door. She was looking away with mortification, and the sight made her chest tighten.

She really said it… she, meant it, perhaps?

Doubt and all, it was enough for the physician to rush back, disregarding the looks of her colleagues attracted by the scandal, and ignoring her brother's shocked look behind Shadow Weaver.

She only cared about her vampire now…

Castaspella almost crashed into her, inertia making her trip slightly, and grabbed her by the collar again, pulling her closer as she asked —You're not messing with me, are you?

—I am not.

—You're not just… telling me what you *think* I want to hear…

—I am not…

—I swear, if you're playing me…

—Casta— Doctor Weaver interrupted. —I am honest— she sentenced. —For once— she then added, looking away with a faint blush.

—Why now?

—Because it would have been *never*, otherwise— she replied, still looking away, with sorrow this time. —You were right. I was… a jerk. I almost lost you because of my pride— she admitted.

Lost her?

If it wasn't just the heat of the moment…

Since when had she been… harboring such feelings?

The physician herself had no idea when her own feelings had developed, and she didn't want to think about it.

So how could *this woman*, of all people, admit and manifest the same feelings even before her?

Forcing herself out of her reflections, and somewhat relieved, she smirked as she told her —You better make it up to me, then.

Shadow Weaver finally looked back, smirking too, and seemed about to kiss her again, but she could probably feel Micah's glare digging holes into her back.

She gave the physician an apologetic look while gently making her release her collar, and turned to address him.

—While this is less than ideal, I hope it's enough to convince you I am not coercing your sister in any way— she condescendingly told him.

—I don't even want to know *how* this happened— he admitted. —But you and I will have another chat about this— he warned her. —And you, Sis… Do me a favour, and don't… *blindly* trust her— he then told her. —I won't… interfere with what you two feel, or whatever, but promise me you won't just trust her every word— he insisted.

—If I trusted her every word, we wouldn't be in this situation— Castaspella replied, a bit cocky.

Shadow Weaver let out a faint laugh and admitted —That much is true.

—It better be— he sighed, finally walking past them and away.

Castaspella was all giddy now and wanted nothing more than to kiss the vampire again.

However, she could feel the eyes behind her and absolutely did *not* dare to turn around.

—Do you think we can… go back into your office? I don't… want to…

—I imagine. Just come in— Doctor Weaver interrupted her. —And you all seem awfully free tonight— she told the curious physicians. —Perhaps I should get rid of the extra personnel…

She had to hold back a laugh hearing that, especially since she picked up a few yelps from her colleagues as they rushed back to their duties.

—Thank you.

—What for?

—Erm… Well… The help, the trust… being honest— Castaspella enumerated. —*How* can it be that you… love me?

—Anyone who can sit through hearing me speak all my bad deeds, without running away in fear, deserves my utmost respect, and my *love*… much as I loathe the feeling.

The physician then smiled, reached out her hand, and added —I was afraid, to be honest myself. But, I think I… can be brave enough to love you too.

Shadow Weaver held her hand between hers and pulled it up to her lips as she replied —Don't feel forced to.

—I am not. I swear.

—In that case…— she then sighed, taking a seat and inviting her to sit with her. —What you need to know now is that the hunters will monitor your movements, alright?

—Why?— Castaspella curiously asked, slightly confused.

—Micah will probably order as much because there's a common fear that vampires might target a hunter's partner to get some leverage…

—*Partner*?— the physician asked, with a smug tone. She then giggled and, before Doctor Weaver could answer, she changed the focus back to what they were discussing, asking instead —Why only the partner and not the family? I mean… With Micah being my brother, wasn't I already in danger?

Shadow Weaver smirked and scoffed in amusement before replying —And you'd be right, except for the fact that you were fairly unknown…

—What!?

—I know I'm quite the jerk, even to you, but I mean this literally. You always lie low, or you *did*; Micah made sure you'd remain under the radar taking advantage of that— she explained. —But now? This is quite the scandal…

—I hadn't… considered that— she admitted, looking away, pensive. —So… I reckon your promise to keep me safe is now… more of a public and justified matter among hunters, isn't it?

—Exactly. In any case, you're not supposed to know, so don't say a thing, and *pretend* you don't know.

—A-alright— she nodded. —But that may… complicate things for you— Castaspella then realized. —If someone finds out I'm giving you my blood…

—*If* that happens, we'll see what we do— Shadow Weaver interrupted her, standing up to approach her. —Don't you start panicking about things that haven't happened yet, or your insomnia will only get worse— she warned her.

—Of course…— the physician replied, looking down.

Gently tilting her chin up, Doctor Weaver made her look back at her to request —Just promise me you won't take any more unnecessary risks…

—I- A-alright— she nodded. —But the same goes for you, then. You're… always exposing yourself.

—I've done this for enough time.

Castaspella stood up too and insisted, with a serious frown, —But the situation is different now.

—You needn't worry about me— she whispered. —I have my methods and hardly struggled before. This is barely more challenging.

—I guess I'll have to trust you— the physician whispered back, leaning forward.

They met in a brief kiss before parting to handle their duties for the remainder of their shifts.

As morning arrived and their shifts ended, Castaspella returned to her apartment as Doctor Weaver told her, while she tried to negotiate the "vigilance" she'll have now.

After eating, taking a bath, and extracting a hundred milliliters of blood for the vampire, Castaspella was ready to finally go to sleep.

But frenetic knocking interrupted her right as she sat on the bed.

—Open the door!— Shadow Weaver's voice exclaimed.

—Yes, yes! Just give me a moment!— she replied, rolling her eyes and making an effort to stand again. As she opened, she asked —What happened? Uh, sure… come in…

The vampire seemed frenetic and practically shoved the physician aside to walk inside.

—Close the door— she ordered, while obscuring the apartment's only window. —This is serious— she insisted.

Just in case, she locked the door too, and hesitantly asked —Is this about the vigilance?

—No, no. I easily handled that. You have vigilance only when I'm not around— Doctor Weaver explained.

—Then what's the matter!?

—The Queen! The *damned* Queen!

—What did Angella do!?

—She almost, *almost* revealed everything to Chief Adora!— she replied, indignant, pacing around.

—What!?

—She called Adora to a meeting, but didn't directly tell her what she was proposing, so I reckon the Chief remains oblivious. Yet only because Micah arrived in time to stop her!

—Okay, okay. Calm down, why don't you sit?

—And after all the effort it took from me to convince the Alliance we had to keep Adora *out* of this!— she went on, ignoring Castaspella's offer.

—It's not that terrible either… *If* she accepted, which I doubt, she'd just be another hunter out there!

—You don't understand— Shadow Weaver denied. —Adora *cannot* join the hunters! It will be the end of *all* vampires!

—Why!?

—Be-because…— she hesitated, finally stopping her pacing. —She's… a descendant of Mara.

Chapter End Notes

I hope someone caught the reference to a certain book XD (aka, the one Adora meant lol)

Ahem, so…
The plot thickens and hopefully it'll only get better (>v<)

I'm so excited to post the final chapters!
I mean, I'm still writing ch 10, so it's good there's still another week before I have to post ch 9
But *gods*, I have to fight the urge to spoil everything haha

I'm trying not to ramble here, so I'll end the note.

See you next week!! I hope you enjoyed!!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

Well well, here we're again XD

I hope you're ready for more!! Wooh!

I'm glad to present yet another chapter ~~while also dreading next week since I've yet to finish ch 10~~

So, after this chapter, only 3 more remain, and next one is actually pretty important! I can't wait to share it while also begging time to pass slower so I can finish in time <("^_^)

Anyways! Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Fortunately for Adora, they did *not* call her that day.

As the hours went by, and no one showed up with a new invitation from the Queen or anything similar, she gradually relaxed.

That way, she could focus on a little matter she had been investigating lately: whatever had affected Catra that night to make her go blind…

As everyone in the station knew she had been hurt that evening, they didn't hesitate to help her investigate who had been around and look for anything suspicious. Their findings had been just some unidentified cloaked individuals that couldn't be recognized, and some strange contraption, seemingly burnt.

The results finally arrived that day; everything indicated the burnt marks were from a short-circuit and, as the components were all melted, it was irreparable. It seemed to have been able to emit some inaudible frequency, according to very technical forensics that Adora couldn't understand from the report.

However, that wasn't everything.

One of Adora's subordinates had submitted a second device, exactly like the burnt one, found crushed on the outskirts of Mystacor's floating medical institution.

—Really!? Up there on the island!?— she asked him.

—Yes, Chief. A nurse called us and I went to collect it— he explained. —I recalled the one we found where you were attacked, so I sent it to be examined too.

—Do we have the report already?

—It should be done soon. The components weren't that damaged, only the carcass, so the device could be reconstructed. It's being tested as we speak.

—And what about fingerprints?— Adora inquired.

—We… got the results just now; that's what I was about to give you— he admitted, before handing her the report. —It's… not really useful, to be completely honest.

—Let me see— she sighed, opening it. —Three sets of prints were found… We have… the nurse who reported the incident…— she began reading. —And- *What*? Doctor Weaver? And *King Micah*!?

—Not only that, Chief— her subordinate pointed out. —Look at where the fingerprints were…

—That's… odd— she uttered.

The King's were on the activation toggle. Which would necessarily mean *he* set it there and turned it on.

Why? Was he hunting a vampire there?

It would make sense *for her*, at least. Though there was nothing she could do with that information.

Nothing official.

On the other hand, Shadow Weaver's were on the dents.

She crushed the device.

Once again, *why*!?

Wouldn't she be using it to hunt too? Why destroy it?

Perhaps she could interrogate her about it, but *how*?

And Catra would hate it if she went to see the woman…

—What should we do, Chief?— he finally asked, after giving her a moment to reflect. —None of this makes any sense…

—Who else knows?

—No one outside the station and the forensics department. We told the nurse to keep silent about it to avoid panic among people— he assured her.

—Are we sure he didn't speak?

—Absolutely. In fact, that nurse seemed… *scared* to be found talking to us.

—Really?— Adora reacted, confused.

—Yes, Chief. And the times we tried to ask for a follow-up conversation, the nurse refused.

—I see— she sighed. —Well, we can't exactly interrogate the King about this, or Doctor Weaver either…

—Do we even know how the devices are connected to the attack you suffered?

—Have we gotten any reports of an attack on Mystacor that same night?

—None.

—We could look into that, but it may just be a coincidence, so don't worry. I'll take it from here— she assured him. —Just, make sure to notify me as soon as the report of the device's functionality is available.

—Of course, Chief— he agreed, before saluting.

She arrived home late that night with a copy of the reports she got, wanting to tell Catra about her findings, and hoping the information would help her and other vampires be safe from such strange devices.

—I'm home!— Adora exclaimed, after closing the door. —And I have a lot to tell you!

—So do I— her fiancée replied, walking out of the bathroom while drying her mane.

—Oh, something good?

—I don't know… Just… curious. You?

—I don't know if good, but certainly interesting, might as well be a breakthrough— Adora replied.

—Then, go ahead. You first— Catra decided, sitting at the table while tidying her bathrobe.

—Alright— she accepted, taking a seat next to her, jacket off, and putting down a folder in front of her. —Remember how you told me that the night you attacked me it was because *something* made you go blind?— she began. When her fiancée nodded, she went on —Well, we found something about it. Some sort of device, and…

—And?

—It wasn't very useful, to be honest. They could only identify it could make some inaudible sound— she explained, passing her the folder. —However, a second device, exactly like the

first one, was *also* found at Mystacor; it was less damaged and had fingerprints— she went on. —It was tested and, as expected, all it does is emit a sound at an inaudible frequency for us, mortals— she explained. —However, it made animals go feral and… I-I don't want to compare you to animals, but I am guessing your audition must be just as sharp so…

—Dor, I know— Catra interrupted her, letting out half a smile. —This is definitely hunter stuff, especially if King Micah's fingerprints are on it.

—Yeah, I guessed the same. But look at where Doctor Weaver's are.

—So she crushed it?

—So it appears.

—Why?

—That's what I wonder…

—Alright— Catra sighed. —I'll take this to Judge Hordak tomorrow…

—I imagined you'd want to— Adora admitted with a smile. —So, what did you want to tell me?

—Oh, right. It's insane— she began, looking baffled. —Judge Hordak wants me to ensure Castaspella's safety.

—You… mean… *that* Castaspella? Glimmer's aunt? Doctor Weaver's partner!?

—Yes.

—But…

—I don't know how, but she seems to have earned his respect and he now deemed her a friend who shouldn't be attacked, and must even be *protected* by us. A-as if the hunters would do anything to her! I don't get it!

—But?

—But it's an order— Catra pointed out. —He only told us that the woman expressed her contempt for the murder of vampires, though we don't know why, taking into account she's literally the partner of a *vampire hunter*.

—So… you'll be protecting her from now on?

—Yeah. But, just in case, I'll do it publicly. If I do it from the shadows, the hunters will surely notice…

—What do you mean?

—I'll talk to her… Perhaps I'll understand why- *how* she earned Hordak's respect.

—She might earn yours too— Adora chuckled.

—Perhaps…

Catra let out a long sigh and rested back on her chair.

—Want a drink, Love?

—It's alright, Dor. We should probably just have dinner and go to sleep…

Castaspella

At first, Shadow Weaver refused to explain what she meant by "descendant of Mara", yet, after some breakfast and a few hours of rest with Castaspella, she finally explained it.

The ultimate weapon against vampires…

Her power so impressive, so uncontrollable, that she refused to let the hunters access it.

And she was right, it would be a bloodbath.

Of course, Doctor Weaver wasn't thinking about the many vampires that would die; she was solely looking out for herself. After all, her spells could keep her safe from Adora's passive power, but never from her full might.

So, now, in the upcoming meeting, the vampire would have to use her best manipulation techniques to get her way and delay Adora's recruitment as much as possible.

Before lunch, the women left Castaspella's apartment and went to Shadow Weaver's place to have a meal until she had to leave for the meeting.

—Come on, now. That suit looks so good— the physician insisted, as soon as the vampire was out of the bathroom.

—You just want to see me in it, don't you?

—Maybe— she admitted, smiling sheepishly. —I bet you look very handsome in it— she added, giggling.

Doctor Weaver hooked her arm around Castaspella's waist and pulled her closer to whisper —How bad do you want it?

—More than words can say— she replied, her tone soft.

They shared a kiss for a moment, the physician rested her head on the vampire's chest, and they stood like that for a moment.

Eventually, Shadow Weaver sighed —Alright, I should get dressed before it gets late. I'll wear the suit.

—Great!— Castaspella beamed. —I can maybe prepare something for when you come back…

—I reckon the meeting will last until evening, so you better not wait for me.

—Then I'll make dinner, don't worry.

—As you wish— she sighed. —Just don't burn my kitchen.

—Mean!

Doctor Weaver only smirked as a reply and went to get changed. She put on a burgundy and magenta suit along with a matching veil to cover at least the lower half of her face. Castaspella then helped brush back her hair and, once ready to go, the physician bid her farewell with a kiss through the veil.

And so she was left alone.

But not for long…

Castaspella had just settled on the lounge with a cup of tea when someone knocked on the door. And when she went to open, it was none other than Judge Hordak.

She got goosebumps but, knowing there had to be hunters around on the watch, she pushed away her fear and only greeted him.

—Good afternoon— he politely replied. —May I come in before the downpour begins?— he asked, vaguely gesturing at the cloudy sky.

—Sure, of course, come in— the physician replied, moving aside to let him walk in. —To what do I owe the visit? This… isn't even my home, so I suppose you weren't looking for me.

—I was, in fact, looking for you, Castaspella.

—You… know me?

—You're Beatrix's blood slave, aren't you?— he asked back, instead of replying.

Beatrix!? Did he mean Doctor Weaver!?

And a *what* slave!?

—I am *not* a blood slave— she first replied, offended. —Whatever that is…

—Does she *not* consume your blood?

—I willingly give it to her, yes. I-I extract it for her— she quickly replied, unsure of why she was being so honest.

Judge Hordak only hummed and inspected her closely. Then, he noticed the cup of tea next to one of the couches and raised a brow.

—Did I interrupt your afternoon tea?

—Maybe— she rebuked, more annoyed than intended. —But, of course, if you need to talk to me, in a civilized manner if possible, I'll be glad to invite you to a cup.

—Of course, that would be appreciated.

Soon, both were settled with their steamy mugs, and Castaspella decided to get back into the conversation.

—I believe we should start all over. You already know my name, and I know yours, so introductions aren't necessary. However, I would like to know what brings you here, Judge.

—I have come to speak to you, of course. You have called my attention: sister of the hunter King, partner of the hunter *vampire*— he explained.

—Wait, I just realized: How do you *know* Doctor Weaver is a vampire?

—Who do you think turned her?

She had never thought about it.

—Oh…

—But you seem… different. You're not a blood slave, as you said, since you get nothing in exchange for the blood you give her. *Why* do you do so, then?

—I just- I mean, the alternative was the blood she had been buying from drug addicts in a shady alley— she began, scoffing. —I'm a physician, I know what I'm doing. Rather than letting her get intoxicated with that poisoned blood, or even let her accidentally kill one of those people when drinking from them, I preferred to… donate mine— she honestly responded.

—You are aware of the reaction your brother would have if he knew, aren't you?

—O-of course! But I won't let him find out. I-I can't let him know about it. I don't want him to *kill* her— she stammered, rushing to reply. —Listen, I…

—Do you *not* fear vampires?

—I don't. The only time I was attacked, she was blinded by *something*. Before that, I didn't even know about vampires; after that, all I learnt has led me to believe I have nothing to fear

— Castaspella replied. —You're just like mortals in many ways…

—If you could stop your own brother from killing one of my own…

—I would— she resolutely affirmed, before he could even ask. —I would rather neither vampires nor hunters died— she went on, looking away and taking one last sip from her tea. —But it's not something I can control. I've… tried, helping both of you, but it's impossible to simply stop it all.

Judge Hordak took a moment to mull over her words while sipping his tea, and finally said —An interesting answer.

There was silence for a moment, and Castaspella noticed night was falling already.

Shadow Weaver would return soon.

—Listen… She won't take much longer to get back. You should probably leave already, Judge.

—I suppose, yes— he nodded, putting down his empty cup. —Then I shall be going before your brother can intercept me.

—Excuse me?

—He's on his way here, I'm sure.

—Why?

—The hunters watching over this place have contacted him— he explained. —I can hear the frequency of their radios anywhere. It's quite annoying— he added.

—I'm so sorry; they have me under vigilance. So, please go before he arrives.

—I reckon we'll see each other soon— Hordak ominously told her, bowing his head slightly before approaching the door.

Castaspella rushed to open, watched him walk away, and disappear around the corner.

Barely minutes after she closed the door, she heard frantic knocking and found both Micah and Shadow Weaver had arrived.

—Are you alright!?— he asked, desperate.

Did he… *know*!?

—I'm fine…

—Are you sure!? Who was here!?

—I am sure. Nothing happened— Castaspella insisted, avoiding the second question.

Either he knew Hordak is a vulture, or he simply didn't trust the Judge.

—I promise, Sis, whatever happens, I'll keep you safe, you can trust me. *Who* was here?

—I…

—Was it Judge Hordak?— he finally asked, apparently unnerved by her hesitation. Looking away, she nodded. —What did he want?

—It's nothing important, Micah. He just stayed for some tea and a chat.

—No-nothing more? That was it?

—Yes, that was it.

—What did you talk about?

—A-about the-the murder case that- the one near my apartment, remember?

—O-of course… But, how did he know to look for you here? And why the Judge himself!?

—He mentioned- Well, something about asking the doorman of my building about my whereabouts to interrogate me, no-nothing official— she lied. —And he said he was doing this himself because all his people were busy following other leads.

Shadow Weaver remained silent and unmoving while Micah continued to interrogate her — So you're alright? You're… safe. Nothing happened…

—Why would anything happen? How did you even know someone came here?

She couldn't help asking; she wanted to hear how he would try to fool her…

—No reason, but… It was just suspicious— he replied. —Look, I… So-some of the people I- You-you know how I sometimes go out at night with some friends? We usually go hunting together, to-to the Whispering Woods, and… I asked some of them to keep an eye on you when Shadow Weaver isn't around. To-to keep you safe— he blurted out, clearly in panic.

—You have me under vigilance!?— Castaspella asked, pretending to be indignant. —Micah, I am *fine*!

—O-of course… I don't know why I thought… Of course you're alright.

—Please, Micah. Go, now… It's getting late.

—And we still have to prepare dinner, don't we?— Doctor Weaver pointed out, probably realizing the physician was trying to get rid of her brother.

—I- Right… I should go, yes— he awkwardly accepted. —Can we… talk for a moment first, Shadow Weaver?

—Of course. I'll be right back— she said, leaving with Micah and closing the door.

Exhaling in relief, Castaspella walked back until she was against the wall, next to a window, and turned to look outside, taking deep breaths.

—That was close— she sighed, right before being startled by a knock on the crystal. —Shit! What- Who!?

—Fear not…— Hordak's voice said from the darkness. —I have just one question: Why did you *not* tell the hunters about me?

—I told you already— she insisted, keeping her voice low. —I do not want anyone to die! Neither hunters nor *vampires*! And my partner happens to be *both*!

—What would you do to keep both of us from dying?

—Anything— she sentenced, determined.

Castaspella could faintly see the ghost of a smile illuminated by the light from inside the house.

He was smirking.

—I see— he let out. —My respect— he then said, with a solemn tone.

—What?— she asked, yet got no reply as he retired deeper into the darkness.

With a sigh, she backed away from the window, only to bump into Shadow Weaver, who immediately wrapped her arms around Castaspella.

—What were you doing?

—No-nothing…

—It doesn't sound like nothing, and you can't fool me as easily as your brother…

The physician let out another long sigh and rested her head back against Doctor Weaver's chest.

—I… was talking to Judge Hordak again. He… was spying, I guess, to see if I'd snitch on him or not.

—And you didn't. I suppose he won't be out to get you.

—All the opposite, he said "my respects" before disappearing.

—I see— Shadow Weaver hummed, curious. —Well, now, if you don't mind, we should prepare dinner, and *you*, young lady, will tell me the truth of what you talked about with that vulture— she severely said.

—Deal. But *only* if you tell me the truth too.

—What truth?

—He said he turned you! You never told me! And what does he mean? Your real name is “Beatrix”!?

Chapter End Notes

Alright! That was all for today!

Thank you very much for reading, and you can expect more secrets to be revealed next chapter as we enter the final quarter of the fic!! :D

Also, I suppose one of the reasons why next chapter has been so complicated to write is because in Casta’s part there are some difficult conversations that are pretty hard to properly put into words and all…

Whatever, I’ll end this here before I ramble to much XD

I’ll eagerly await your comments!
See you next week!!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

I am *so sorry* for the length of this chapter…
Also because Casta's part is *twice as long* as Adora's part, and I absolutely couldn't change that…
There is nothing "extra" in Casta's part, and there wasn't anything else to add to Adora's part (I actually did add something, but it wasn't enough)

So… <("^_^)
Sorry!!

But I hope you enjoy!! There are tons of revelations in this chapter! It's a turning point, AND ends in a cliffhanger, sorry to say lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

As Adora readied to settle in bed with Catra, she couldn't help glancing at her and noticing some sort of distress in her behaviour.

—Are you… sure you'll be able to sleep?

—Why not?

—I just think you look- I mean, you're doing that thing with your tail you always do when you're nervous…

—Ugh, right…— she grunted, grabbing her tail and holding it still for a moment. Catra took a deep breath, let go of it, and sat down next to Adora. —I'm just a bit afraid of… tomorrow.

—You mean having to protect Glimmer's aunt?

—I *know* Hordak must have a good reason to trust her, but what if it puts me at risk of being discovered?— she argued. —I don't exactly have a choice in the matter, I have to do it whether I want it or not, it's a direct order. But, like… it would mean having hunters' eyes on me all day!

—Yeah…— Adora sighed. —I don't understand why *you* have to protect her, or from whom, but… if it's your duty…

—Exactly. And, well, I *suppose* Hordak doesn't trust the hunters to be able to protect her, or might even think *they* are a menace to her, in some way? I mean, the main threat would be

the rogue vampires; he must want her to stay alive, for some reason, hence why he *suddenly* cares about the vampires that *don't* follow his orders possibly targeting her— Catra explained. —On the other hand, he might know something about the Alliance that makes him think she's in danger associated with them?

—I don't get it either— her fiancée admitted. —But… better safe than sorry?

—Yeah— she smirked. With a sigh, she leant back on the pillow, staring at the ceiling. —I'll see how it goes tomorrow, and then I'll tell you— she finally decided.

—Please— Adora replied. She then lay down, pulled Catra into an embrace, took a deep breath, and kissed her forehead. —Sweet dreams.

—Sleep well, Dor.

Around noon, Chief Adora found herself wondering how things were going for Catra instead of paying attention to the file on her hands. After all, she was still working with the devices found where she was attacked and in Mystacor, and it inevitably made her think of her.

Perhaps…

Well, Catra had given her boss a copy of the file. What if he also wanted her to protect the physician because of that device found in the floating medical facility?

—Chief?— a voice called, extracting her from her thoughts. —The technician of the court is here.

—What? En-Entrapta? But why?

—She said she has to speak with you.

—Sure then, bring her to my office, please— Adora accepted.

Well… If Hordak had sent Entrapta to investigate the devices, that most certainly confirmed her suspicions: they affect vampires.

—Thank you for receiving me!— the technician cheerfully exclaimed, as soon as she crossed the door.

—Of course, Entrapta. It's no problem at all. To… what do I owe the pleasure?— she decided to ask, pretending obliviousness.

Since she wasn't supposed to know they had the information about the devices…

—Right! I was sent to analyze a certain piece of evidence you have. A device of sorts.

—A device. Well, yes, we have… an ongoing case with such piece of evidence but… how do you know?— she further inquired, playing dumb.

—Oh, well, we just caught wind of an incident you had, right Chief?— she innocently began. When Adora nodded, she went on —We recently decided to follow the investigation, in case it was related to the murder of the Butcher brothers, and…

—Were you officially sent to look into the device or is this your curiosity?— she interrupted, feeling a bit guilty for pushing Entrapta to explain so much.

After all, she might work as a technician for the court and all, but she was still as much of a princess as Glimmer…

—I- Um, yeah… It's mostly out of curiosity for now— she admitted, scratching the back of her neck. —But if I have reasons to think it's related to the murder, I will have to take it with me. Is that alright, Chief?

—If that were the case…— Adora sighed. —I suppose I would have no choice. But only if you give me a copy of your report.

—Sure! It was you who got attacked, after all. I understand if you're curious too.

—Precisely— the Chief smiled. —Then, go ahead. I'll let the forensics know you have permission to tinker with the device and use our resources too. I'll just sign you an authorization to get the evidence from the storage and you can go.

—Much appreciated, Chief!

Entrapta did as promised.

Adora's people reported that she spent the afternoon experimenting with the mysterious gadget, running tests, and recording her conclusions. By the time the night shift began, she was hardly done with it, but apparently had to go back to the court, and asked for permission to return and finish so she could properly write her report.

Yet she didn't leave without giving Chief Adora a copy of her draft.

She went over Entrapta's findings until it was quite late so, by the time she left, darkness enveloped the streets.

—Moonless night— Adora noticed. It reminded her of the "incident" with Catra once more, and she inevitably fell into deep reflection, trying to find a way of *somehow* connecting the device to the Alliance without revealing that she knew everything. —Maybe with the King's fingerprints on the trigger button— she muttered to herself, pensive, until a loud outcry interrupted her thoughts. Out of instinct, Adora grabbed her weapon and flashlight, turned it on, and rushed to the dark alley around the corner. —Who's there!?

She heard the steps of someone running away yet didn't follow, because her light found none other than Bow, armed yet with his hands raised.

—Don't shoot!— he promptly exclaimed. —I-it's me, Adora.

—Wha-what are you doing here!?

Hunting vampires, for sure…

—I was… o-on my way home. And-and I got attacked. I think it was a thief trying to rob me — he stammered.

It *had* to be a lie.

However, if he was actually hunting a vampire… Adora couldn't help but worry.

Taking a deep breath, she approached him and quickly noticed —You're bleeding.

—It's nothing. I think they had a knife or something, so I couldn't… do much with my bow, you know— he replied, awkwardly hanging it on his back as he couldn't move the wounded arm.

—Could you see the attacker?

—I… couldn't, no— he admitted, looking down.

—It's alright. Never mind— she gently said. —Now, please go to Mystacor and get that patched up— Adora pleaded.

—Of course, yeah… I wouldn't want it to infect or anything— he nodded. —But I'll be fine. I'll just get going now, don't worry.

—Don't you want me to accompany you?

—No, really. You can go home.

Could she really trust him?

—Alright— she finally sighed. —Be careful.

—I will.

Hesitant, Adora stood there for a while, watching him walk away, and only then continued on her way home.

By the time she arrived, Catra was resting on the couch with a drink, looking conflicted.

It was telling enough, but she still decided to ask about it.

—Catra?

—Oh, hey, Adora— she noticed, raising her sight.

—It… was you, wasn't it?— she inquired, taking a seat next to her with a worried frown. —In the alley a while ago.

—Yeah— her fiancée admitted, looking away again. —I'm sorry I ran, but I didn't want him to see me.

—Don't apologize. I'm glad you fled.

Catra took a deep breath, sipped her drink, and then explained —He was chasing after me. Well, at first he was actually hunting down Rogelio, one of my coworkers, but I interfered and he shifted his attention to me.

—Yet he didn't see you.

—I don't think so. Not like it would have made a difference.

—You… really think he would try to hurt you?— Adora asked, placing a hand on her shoulder.

—*I hurt him*, did I not?

—You were in danger. And I saw his wound, it was shallow.

—Yeah, of course I held back, but… still. Adora, I *hurt him*! It's enough to… convince him I'm the threat the Alliance told him we are…

—No, no— she promptly denied, pulling her into an embrace. —You didn't mean to. Wouldn't have done it if he wasn't after you. A-and I'm sure he would have let you go if he knew…

—And what if he didn't? What if he only considered me a traitor?— she asked, her voice broken.

—We both know Bow is very loyal…

—The problem is to *whom*.

—I want to believe he'd choose his friends over the Alliance.

—It… doesn't matter. I don't wanna talk about this anymore— Catra sniffed.

—Then we won't— Adora decided, cupping her face and gently making her fiancée look at her. —Why don't you tell me about your day instead?— she asked with a grin.

With half a smile, she nodded and rested her head on Adora's shoulder.

—It was better than expected, you know? Castaspella is pretty agreeable.

—That sounds good…— she replied, caressing Catra's hair.

—So I… Well, you won't believe it, but I told her everything.

—You did!?— Adora reacted, surprised, making her chuckle.

—Shocking, right? I mean, she already knew I surely was a vampire since Hordak sent me and all, but… she seemed concerned. About how we were handling both, that you "didn't know" about vampires, and the fact that the Alliance is trying to recruit you… Basically everything we've been struggling with.

—So you told her that I'm aware…

—Yeah. She actually seemed glad, you know? Oh, and she was also worried about me being discovered since she's under vigilance. She even went to finish her lunch inside so I wouldn't have to sit under the sun!— Catra added. —So, yeah, Hordak is right to trust her. She doesn't want anyone to die. And it appears she's convincing Doctor Weaver to undermine the Alliance. In fact, she's the one who persuaded the hunters to keep you in the dark and *not* recruit you.

—That's great— Adora smiled, sighing in relief. It was… *perfect*. Feeling optimistic now, she let out —Then I'm sure we have nothing to fear.

—I hope so.

The vampire downed the rest of her drink and rested on her fiancée's lap, who didn't hesitate to tease her ears, making them twitch. That way, little by little, Adora noticed her calming down until she fell asleep.

They were, in fact, right, and for a whole month, Catra fulfilled her duty without trouble.

When approached by King Micah himself, asking why she was around her so much, both convinced him it was due to new information in the murder case near her home. Being his sister, Hordak saw fit to have someone keeping an eye on her, they said.

It was a *great* strategy, Adora reckoned, since Catra had told her the physician being under the hunter's vigilance wasn't supposed to be revealed.

At the same time, their alertness about Adora's possible recruitment subsided.

She felt relieved, but also… *suspicious*.

There was… *something* in the back of her mind expecting the worst…

Yet the month passed smoothly, without surprises, and the couple settled back into how things were before that fateful night.

However, one evening, Catra wasn't home when Chief Adora arrived.

It was certainly strange, but she decided to push back her fears and prepare dinner for when she showed up.

In the meantime, Adora reviewed some administrative work she had taken home, and eventually felt curious about something…

Going over all those files kept making her mind connect them to vampires, to the point she felt like she was pretty much inventing connections, and it led her to think about that little matter she had been hiding for decades now. Her secret.

Curiosity got the best of her, so she went to her room momentarily and returned to the lounge with a worn-out book. The only source of information about her *heritage*.

It would be a good way to keep herself busy until Catra arrived…

The story of Mara.

A hero, the book said, who protected Etheria from the clutches of a formidable threat. Thousands of years ago, her powers had leveled the field against an army larger than the planet's population, achieving a victory that many thought impossible.

Said power had been called "Blessing of the Sun", and Mara herself, "The Chosen of Etheria". This implied, Adora reckoned, that her powers stemmed from nature itself, from the planet, which made Mara *the ultimate guardian*.

Her heritage was a duty to Etheria, not just to mortals.

Right?

But then, why would her powers be such a threat to vampires? Or was it because they weren't native to Etheria, but rather the remains of what used to be their greatest enemy?

That sounded… *unfair*.

They may have been the enemy centuries ago, but *now*!?

The vampires that remained, as far as she knew, no longer posed a threat! Catra had told her they were not supposed to attack innocent civilians!

So *how* could they be considered the enemy still!?

There had to be a way to use her powers without risking hurting vampires with her mere presence, as the book suggested Mara did.

But *how*!?

She… had no idea.

She barely understood this book, and absolutely didn't understand her own powers yet.

It was frustrating.

She had never wanted to use this power, even before knowing vampires were still around and not just a centuries-old myth. And now!? Far more reasons for her to refuse her heritage.

Frustrated, Adora closed the book and let out a sigh.

Perhaps it would be better if she ate already.

Catra would surely arrive soon…

But hours passed, the food went cold, and the vampire wasn't home.

Adora's anxiety grew until she couldn't stay sitting anymore, and so she rushed to get changed, planning to go look for her.

She was barely finishing when a knocking on the door called her attention.

Could it be Catra?

If not, who else?

But then, shouldn't she be opening the door herself?

In any case, she decided to open, yet stopped just before reaching the doorknob as the knocking became frenetic and a slightly familiar voice yelled on the other side.

—Chief Adora!— she heard. Wasn't that Glimmer's aunt? —Please open! This is urgent!

Right.

Confused now, she opened up and found a *very* distressed Castaspella, clutching a piece of paper.

—What's going on!?

All her fears returned in a second, causing a ringing in her ears to immediately overwhelm her as the physician exclaimed —They've got Catra!

Castaspella

The physician was decided. She wouldn't drop the matter until she got *answers*.

Fortunately, the vampire agreed to give them… but during dinner since she felt quite hungry, and not for blood this time.

They decided to cook together a dozen pieces of falafel, some rice to go with it, and of course, each grabbed a drink.

—Where should I begin?

—Good question… Um, your name. Why didn't you tell me before? I've been avoiding calling you by your full name in private because it felt too… *detached*. But I couldn't find any nice way of calling you, since using just part of your name doesn't quite fit— Castaspella replied, over-explaining a bit.

—So I've noticed, and that was for the best; I dislike nicknames— Shadow Weaver sighed. —I suppose you *can* call me "Beatrix", as long as you don't use it in public.

—Thank you— she smiled. —But why didn't you tell me?

With an annoyed grunt, the vampire explained —It's not that I dislike it, but it doesn't represent me anymore. I'd say *no one* knows "Beatrix", only "Shadow Weaver", the persona I choose to show.

—No one? Not even me?

—You might be the only one who's come close enough, that much is true. But can you really say you know me?

—I'm *trying*, which is why I'm asking you to be honest now— Castaspella argued. —So, my next question would be… when did Hordak turn you? And why aren't you part of the Horde like other vampires?

—I hardly remember when it happened— she admitted with a breathless laugh. —I believe it was after a few missions… If I recall correctly, my pride made him want to teach me a lesson; instead of killing me, he let me live as the enemy I had sworn to destroy— she began, pensive. —Yes… I believe it was among my first missions as a high-ranking hunter. Everyone was quite shocked to discover I survived after they lost contact with me. And to answer your second question, I made a deal with him.

—A deal. Is that why you haven't revealed his identity?

—Part of it. I retained my freedom, he retained his anonymity. But the core of the deal was to keep Adora from joining the Alliance.

—Oh…

—That was when I learnt of her heritage as a descendant of Mara. She was just a child, so we were in time to make sure she'd be kept in the dark.

—But how?

—I convinced Queen Angella she would be in greater danger than any other hunter since she showed extraordinary aptitudes, *and* would put the secrecy of the Alliance at risk. It was easier to convince her as her own daughter had similar characteristics.

—I don't understand… How would Adora or Glimmer put the secrecy at risk?

—Their powers. Both of them have really powerful abilities that would deal with vampires with ease *but* would call unwanted attention to themselves— Shadow Weaver explained. —It's the same reason why Angella herself doesn't get involved in actual hunting. However, of course, I never disclosed the true extent of Adora's powers.

—Then… why would she want to recruit her now?

—Who knows— she sighed. —At least I managed to succeed in the meeting today arguing she's someone who'd see our hunting as an unfair, rather uncivilized practice— she explained. —As a servant of the law, I'm sure Adora wouldn't approve of delivering punishment by our own hand, much less without proof of any wrongdoings from the hunted vampires. And it would be a great threat for the Alliance to have Adora as their enemy.

—Which is completely reasonable!— Castaspella pointed out, indignant. —A-actually… Do you *realize* how bad your actions are, or do I have to explain it to you?

—You mean how we systematically chase down and eliminate individuals based on nothing but their nature?

—Exactly! I-I mean, *you* are proof that vampires aren't the monsters the Alliance believes them to be! In fact, it's far more monstrous what the hunters do! It's cruel and-and…

—You can tell me I'm a monster for being a *hunter* rather than for being a vampire— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—I…— she began, but interrupted herself and swallowed hard. —I certainly don't want you, or any of the hunters, to continue with what you do. But I know I can't stop it either— she hesitantly started again. —And no. You're not "monsters", it's even *worse*. You can't expect anything from a monster other than cruelty and wickedness. But you? *All of you* are actively *choosing* to do this. It's not "in your nature" because you're *not* monsters. You're just being cruel and senseless.

—I suppose you're right— the vampire sighed. —Just like I'm a traitor to my own kind…

—Can't you… stop this?

—I don't think I can, no.

—But…

—I won't pretend I tried, nor will I lie and tell you I've ever sabotaged missions… However, if so you want, then I'm willing to do it from now on whenever I'm assigned a task— she proposed. —Sabotaging myself should be easy enough— she smirked.

—I said before that I don't want you to take any more risks and that remains true, but that would be… a good start, yes— Castaspella nodded. —However, I don't want you to do it because *I* ask you to. I just want you to see how *wrong* the hunt is; do the *right thing*.

—I'm not a righteous person, Casta.

—But you're not *as evil* as you pretend to be, either…

She *couldn't* be, right?

—What?— Shadow Weaver asked, probably noticing her confused expression.

—One last question— she began. She had *many* questions, but the others could wait. —Why does the Alliance… hunt? How did it begin?

—Interesting question…— she hummed. —Angella would know better but, from what I know, it began centuries ago, with an invasion. A vulture known as Horde Prime threatened Etheria, and a hero named Mara rose to fight him.

—Centuries… A-a vulture like Hordak… and I'm guessing that Adora's powers are what Mara had…

—Correct. Hordak is a clone of Horde Prime, one that remained.

—Alright?

—The hunters as an organization were established by Mara, and then *dissolved* by her too. The current hunters, the Alliance, were restablished by Queen Angella much later.

—Why- Wait, *what*!?

—The original hunters were tasked with eliminating the vultures and vampires Horde Prime commanded, who ravaged Etheria for decades— Shadow Weaver started again, sighing. —Mara managed to drive them away, and since the threat was no more, the hunters were dissolved.

—Alright, I understand. So why did Angella…

—Patience, I was about to explain that— the vampire interrupted, smirking.

—Right, I'm sorry— Castaspella muttered, blushing a bit.

—It isn't known *why* she decided to create the Alliance, the secret one, restoring the ancient hunters as an organization, but rumors say that she caught wind of a vulture remaining on Etheria, and apparently thinks he might be a dormant threat.

—If he were…

—He would have attacked already, yes. But we can't tell her that. She won't *listen*.

—Right…

—So, of course, they are fighting an imaginary enemy now. They think they are still at war, and there is no way to convince them otherwise— Doctor Weaver huffed. —They even

invented those devices to make us go mad… Remember when I attacked you that night? It was one of those. The purpose is, supposedly, to make us expose ourselves, but I think it's just an excuse to justify hunting us.

—Sounds like it, yes— Castaspella let out, disgusted. However, her expression suddenly changed as she realized —You… are speaking like a vampire.

—What do you mean?

—You… spoke about hunters as if you weren't one, and included yourself with the vampires — she explained, unable to hold back a smile.

—And it makes you happy because…

—I want to believe that, if you had to choose, this means you'd choose the vampires over the hunters…

—Perhaps— Shadow Weaver sighed, reaching for her hand.

Inevitably hopeful, Castaspella laced her fingers with hers and squeezed a bit while smiling brighter.

All she had, she realized, was hope…

That night, the physician went to sleep with a conflicted feeling tightening her chest.

She hadn't really dwelled on it before, she didn't want to, but the people she loved, her partner and her brother, both carried out what could only be described as a heinous *massacre*.

She woke up just as troubled, as she expected, and went to work almost automatically, barely paying attention to anything.

Her duties now felt so… *stupid*. She felt useless, doing nothing about the hunt; just letting it happen.

But what could she do?

A mix of guilt and shame overtook the physician for hours…

Until someone surprised her during her lunch break.

—Excuse me— a voice called from behind. —Castaspella, right?

A young woman, magicat from her appearance, had approached her seemingly out of nowhere.

—Yes? Do I… know you?

—You don't. But you know my boss, Judge Hordak.

—Oh… Yes, that's correct.

Could this be a vampire?

—I'm sorry to bother you. My name is Catra, pleased to make your acquaintance.

—Nice to meet you, Catra— Castaspella replied with a smile.

—I just wanted to tell you that you might see me around since I've been assigned to keep watch on you and make sure you remain safe.

—Re-really? Why!?

—Hordak's orders. I don't know more than you.

—I see… Would you like to take a seat? I have another forty minutes before returning to my duties— she offered.

—Oh, su-sure— Catra accepted.

—Have you been working at the court for long?

—Two years and a few months— she replied, neutral.

—Impressive. You look quite young, though. May I ask what your duties are?

—A few administrative things, but I mostly handle Hordak's errands. Like this one.

Castaspella let out half a smile and nodded.

—This sounds like a bit of a dangerous errand, wouldn't you say?

—I've… dealt with worse dangers…— Catra vaguely replied, seemingly catching herself before saying too much.

—Like… the sun?

The physician knew she'd probably be pushing her luck a bit too far. However, she found no other way to let her know that she knew the truth yet meant no harm.

—Perhaps.

—Then we should probably go inside— Castaspella suggested. —I like eating out here, but… you're not the only one keeping an eye on me, and such unwanted attention is probably a big risk already.

—Are you sure?

—Absolutely— she nodded, picking up her things. Catra's expression was of absolute surprise; she seemed speechless, and possibly relieved. —Follow me. We can go to the break room.

As the women sat at a table, they got comfortable and chatted a bit more until the vampire relaxed enough to remove her hood and lay back on her chair.

That was when Castaspella dared inquire a bit more.

—Excuse my intrusiveness. You're Chief Adora's fiancée, right?

—I am, yes— she admitted, unable to hold back a smile. —Do you know her?

—She has come to Mystacor a lot of times, yes— she replied. —Unfortunately, of course…

—Yeah. I don't really like it when she has to come here.

—I imagine— the physician sighed. —The reason I ask is… well, I just wonder how it's possible that Chief Adora doesn't know about, you know, the *Horde* and the *real* Alliance— she revealed, keeping her voice down despite the place being empty.

—Why-why do you ask?

—I presume it's not easy to hide your nature from her; she must have noticed *something*— Castaspella clarified, noticeably concerned. —I can't imagine how hard keeping it from her might be…

—That's- I- You're… worried?— Catra stammered, seemingly moved. —Tha-thank you for your concern but… Ah…— she began, yet interrupted herself with a sigh. —Alright. You're… clearly trustworthy, especially if you have Hordak's respect— she then nodded, greatly surprising the physician. —I'm not supposed to tell you this, but I believe I can trust you won't reveal it: Adora knows.

Castaspella's eyes went wide and she held back a gasp.

Part of her was relieved to know it, but then Shadow Weaver's words resonated in her head and she couldn't help feeling a bit anxious.

—Si-since when!?

—There was… an accident. I was affected by *something* and attacked her; she fired back and… let's just say I had absolutely no idea how to justify the blood and the scars— Catra explained, shaking her head a bit. —Besides, I had been lying to her for a year. It felt awful…

—I see— Castaspella nodded. She was about to reveal she went through something similar but, unsure of how much this vampire knew, she refrained from revealing the truth about Shadow Weaver. Instead, she said —Well, I… learnt that the hunters are trying to recruit her now. It wouldn't matter whether she knows or not. So how is she…

—We're handling it— the vampire interrupted. —Thanks for the concern, again…

—Of course.

—Mind if *I'm* intrusive now?

—Please, go ahead— Castaspella chuckled.

—I don't understand how someone who's clearly against the hunt… is also deeply related not to one, but to *two* hunters— she began. —I-I mean… how is it that you- Why *aren't* you on their side?

—Right…— the physician sighed, looking down. —That's actually a great question— she admitted, with a short breathless laugh. —I'm the last person you'd think would be on your side, I guess.

—Well, yeah… It's just difficult to understand how you can love someone whose actions you condemn.

—Indeed— she sighed again. —The truth is… I've- It's complicated for me. I think that, at first, it was because Micah is involved, and eventually, because I fell for Doctor Weaver, but I had indeed been ignoring the obvious: the hunt is nothing but a massacre. They think they're fighting a war, but it's… it's most certainly *not a war*.

—We can't exactly attempt any kind of negotiations or diplomacy, but Hordak really wants a truce. He ordered everyone in the Horde never to threaten innocent civilians, thought that would be enough to keep the hunters off our backs… but they- Ugh… They won't let us be! — Catra expressed, noticeably frustrated.

—I know— Castaspella nodded. —So… admitting this now, I can't help but be conflicted *precisely* because, as you said, those I love are… doing *that*. I can't control who I love, just like I can't pretend Micah isn't my brother. Yet that's no reason to keep turning a blind eye! It's all so *wrong*! And I'm just… allowing it.

—Yeah, but… it's not like you can do much either— the vampire muttered, looking away.

—I *should*. Pe-perhaps discussing this with Doctor Weaver yesterday actually made a difference— she reflected. —Maybe she… A-alright, I don't know if she'll really see how *wrong* everything about the hunt is, but since I'm asking for it, she's willing to sabotage missions and try to take down the real Alliance from *within*.

—She- There's no way!

—I know she isn't exactly, uh, a *nice* person. She's selfish, manipulative, egocentric… she never does anything that won't benefit her in some way— Castaspella enumerated. —But she might do this for me. I would rather she did it with the honest intention of making up for her actions… yet that's *unlikely* to happen.

—Wrong reasons, but… I'll take whatever I'm given— Catra let out, eyes wide open in shock. —If she really does that, then we might- I…— she stammered, breathless. —Thank you.

—There's nothing to thank me for, Catra— the physician immediately replied. —It's the least I can do, and I wish I could do more…

—It's a lot. It's- I mean, maybe you could ask her to make sure they don't recruit Adora— she hesitantly proposed, with a glint of hope in her eyes.

—Oh, I don't need to— Castaspella assured her, gesturing dismissively. —Doctor Weaver is the one who convinced them to keep Chief Adora in the dark in the first place. She already made sure they won't bother her again.

—Really!?

—Absolutely.

—*Why*!?

—Like I said, she's selfish and egocentric. Keeping Adora from joining the hunters plays into her interests. I can't… tell you much more, but you can trust me— the physician carefully explained, making sure not to reveal too much.

—Tha-that's great news! I… Seriously, *thank you*— Catra expressed, sighing in relief.

As nighttime arrived, Catra's working hours came to an end, and she explained to Castaspella that a coworker of hers, Rogelio, would keep an eye on her from the shadows until she reached her home. Once there, he would retire since they didn't want to invade her privacy, and only return in the morning or when she left the house.

Hence, they discussed the physician's schedule and residence addresses before Catra left to let her work. It would certainly be a long night again, especially with her thoughts returning to the dilemma of how horrendous the hunters' actions are, but she couldn't help feeling… quite *safe* knowing she had the protection of the vampires.

Because… what if the hunters learnt about her allegiance to them? Or that she convinced Shadow Weaver to boycott them?

What if they found out she fed the vampire her own blood?

What if…

Her thoughts were interrupted by someone knocking on the emergency room where she was allocated for the night.

—Who is it?— she asked as she opened the door. —Bow!?— she immediately gasped, ushering him in as she saw his bleeding arm. —What happened!?

A thought formed as soon as she asked… He was probably *hunting*.

—It was… a-an accident. Don't worry— he nervously replied.

As she fetched some gauze and hydrogen peroxide, she told him —I need to know what happened to properly treat the wound.

—But…

—If you don't tell me *how* you got cut, I can't know if you need stronger antiseptics or something— she insisted, trying to sound gentler.

She couldn't help fishing for information, but she couldn't *force him* to speak either.

—A-alright… I got- I think a thief tried to rob me— he hesitantly began. Was he lying? —They must have had a knife or something, a-and cut me— he went on, looking away.

His eyes… He was lying.

—So… probably a metal cut. Let me give you a tetanus shot, just in case— she suggested.

After all, if it was a vampire's claw, like she supposed, then it would be necessary indeed.

—Thank you, Casta— he sighed, holding the piece of gauze covering his wound.

—I… know you're in that, uh, hunting party thing— she carefully began, before injecting the vaccine. —I've seen my brother's scars and… *this* is nothing compared to what you can suffer, you know?

—I know.

—Well— she sighed, piercing his skin with the needle. —If I were you, I wouldn't want to worry Glimmer that much— she commented, taking her time with the injection. He said nothing, probably too focused on bearing the sting, and she carefully withdrew the syringe. —She'll probably freak out when she sees this, so… why don't you… consider leaving? You can always go back to the academy— Castaspella decided to say, risking it a bit too much.

Bow seemed surprised at first, but then slowly lowered his head.

—I… can't— he admitted, sounding conflicted. —It's not… something I do because I want. I-I *have* to do this…

—Why is that?— she asked, gentle and encouraging.

—It's- I promised to do this. I *have to*. It's fo-for Glimmer's safety.

—Bow… wanting to look after her is alright, but she's not exactly defenseless, and it's certainly *not* your *duty* to keep her safe— Castaspella argued.

—It is. I- If I want to- I *will* marry her, soon enough, I hope, so I have to do this— he insisted, straightening his back.

—Did… my brother tell you that? Are you doing this to earn his blessing?

—No-no. I-I'm doing it for Glimmer, I swear— Bow promptly replied. —I want Bright Moon to be safer for her— he sighed, closing his eyes. —Whatever the cost.

—Even if the cost is your *life*?

He looked at her with a bit of a pleading look. Like begging to end the conversation.

Yet it also seemed like he was trying to figure out just how much Castaspella knew…

Perhaps she was risking it too much, after all…

—I will be fine, Casta— he assured her, forcing a smile. —Thank you.

—You're welcome— she uttered, trying not to feel guilty for subjecting him to that interrogation. —Take care, alright?

—Of course— he nodded.

Unfortunately, despite Castaspella's efforts, Bow didn't quit.

She had even convinced Shadow Weaver to help her, which basically meant asking her to manipulate him into leaving the hunters, yet it proved futile.

In fact, it even angered the vampire; not because she wanted Bow to quit, but rather because she couldn't believe her manipulation wasn't working.

Something had a greater hold on him than the influence her manipulation could exert.

That obviously meant Shadow Weaver got a bit obsessed with finding out what that was, and Castaspella's theory was soon proven right.

Micah had convinced him that the vampires were a threat, that marrying Glimmer meant he had to do his part, and that if anything ever happened to her, it'd be his fault for ignoring his duty.

Yet the knowledge was useless…

—I'm telling you… The boy is hesitant yet resolved at the same time.

—I just…

—If you fear that he'll kill a vampire eventually, then you can rest assured: I've made sure he only gets scout missions under the excuse that he could have died with the Butcher brothers that first time— Shadow Weaver told her.

—Ah… thanks, Bea— Castaspella sighed.

—In any case, he has tried to stick to mere logistics. He's good with technology and prefers to craft gadgets rather than use them.

—Yet those are still used to kill vampires.

—While true, that doesn't put blood on his hands— Doctor Weaver tried to argue.

But the physician disagreed.

Resting back on the couch, she let out a long sigh and remarked —It does. It makes him just as guilty as them.

—Do *you* consider yourself guilty too?

—You mean for letting the hunt just *happen*!?

—Yes.

—Of course I do!

—You shouldn't— the vampire rebuked, rolling her eyes.

—No offense, Bea, but you aren't exactly a moral standards reference point.

—You and your morals…— Shadow Weaver scoffed, sardonic.

—You know what!? Forget it. Let's just prepare dinner, please…— Castaspella decided, standing up.

—Sure…

As the vampire stood up to follow her, smirking mockingly at the physician, a sudden slam against the door made them both jump.

—What…

—Quiet.

A second slam soon followed, almost breaking the door.

Frozen in place, Castaspella felt her heart beating fast, deafening her.

What was going on!?

Shadow Weaver immediately raised a hand gesturing at her to stay put, and stepped closer to the door.

Yet before she was close enough, a third slam finally broke the lockset and it burst open.

Instinctively, the women readied spells to face whoever was breaking in, yet dropped them almost immediately.

—Micah!?— Castaspella exclaimed.

—Are you *insane*!?— Shadow Weaver indignantly yelled.

—Take her— he simply ordered, revealing two men behind him.

—What!?

Ignoring their question, the pair, probably hunters, approached the vampire, who was too shocked to react in time. When she finally raised shadows around her to push them away, Micah quickly countered them and the men caught her hands.

—No, wait!

Castaspella finally forced herself to react, casting a spell of her own, yet her brother got in the middle.

—Stop.

—Micah, what are you doing!?

—We have to take her, Sis. I'm… sorry— he replied, averting his gaze.

—You can't even look me in the eye while you say it!

—I need you to stay out of this— he insisted. Placing a hand on her shoulder, he added —This isn't something you understand.

—You can't say that! You have no right!— Castaspella exploded, shoving his hand away and trying to walk past him to help Shadow Weaver.

The vampire was struggling against the hunters, yet it was clear she tried to keep the façade of being a mortal, since she wasn't using her full strength.

—That's enough! Take her away!— the King ordered the hunters, who coordinated their movements to subdue Shadow Weaver. —And you, stay away from things you *don't* understand— he then told his sister.

He couldn't be doing this.

Not *now*!

What on Etheria could she do!?

Desperate, she simply threw herself at one of the hunters, trying to give the vampire a chance to free her hand and use magic, but the man easily pushed her away, keeping Doctor Weaver down, kneeling on the floor.

The physician fell back against a small table, yelping —Hey!

—Careful!— Micah reacted, glaring at the hunter.

—Then keep her away!— the man rebuked.

—No! Just let go of her!— Castaspella insisted, pushing herself up and trying again, gripping the hunter's coat as he pushed her back. —Bastard!

She was shoved to the ground once more, making Micah tell him off, and noticed a piece of paper had fallen from the hunter's coat. Discretely, she brushed it under the little table and stood up again.

—…Then keep her *away*!— he was repeating, facing the King yet keeping a firm grip on the vampire.

—Fuck you!

—Stop, Casta— Micah quickly interceded, holding her by the shoulders.

She was ready to yell again, furious beyond compare, but Shadow Weaver spoke first.

—Just listen to your brother— the vampire urged her.

—No, please…

—And forgive me, but our dinner will have to wait— she let out, breathless and a bit sardonic.

—Micah! You can't do this!

—I must— he insisted, keeping her from reaching for Shadow Weaver again.

—Where are you even taking her!?

—I can't answer.

—For how long!?

—I can't answer either…

—That's like saying "forever"!— the physician indignantly cried.

—I can't do anything about this— he sighed, shaking his head.

—Yes, you can! Just stop this!

—It's not my prerogative…

—Micah!

—I'm sorry, Sis.

—If you really are, then at least let me… say goodbye— Castaspella finally begged, feeling her tears fall.

The King couldn't look at her again.

He hesitated for a moment, seemingly struggling internally, until he finally nodded and let go of his sister.

—Casta— the vampire managed to say, before being interrupted by a desperate kiss.

—I'm sorry, I love you— she sobbed, cupping her face. —I'm sorry…

—Listen, Casta… Remember when I told you I only look out for myself?— Shadow Weaver began. As she nodded, the vampire continued —It's no longer true. Understood? I also care for *you* now, so I need you to *promise* you'll stay away, *safe*.

—But…

—No foolish acts of heroism, Casta. Keep yourself safe— she insisted.

—I'll try— Castaspella finally accepted, pressing her lips together as she held back another sob.

—Good…

The physician kissed her one last time before her brother pulled her away once again, ordering the hunters to drag Doctor Weaver out of there.

Finally, he told her something she didn't pay any attention to and left her crying on the floor.

It took Castaspella a while to compose herself and fix the door to close it again, and even longer to remember the little paper she had hidden under the table.

In the middle of her mourning, the memory returned, giving her a bit of hope.

What if it had useful information!?

They would probably take her to the library, but what if this had codes or indications useful to find whatever kind of holding facility they had?

Brushing her tears away, the physician sat on the couch, opened the piece of paper, and found nothing but gibberish.

Right.

Shadow Weaver had mentioned they write in code in case something like this happens.

Yet it seemed… pretty obvious to the physician.

Using a bit of sorcery, she translated the message and felt like fainting.

It couldn't be…

Capture confirmation: the suspect of vampirism, Catra D'riluth, has been apprehended after leaving the court. In wait for questioning.

Capture order, to be executed immediately: Doctor Beatrix 'Shadow' Weaver, under the suspicion of vampirism.

They found out.

How did they find out!?

And about them *both*!

Had Micah somehow noticed Castaspella had been extracting her blood, maybe?

Had the hunters monitoring her noticed *something*!?

She was sure Catra had done nothing to blow her cover, and yet…

Before she could think better about it, the physician was running down the streets, in the middle of the night, to Chief Adora's only known address.

What else could she do!?

This was her only shot…

Knocking on the front door, she noticed her desperation rising.

No one answered, but the lights were on…

She *had* to be home, right!?

Knocking more frenetically now, she cried out —Chief Adora! Please open! This is urgent!

She clutched the piece of paper in one hand, while the other rested on her chest as she tried to recover from the run.

She was still quite breathless.

Castaspella was about to knock again when the door finally opened.

—What's going on!?

She didn't waste time trying to gently break the news to her.

She'd probably lose it but, right now, she *had* to lose it…

So it was no surprise that Adora's bewildered expression went pale the second she exclaimed —They've got Catra!

Chapter End Notes

Ok

I admit that was kinda cruel

But hehehehe it will guarantee you return for ch 11 lol

Nah, I'm joking XD
It just had to be like this cause it's more *dramatic* :D

Next chapter will also be pretty loaded, intense, I dare say, and I barely finished writing it last Sunday. With Adora and Castaspella joining forces, writing the different POVs without repeating everything is a bit difficult hehe <("^_^)

ANYWAYS! I hope to see you next week, and I can't wait to know what you think and what your theories are!

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

I normally post right after midnight here but last night I forgot what day it was, so I'm sorry for the delay…

Welp, this chapter ended up being a bit short… I'm thinking part of Ch 12 should be here but I wanted to keep some suspense before the end!!
And, compensating last time, Adora's part is slightly longer than Casta's this time lol
~~It's nowhere near enough compensation haha~~

AHEM

The end is NEAR

Are you ready?
Lemme spoil you: you're not

Ehe

But no more prelude… Please enjoy!! (And share your theories for what's to come!!)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

—Come in.

The woman hurried inside, seemingly out of breath, and Adora closed the door immediately.

—I'm so sorry, Chief.

—Just *explain* to me what's going on. What do you mean!?

—Right— Castaspella sighed, taking deep breaths. —It's this- I-I mean… It's a lot to explain, and I don't know how much time we have…

—What is that?— Adora asked, taking the piece of paper the physician handed her. —I can't… understand this.

—Right, right. It's in code. It says they captured Catra and wait for the interrogation, a-and… it orders the capture of… Doctor Weaver.

—What!? The-the hunters- No, no… Catra— Adora uttered, starting to panic. Her head filled with noise again, until realization hit, froze her a second, and prompted her to ask —Why… did they capture Doctor Weaver too? Isn't she a hunter?

—That's the "lot to explain" I mentioned…

—Listen, my fiancée is in danger— she severely began. —Tell me *everything* and we may be able to get them both back.

—Ye-yes. A-alright— Castaspella nodded. —To begin with, Shadow Weaver is also a vampire— she first said. Seemingly anticipating Adora's surprise, she quickly clarified — Yes, she is a hunter too, she's… not the most honest person out there.

—And got caught *now*!? How!?

—My… brother and a pair of hunters broke into her place, subdued her, and in the struggle to help her, I managed to steal that note from them— the physician briefly explained. —She was trying to keep the mortal façade, otherwise, she wouldn't have been caught, but… we just *can't* throw everything away as if…

—Wait, you mean she wants to keep being a hunter!? And *what*!? Convince them their *absolutely correct* identification of her as a vampire is actually *wrong*!?

—I don't know. I suppose…— Castaspella hesitated. —She certainly doesn't want to be discovered, but… at the same time, as I asked her to sabotage the Alliance and that's easier to do from the inside…

—Yeah, Catra told me— Adora remembered. —So they discovered them both… and now caught them, and… do we even know *where* they took them!?

—They might be in the library— the physician guessed. —I think.

—You *think*?

—I haven't been there many times. I'm *not* supposed to know. I only have what Bea told me to go by!

—Who?

—Doctor Weaver. Sorry.

—Right. It-it's something. We can start there…

—Good— Castaspella sighed, seemingly relieved.

A silence then settled between them, and the women kept looking anywhere but at each other. Adora was… very much on edge, and may have been a bit severe, but the physician was probably feeling exactly the same, so she felt a tad guilty.

—Please, take a seat. We'll discuss how to do this, and we are *going* to do this tonight.

She finally looked back at the Chief, letting out a smile, and nodded.

—So I hoped, thank you— she uttered, letting herself fall on a chair next to the table.

—Of course— Adora sighed. —Now, what exactly do we have in our favour?

—Some sorcery? Perhaps, I'd say, the element of surprise?

—How?

—None of us is supposed to know about vampires or hunters…

—Right. So, surprise element, they won't be expecting us, and your sorcery— Adora began enumerating. —I have my gun, but I can't fire it without a good reason… And then there's… *that*.

—You mean…— Castaspella hesitantly asked. —Your heritage?

—Yeah…

Perhaps her sudden wariness was obvious, since the physician quickly told her —Doctor Weaver knows… and told me. That's why she didn't want the hunters to recruit you.

—Oh… That- Well, that makes a lot of sense with the full context now.

—Yes— Castaspella nodded, shyly brushing a lock of loose hair behind her ear. —Just in case… you don't have to use those powers if you don't want to. Alright?

Was her reticence *that* obvious?

Well, maybe she *could* be fully honest?

Her fiancée trusted this woman, and she had come to her immediately after knowing Catra had been captured too…

—You're right, I suppose— Adora exhaled. —Truth is… I never wanted to use those powers; even before knowing vampires were still a thing, I mean. At first, I thought it was stupid to have such a specific ability, especially since it was tailored for creatures that no longer existed— she first explained. —Then Catra turned out to be a vampire and, I didn't even want to think about it. But this past month I've been reading what little I have on the matter, and there's no doubt: my "heritage" is to kill my fiancée. And I refuse— she went on, serious, staring at her hands. —But if I have to transform and turn my powers against the hunters, *I will*.

Castaspella took a deep breath and Adora looked at her with determination.

—That's very noble. I'm sure we'll be able to rescue them.

—I hope… Because, if we don't, I can't guarantee what I'll do— she admitted, closing her fists tightly.

—It won't be necessary, Chief— the physician reassured her. —But, if it were, I… have quite a lot of information on them that I *may or may not* have collected months ago— she then added, sheepish.

—I've been pretending that I know nothing, to keep Catra safe, mostly, but… I'm starting to think I should drop it and build a case against their whole… organization— Adora decided to admit, finally sitting down too. —What they do, I'm sure you agree it's far from acceptable. I'd even say…

—Unforgivable. Yes.

—So I'll probably ask for whatever evidence you have of what they do.

—It will be difficult going against the Queen— Castaspella pointed out, looking away. She then swallowed hard and added —But it might be the only way. I mean, after a month, Doctor Weaver has made little progress in taking the Alliance down from the inside. She couldn't even convince Bow to quit!

—He's one of my best friends, you know?

—I know.

—Thank you for trying— Adora faintly smiled. After a moment, she sighed —I guess we should prepare to get into that library then.

—I can get us inside with a cloaking spell.

—Then what?

—I know how to get into the forbidden section, which is actually like their headquarters, and I can see if I find any kind of holding cells.

—And use magic to free them?

—Probably.

—Then I'll stay outside to make sure you can get them out.

—That's a good idea— Castaspella nodded. —I'll go to my apartment to check my notes and the schedule so we have an idea of who will be there now.

—Then I'll see you at the entrance of the library.

—Of course— the physician nodded, standing up.

Adora saw her out, looked around hoping no one had spied on them, and locked the door.

Fighting back her anxiety, she went to her room, opened the last drawer of her dresser, and stared for a moment at the elegant white and gold sword hidden inside.

With a nervous gulp, she picked it up, took a deep breath, and it shone for a moment before disappearing.

However, her instincts told her it would be better to take her gun regardless, so she grabbed her holster, secured it across her chest with her gun on, and left the bedroom.

She was ready to go.

As agreed, Chief Adora met Castaspella right at the entrance of the library, where she told her they'd wait for someone to open the door before sneaking in.

According to the information she had gathered, it was about the time some hunters changed shifts, so it was the perfect time to get in. And right on cue, a couple of young men walked in before long; cloaked by the physician's sorcery, they followed them inside and found a hiding spot behind a bookshelf.

In hushed tones, Castaspella explained exactly who each of them was…

—Got it. If they discover me, I can handle them.

—Let's hope they don't.

—In any case, just go and don't worry about me. Focus on getting them out.

—Yes, Chief— she replied, before cloaking herself again to leave their hiding spot.

For the first couple of minutes, Adora's mind was on the myriad of possible ways in which this all could play out. She tried to keep herself optimistic, but it was quite hard…

Yet it wasn't long before the conversation between the pair of hunters they had followed inside called her attention.

—Can you believe it? A vampire in the court— the first one was saying.

—Who would have thought they had infiltrated them… Vampires within one of the most powerful organizations in Etheria— the other replied with a scoff.

—Just you wait. We'll get information out of her: how many are in the court, who their leader is, where their nest is…

—You think she'd reveal all of that?

—With those truth spells of the King, *sure* — he confidently answered. —If not, they can *always* torture it out of her.

They could *what*!?

Oh, no.

They would absolutely *not* touch a single hair of hers.

Clenching her jaw and closing her fists tightly, Adora shut her eyes, trying to calm herself down.

But then she heard —Do you think they'll let us watch?

Was this all a *joke* to them!?

Watch!?

That was certainly enough.

Adora couldn't take it anymore.

Before she could think better about it, She-Ra was out, sword in hand, stalking towards the desk behind which the hunters were standing.

—Who-

—How *dare* you!?

—Who-who the fuck are you!?

—I ask the questions now. Where is she?— Adora severely asked.

—We-we won't tell you a-anything— one of them stammered.

Pointing at them with the sword, she repeated —*Where* is she? Now.

—Why do you care!?— the other asked, putting on a fearless expression. —She's a vampire! A threat!

—That is *not* true! They are not threats. *You are*!

—We keep people safe!

—Bullshit!

—She-Ra!?— a voice suddenly exclaimed behind her, making the hunters smirk.

Adora immediately turned around to find the Queen standing in shock after rushedly flying towards the back of the library.

Angella was closing her wings while quickly schooling her whole presence into her usual poise.

She seemed ready to downplay whatever was going on, but the Chief wouldn't let her.

—I'm not playing games, your Majesty.

—Of course, Adora. We know. But you must calm down— she replied, paying no mind to the sword pointed at her.

—I will not until Catra is back safe and sound— she sentenced, squinting at her.

—Adora!— Another voice called out, once again behind her, before the Queen could say anything else.

The physician had returned… with both vampires in tow.

Castaspella

Alright. They had a plan.

Having agreed with Chief Adora on what to do, Castaspella rushed to her apartment and quickly went through her investigation.

It was the end of the week, the Queen would return much later, so they would probably have free way into the forbidden section. With Adora staying outside, Angella's return wouldn't be a surprise, and that only left her to deal with Micah.

He *surely* would be back there, if that's where they keep prisoners.

Who else could be there?

According to the schedules she had managed to put together, Bow and his fellow trainees would also be there…

Right, they could probably use the time when the last of them enter to go into the library without being noticed!

Yes, that would be enough…

—Alright, time to go— she told herself, pushing back her nerves before finally leaving.

Soon enough, she met Adora at the entrance of the library, as agreed.

—How do we get in without being noticed?

—We wait for someone to open and sneak in behind them.

—That can take forever!

—Two hunter trainees will be arriving soon, don't worry— Castaspella explained. —I took note of their schedules, and they work in shifts. So this is the perfect time to infiltrate.

—I'll… trust your certainly *not* concerning stalking of the hunters…

—It's a bit weird, isn't it?— the physician asked, ashamed.

—Perhaps, but… it's useful now, right? Don't worry about it— Adora pointed out, trying to comfort her.

After waiting for a bit, the pair of hunters soon appeared, and Castaspella made sure to keep them covered while they slipped into the library without alerting the trainees.

They quietly made it to the back and chose a bookshelf close enough to spy on them without being discovered.

—Alright. Listen: those two were trained with Bow, but they aren't official hunters like him yet— the physician briefly explained. —They don't have proper fighting skills.

—Got it. If they discover me, I can handle them.

—Let's hope they don't.

—In any case, just go and don't worry about me— Adora urged her. —Focus on getting them out.

—Yes, Chief.

She was right.

Better focus and trust her to stay safe while she handled breaking the vampires out.

Cloaked once more, Castaspella managed to open the entrance to the forbidden section just enough that the hunters couldn't notice, and carefully explored her surroundings.

It was *huge*.

Rows and rows of shelves populated the place, and at least a couple of doors could be found both to her right and her left.

She could hear faint voices coming from a room to the further left, one of them she recognized as Bow's, and it made her chest hurt.

She only wanted him away from all of this.

But she had to focus now.

Continuing down the immense place, she soon came across a doorless frame leading to somewhere downstairs, and immediately stopped upon hearing Micah's voice.

—I suppose I'm getting no answers from you— he was saying. —So there's no reason for me to keep you alive.

—*No*— she gasped, breathless, rushing down the stairs. Whoever he meant, she had to stop him. Without hesitation, she got between him and the vampire, exclaiming —Micah, no!

She was fully ready to receive whatever spell he would strike her with… but none came.

Fortunately.

—Casta! What are you…

—I can't let you do this!— the physician interrupted him.

—How did you get here!?— he asked, utterly shocked.

—It doesn't matter. Let them go— she pleaded, hands raised towards him in a pacifying gesture. —You don't want to do this. You *can't* do this!

—They are vampires! *She* is a traitor!— he argued, indignant. —I don't care if she's your partner, she's been using you for blood!

—I told you… to stay safe…— Shadow Weaver breathlessly let out from behind her.

Fighting the urge to turn around, she told Micah —You know *nothing*! *I* was giving it to her!

—You *knew*!?

—I've known for a long while now— she admitted. —And I don't care— she sentenced, frowning. —Vampires aren't monsters. You're not the righteous heroes you believe yourselves to be.

—You don't know what you're talking about— he denied, shaking his head stubbornly. —You have no idea.

—I do, Micah! *I do*! Now let them both go!

—I can't let the girl go, no.

—You're only antagonizing Chief Adora— Castaspella remarked, serious. —You can *forget* about recruiting her *ever* if you do this.

Opening his eyes wide, the King realized —She's here too, isn't she?

—Yes.

—What!?— Catra yelled from her cell, just a few meters away.

—Let them both *go*!— the physician insisted. She then prepared a spell and added —Don't make me force you.

—You'd do this to your own brother.

—Don't you see what *you* are doing!?

Perhaps it was her tone, or how obvious it was that her patience was running thin; whatever it was, Micah finally conceded.

—Fine! I'll- We'll go up there and solve this in a civilized manner, alright?

—As if *you* could be civilized— Catra immediately spat. —I just saw you torture your former Master like she was a stranger!

He did *what*!?

—You- Open that cell now!— Castaspella ordered, pointing at the magicat. —And if you try *anything*, I swear, Brother, not even being family will save you!

She followed him with her gaze for a moment, making sure he would do as she asked, and only then did she kneel in front of Shadow Weaver to check on her.

—You fool…

—Shut up. Don't talk— the physician told her, on the verge of tears. —Can you get up?— she asked, offering her help and trying not to dwell too much on her bloodied face and burnt hands. When the vampire nodded, she helped her up, muttering —I'm getting you back home.

—I'm fine…

—Shush— she insisted. Then, looking back at Catra, who was just leaving the cell, she asked —You aren't hurt, right?

—I am not. Thank you— she nodded. —You said Adora is here?

—She is. And she's very clearly on edge. We need to get back as soon as possible.

—What do we do with him?

Castaspella locked eyes with her brother for a moment before replying —Let him come and see the mess they made.

The four soon made it back to the entrance of the forbidden section and, just as imagined, there she was.

She-Ra.

That was what Shadow Weaver had called her once.

—Adora!— she called out, wanting to get her attention.

—Fuck— the vampire cursed under her breath, hiding back behind the wall.

With a huge effort, Doctor Weaver cast a spell on herself and almost ran out of breath.

—What was that?

—Adora’s passive power, remember?— she asked back with a smirk.

—Right!— Castaspella realized. —Then you have to protect Catra too— she told her. The vampire’s expression said enough, so she begged —Please, Bea.

—Ugh…

—What are you doing?— Catra immediately asked, her hair standing on end, possibly due to the spell. —Why did you…

—It’s to protect you.

—Why!?

—Because your dear fiancée’s mere presence right now is akin to the sun for us…

Chapter End Notes

Ok, first thing I wanna say: This won't end at the library…

I would love theories of how the hunters vs She-Ra will go, but it would also be interesting to know where/how you think this will end! What do you think the aftermath will be!?

I have one more thing to reveal about this fic, but I think I'll only say it in the final notes next week <("^_^)

In any case…
I'm itching to post next week (ahem, first gotta finish writing Casta's part tho lol) and can barely keep myself from spoiling everything hahaha So don't tempt me!

Alright, enough rambling. See you next week!!!

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

I'm writing this about an hour before midnight, in hopes that I'll actually finish editing everything to post before going to sleep.
(Spoiler, I couldn't cause I was falling asleep. So I left it for now, it's about 10am here, when I'm more awake and can better see mistakes lol)
Fr, I feel quite sick, my throat is killing me, and I had to bonk myself into finishing this last chapter in time cause DAMN I wanted to post it without delay!
BUT
I'm sorry to say (maybe it's not a bad thing?) this ended up being over 10k words long <("^_^)
In fact, the first three parts were between 6k and 8k words in total, meaning about 21k long between ch 1 and 9… Wanna know how long ch 10 to 12 are!? 21-freaking-k long!

I'm insane… Could simply have cut everything down into more chapters TT-TT

Anyways

It's the grand finale!!

I'll be (not) so patiently waiting for your impressions ^_^

So, many thanks to withpuppys and Series_Shipper for commenting after every chapter the past few weeks, and ofc to thorn45, one of the firsts to comment, whom I hope will eventually return to read the ending <("^_^) No pressure ofc

Enough rambling!

Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

—Catra— she sighed, relieved to see her well, forgetting everything around her for a moment.

Her attention only returned to reality when the King suddenly grabbed the vampire from behind and dragged her with him to stand between Angella and Adora.

—What the fuck!? Let go of me!— Catra exclaimed, taking a moment too long to use her full strength, having been caught by surprise. —Back off!— she finally growled, breaking free.

—Don’t make me hurt you— Micah warned her, taking out something Adora couldn’t recognize.

—Don’t make *me* hurt you! You have *no idea* how many times I’ve saved your sorry ass, for Glimmer’s sake!— Catra rebuked.

—Enough!— Adora interrupted, pointing her sword at the King. —I won’t let you hurt her. Drop whatever you have in your hands.

—Right— he uttered, opening both hands and letting a small knife fall to the floor. However, his expression soon changed, and he smugly said —But I don’t have to hurt her. You will.

—What!?

—Micah! Don’t you dare!— Castaspella immediately yelled, apparently understanding what he meant. —Adora, your powers!

—It’s what you’re supposed to do, Chief— Angella severely said. —It’s what you’re *meant* to do— she insisted. Then, looking at Shadow Weaver, she added —Isn’t that true? Isn’t that why you convinced us not to recruit her?

Right.

Castaspella had mentioned Doctor Weaver knew.

—You never cared about keeping the secrecy. It was just to save your own skin— the King interceded, his tone acid. —Admit it!

—It is true— the vampire nodded. —Also part of why I’m a *free* vampire— she added, looking at Catra.

—That’s why you aren’t part of the Horde.

—And now you aren’t part of the Alliance anymore— Angella pointed out. —But let us focus on what’s important now: why don’t we settle this in a civilized manner?

—You two are such hypocrites!— Catra angrily spat.

—I can always get rid of the spell protecting you, *miss*— Micah reminded her.

—What!?— Adora let out, confused.

—It’s the only reason why we aren’t charred already— Shadow Weaver promptly explained.

Shit!

Her powers!

That’s what the physician meant.

She had no choice…

Every second she spent as She-Ra, she gave the King an edge.

With a sigh, Adora transformed back and the sword disappeared.

—I reckon I don't need those powers if you *really* intend to solve this diplomatically— she let out, her tone slightly reproaching. —Am I right, your Majesty?

—Of course, Adora— Angella nodded.

—Bullshit!— Catra scoffed, disgusted.

—What did they do to you?

—What they were *going* to do to me, actually— she clarified, briefly looking back. She glared at the King as she reproached him —Will you pretend you weren't gonna burn me with silver and holy water too?

—What!?

—Adora, I had to watch as he did that to his *Master*!— she exclaimed. —"Civilized" my ass!

He had… tortured Doctor Weaver!? *His own Master*!?

Right as she looked back at the vampire, seeking confirmation, both physicians approached, and their grim expressions said enough.

In fact, upon closer inspection, Adora noticed Shadow Weaver looked weaker than she sounded; there was blood on her face, and her hands had fresh scars over the old ones.

—Holy *shit*!— she gasped, shivering at the thought of someone suffering that. Of *Catra* suffering like that. She immediately turned back to the King, drew her gun, and ordered —You're coming with me. I'm charging you with Torture and Illegal Deprivation of Liberty.

—You cannot do that, Chief— Angella calmly replied.

—I can. And I *must*. It's my duty— she sentenced.

That was it. No more games, no more chatter.

Adora was ready to proceed with the arrest of the King, yet an unexpected voice interrupted and called her attention back to the forbidden section's entrance.

—Adora!?

Bow.

Damn it… She had forgotten the pair of trainees that were behind the desk.

They probably went for their fellows while they were distracted.

—Oh, shit— Catra swore, looking away.

The Chief felt her chest tightening and hesitated for a moment, unsure of whether she'd be able to face him if he chose to defend the regents.

However, he only dropped something he was carrying and rushed to them, leaving the others frozen in place.

—What are you doing here!?— he exclaimed, his gaze going from Adora to Catra, and then the King and Queen behind them. —Why…

—You must remember your duty, Bow— Micah warned him, right before Angella gestured at the trainees.

Immediately, she looked back and saw one of them had picked up whatever Bow dropped, and an alarm set off in her head when she recognized it.

—No!— she heard the vampires exclaim, right before he activated that cursed device.

—Fuck!

Bow jumped back just in time to avoid Catra's claws, and right after, a magical barrier enveloped her.

It took Adora a moment to realize Castaspella had contained both vampires within shields.

—Stop this!— the physician pleaded, struggling and looking back at her brother.

But the King didn't make a move, nor did the Queen.

—You need to understand how dangerous they are— Angella insisted. —Bow.

Oh, no.

It was clear what she meant…

Adora could see his conflicted expression when he grabbed the bow and arrows hanging on his back, yet she froze in place, unable to say or do anything.

—I'll do what I have to do— he muttered, pointing at the ground as he loaded an arrow.

She couldn't let him do it, yet she couldn't draw her gun at him either.

She was… stunned.

However…

Before anyone realized, Bow aimed at his fellows and shot.

It was an electrical trick arrow, which accurately hit the device and immediately fried it.

He had chosen his *friends*.

—What have you done!?— the regents exclaimed at the same time, snapping Adora out of her trance.

—That's enough— she sentenced, pointing at them once again, briefly glancing at Catra to make sure she was back to her senses. —I cannot let your hunt continue. You *all* are coming with me, willingly, or I'll return with a whole squad.

—Adora, your powers are meant to *fight* vampires, not *defend them*!— the Queen reproached her, losing her composure.

—*I* get to decide what my powers are for! Now *don't* make me repeat myself!

—Wait! Wait— the King pleaded, appeasingly raising his hands in front of her. —Let us make a deal.

—I have no reasons to accept any deals.

—Just listen— he insisted. —We'll let you all go. Alright? We won't… hunt them down, we *promise* to leave your fiancée in peace, *as long as* you stay out of our way and let us do our *jobs*.

He had to be joking.

That's his proposal!?

—And ignore the manslaughter you have been carrying out for who-knows-how-long!?

—We have the means to eliminate them both right now, no matter what you do— Angella warned her, earning a growl from Catra.

Adora got between them immediately, and noticed in the corner of her eye that Castaspella also stood protectively in front of Shadow Weaver.

She held her gun tighter, keeping her aim on the regents, yet hesitated.

—I…

Could she really do it?

A tense silence settled for a moment, and the more it stretched, the higher her anxiety went.

Perhaps she *should* accept the deal?

Gulping nervously just thinking about losing Catra, she closed her eyes and got ready to accept…

Yet a tickling sensation enveloped her out of nowhere, and she heard —Enough!

It was magic.

Something that looked like electricity suddenly knocked everyone out, and she turned around in time to see Doctor Weaver almost pass out.

—Bea!— Castaspella exclaimed, catching her before she hit the ground.

—I'm fine— she groaned.

She rendered them all unconscious!?

Looking around, Adora confirmed they were all out, and put her gun back in her holster.

—Well, shit— Catra breathlessly laughed. —That was close.

—You're welcome— the vampire mockingly said, managing to stand up on her own.

The Chief sighed in relief and exchanged a glance with Bow, nodding respectfully at him, glad it was over.

She breathed easy… until an unexpected voice called her attention, startling her.

—Mom! Dad!

—Glimmer!?

Bow, Catra, and Adora reacted immediately.

—What happened here!?

—Glim…— he uttered, unsure what to say. —It's…

—It's a lot to explain— Castaspella interceded, probably noticing he was too ashamed to speak.

—Auntie, *what* happened!?— she insisted, after rushing to her parents and realizing they were only knocked out.

The physician opened her mouth to reply, yet Shadow Weaver interrupted her —Let her friends tell her. We have *other* things to do.

—What do you mean?— Adora asked, confused.

—Making a deal with them won't protect your fiancée. Wiping everyone's memory, on the other hand, surely will— she ominously answered. —You all probably have a lot to talk about, don't you?

Right…

She didn't wait for a reply and simply left with Castaspella, both using spells to carry the group of hunter trainees back into the forbidden section.

The four were left in utter silence.

—So!?— the princess finally asked, indignant.

Just *what* could they say? And *how*!?

Adora and Catra looked back at Bow, conflicted.

Perhaps he had to begin.

Revealing he had been lying to her was *his* duty.

—I'm sorry, Glimmer— he eventually spoke. —We have been… lying to you. Your parents… *me*…

—About what!? Why are they passed out!?

—Because they wanted to kill Catra— he bluntly said.

—What!?

—I'm… a vampire, Sparkles. And they are vampire hunters.

—You're joking…

—It's the truth, Glimmer— Adora assured her, sorrowful. —That's why we didn't want to go to the palace…

—But- No, it's impossible!— she denied, shaking her head. —Vampires aren't real!

—We are— Catra insisted. —I don't know why they didn't tell you, though.

—Be-because… Glimmer's powers can kill vampires on the spot, but they are too flashy and would call civilians' attention— Bow shyly explained. —Or that's what Doctor Weaver said.

—I don't… understand— the princess uttered, grabbing her head. —They really wanted to kill one of my friends!? Were *you* going to do that, Bow!?

—No!— he promptly replied. —I would *never*! I-I even destroyed my own device just earlier!

—*Your device*!?— Catra exclaimed. —You made those infernal gadgets!? I-I almost killed Adora because of that thing!

—I'm so sorry! I had no idea! They- I was told it was to expose vampires, make you act erratic, and…

—To have a reason to hunt us! Don't you see, Arrow Boy!?

—I do now…

—What matters is that he stood with us— Adora interceded, trying to calm down her fiancée. —Now, we have to focus, alright? Doctor Weaver will wipe everyone's memories, meaning

they won't know this happened.

—So you have to promise not to tell your parents that you know, Sparkles.

—Right… Pretend I don't know, *sure*. How hard can it be?— Glimmer let out, laughing nervously.

—It'll be alright, Glim. I swear— Bow told her, stepping closer to comfort her.

Right then, they heard steps approaching and the four looked back at the women who returned from the forbidden section.

—All trainees' memories have been erased and there are no other hunters currently here— Doctor Weaver announced. —Only the Regents are left.

—And we got rid of all the evidence they had of either her or Catra being vampires, so you should be safe— Castaspella added. —We just have to leave Angella and Micah somewhere inside the forbidden section to avoid suspicions, so…

—Will they be alright?— Glimmer asked, frowning in concern.

—Of course, Dear— her aunt assured her, keeping the princess from watching as Doctor Weaver wiped her parents' memories.

Unsure of what to say, Chief Adora remained silent and only approached Catra to hug her tightly. After a moment, they watched as the physicians took the regents into the forbidden section as they said, and waited for their return.

The silence was unbearable, but none of them dared break it.

—Now…— Doctor Weaver began, as soon as they were back. —I should probably erase your memory too, young man— she told Bow, who immediately went pale. Glimmer's seemingly instinctive reaction was to grab his arm, afraid, yet none of them said a word. —However…— she then clarified, apparently having changed her mind. —If you *really* want to do what's best for your future wife, then I have a proposal— she explained. —It's highly unlikely that Chief Adora will manage to prosecute the whole organization, much as she wants, so we both should *remain* here and dismantle it from the inside.

—You… want me to help you undermine the hunters?

—Correct.

—But I can't let them continue with this as if I didn't know!— Adora quickly reacted. —The-the King tortured you!

—While it's not impossible, subjecting the Queen to a trial will be close to unattainable, Chief.

—But…

—Trust us, Adora— Bow interrupted her. —I will do it— he told the vampire. —I'll… handle everything here. When they wake up, I can tell them we had captured, uh, some vampires that were sorcerers, and they… they knocked everyone out except you and me. I'll tell them you are after their tracks.

—Clever. I approve— Doctor Weaver replied, smirking. —I suppose I can say I lost their trail on the way to Salineas… That should do the trick.

—Ah… Alright. I'll let you do it— Adora accepted. —But I'll try to gather evidence of their crimes and find a way to file charges against them— she insisted.

—As you wish— the vampire conceded. —We should go now.

—Yes— Bow agreed. —You better leave before they wake up.

The physicians slowly made their way to the door, probably because of Doctor Weaver's weakened state, and Adora gave Catra a look, silently asking if they should go too.

She nodded at her yet took a moment to say —Thanks, Arrow Boy.

—Anytime.

As they turned to leave, they could still hear the princess and her fiancé.

—Can I stay with you?— Glimmer asked him.

—Only if you teleport away before anyone can see you.

—Alright.

On their way home, Adora attempted to start a conversation a few times, yet Catra remained silent.

She couldn't blame her…

Not after that.

Catra had admitted to sabotaging Hordak's traps for King Micah, to keep him safe… Yet *he was ready* to kill her- No, worse.

He was ready to make *Adora* kill her…

Now she wanted nothing more than to put the regents on trial and in jail.

They didn't deserve the risks Catra had taken for them.

And now…

What would they do?

What would Glimmer and Bow do?

Where did they four stand now?

Adora opened the door for Catra once they arrived, slowly closed it, and gently took her to the sofa.

—Should I prepare something for you? A drink?

—I'm… not sure. I don't… know what I want— she replied, her voice a bit broken.

—I'll make your favourite then— Adora decided, rushing to the kitchen to quickly fix a pair of drinks. Once back in the lounge, she sat next to Catra and handed her the drink, saying —Here…

Her fiancée accepted it and immediately wrapped her tail around Adora's hip. Quietly, she took two sips and rested her head back on the couch.

—Dor… I…— she hesitantly began, trailing off. —I don't know how to say it.

—Take your time, Love.

—Alright— she sighed, taking a longer sip this time. —I just can't… get those screams out of my head— she finally managed to say.

—Screams?

—Do-Doctor Weaver's… Which is saying *a lot*.

—What do you mean?— she calmly asked, gently caressing the tip of Catra's tail.

—We're talking about a woma- I mean, a *vampire* who's proud to a fault— she explained. —She began snarky and cocky. She assured him no torture would make her speak, that she isn't one of the weaklings they usually catch… It was actually- I mean, there's a reason I always disliked her— Catra went on, looking into her drink. After another sip, she concluded —But even if she bore a lot of pain without breaking… ultimately, she screamed too.

—I'm sorry you had to watch that— Adora immediately let out, sorrowful. —I'd never let that happen to you…

—I know… But it could have. I mean- I-if you and Castaspella hadn't arrived in time, I would have- I'd have seen the King *kill her* and then… I'd suffer the same.

—Don't even think about that.

—I could have died tonight!— she finally yelled, admitting the realization she was probably trying to avoid. —At the cell or later, o-outside… if he- if he removed the spell against sunlight…

—*I* would have killed you…

Shaking her head, Catra bent over, downed the rest of her drink, and set the glass on the stand closest to her, coughing a bit.

—Dor, why would they- why would they do that!?

Adora caught her fiancée in a tight embrace and held her close to her chest as she sobbed, while holding back tears of her own.

—I don't know, Love… I wish I knew…

—How the fuck am I supposed to sleep now?— Catra whined, making Adora's heart shrink in sorrow. —I can still hear those screams… I can't even explain how-how *mortifying* it is to hear someone like her *scream*…

—Why?

—Because- I-I mean… She was- Like, she kept taunting him, defying him. It's obvious she trusted he wouldn't dare hurt her, yet he *did*— Catra began. —He said he felt betrayed and almost- I think he was on the verge of tears. He couldn't believe it at first, and burning her with silver and holy water was… At first, it was just to prove it *was* true, that she's a vampire. But then… it's like something took over him, and he began… torturing her for real.

—Catra…

—I think I could see the exact moment when she realized he would do it…— she went on, pulling away from Adora's embrace to hug her legs against her chest instead. —It was when he grabbed those silver knuckles to punch her in the face— she finally said. With a scoff, she admitted —How long have *I* wanted to do that, though…

—Love… You don't have to- Are you sure you want to do this now?

—Yeah… You always say witnesses have to be questioned right away while the memory is still fresh, no?

—You're not a witness in this case, Catra, and you're not being questioned— Adora pointed out. —Even if I wanted to take your testimony for the case against them, I can't- I can't do it under the circumstances…

—Then just listen to me… *please*— she pleaded. —Perhaps- I hope letting it all out might help me sleep a bit…

—Of course, of course— she promptly nodded, embracing Catra, who put her legs down and leant into Adora's embrace.

—At some point, I began wondering whether Doctor Weaver is insane, or if the pain had driven her mad, maybe…— she started again. —While the King kept repeating that she was making him do it because she wouldn't cooperate… she only laughed, loudly, asking what happened with "we aren't monsters like them"…

—He really…

—Doctor Weaver reproached him for his disgust for the Butcher Brothers' methods, you know, slaughtering vampires, but then torturing her like he didn't know her… And you know what!? I *never* felt that much fear before. He pressed silver knives against her skin, splashed her hands with holy water, punched her face with the silver knuckles… If he- I-if he could do that to someone so close to him… what would he have done to *me*!?

Catra cried for hours after that.

At some point, resting on Adora's lap, she stopped; the Chief thought she had fallen asleep.

However, she soon wondered —What will I tell my Boss?

—*We* should tell him everything.

—You- But…

—Trust me, alright? I need to speak with him.

—Then… what will we tell him?

—We… explain everything that happened tonight, try to come up with some… plan, or whatever, and… with some luck we'll avoid any more bloodshed.

—Alright— Catra sighed.

—Perhaps… let me talk, alright? He doesn't know me, so… I reckon I'll have to win his trust, and I mean on my own.

—But I'll still be there.

—Of course, Love.

Calmer, the vampire took a deep breath, looked back at her fiancée, and sighed —I love you…

The following day, after a quick breakfast, the couple arrived at the court quite early in the morning.

—Oh, you're here too— Adora noticed, shortly after arriving with Catra. The physicians were there… —Have you come to speak with Judge Hordak?

—That's right— Castaspella nervously smiled. —It's quite a relief to see you here!

She was probably dying of anxiety right now.

Perhaps it'd be a good idea to reassure her.

—That's good. But… you have nothing to fear, alright?

—Yeah, he's actually pretty reasonable— Catra supported, sounding surprised to be saying that.

—I'm sure, of course— she nodded, looking away.

—Don't waste your energy. She won't calm down— Shadow Weaver interceded. —I've been trying all morning…

—Why are you so nervous, though?— Catra asked, confused. —Like a month ago, he *told you* that you have his respect.

—Yes, but… I don't even know what I did to deserve it, and I'm- Well, I suppose I fear losing that respect…

—Oh, right— Adora sighed. —I'm sure there's no need to worry, really— she insisted, smiling gently.

—Agreed— her fiancée nodded.

Before anyone could say anything else, a young woman approached them.

That was probably one of Catra's coworkers…

A vampire too? Maybe?

Perhaps just a blood slave?

Neither?

—Ahem… Judge Hordak will receive you now— she solemnly said, extracting the Chief from her thoughts. —A couple at a time, though. So, who's going first?

The women exchanged silent glances for a moment until Adora, noticing Castaspella's hesitation, suggested —Why don't we go first so you get ready?

—O-oh, alright. Yes, thank you— the physician quickly agreed.

—We're going then. Thanks, Lonnie— Catra told her.

They both followed her to a pair of large wooden doors at the back of the main hall of the court, and she opened for them. Once they walked in, Lonnie closed from outside.

—Ah, be welcome— Judge Hordak received them. Gesturing at the seats in front of his desk, he added —Please, make yourselves comfortable.

—Wow… the big boss being polite is a rare sight— Catra whispered to Adora, snickering.

Holding back a laugh of her own, the Chief cleared her throat and replied —Thank you, Judge.

—I have been informed about the… unfortunate incident you had to deal with last night— he began, joining his hands in front of him over the desk. —While I'm pleased to know all pertinent evidence has been destroyed, I have to think the hunters will eventually gather the necessary information to reach the same conclusions they did before… Isn't that why you're here?

—That may be part of it, yes— Adora nodded.

—Catra?

—We don't know *how* they discovered me, so we have no way to prevent it from happening again, Boss. But…

—But I want to offer my help to the- to the Horde. I want to make sure no more vampires are hurt— she completed, after exchanging a glance with Catra, who held her hand tightly. —I can't stop the Alliance on my own, not the right way, and-and…

—Can I show you something, Chief?— Hordak interrupted, smiling ominously at her.

—Su-sure— she agreed, hesitant.

She gave Catra a questioning look, yet the vampire seemed just as clueless.

Seeing him stand up and approach one of the bookshelves, Adora considered standing up yet only did so when he gestured at her to approach.

—Can you read this?— he asked.

Adora carefully inspected the ancient-looking plaque taking over the space of at least five regular-sized books, and realized, much to her surprise, that she could read this language she had no idea even existed.

—*Fidem et Proditionem*— she read aloud. —This says… it's a prophecy of sorts.

—Correct. It is— he nodded. —One that has been fulfilled before, and shall come to pass once more, soon enough…

—What? I- How can a prophecy…

—I wish I had an answer to that question, Chief, but I do not. I can, however, explain what it means…

—Please, Judge.

He gestured in the desk's general direction, quietly suggesting they sit down again, Adora reckoned, and they returned with Catra.

—So, as I said, this prophecy I just showed you has been fulfilled before, Chief, by none other than your predecessor… and *me*.

—You knew Mara?

How!?

—Indeed— he nodded, once again letting out an ominous smile. —"*Fidem et Proditionem*" is a fitting name for this prophecy, since it speaks about loyalty and treason— he began explaining. —Centuries ago, Mara incarnated loyalty, *Fides*, against an enemy that should have wiped out Etheria. I presume you know the story…

—Yes, the great threat she fended off.

—Precisely. However, what you may not know, is that I incarnated treason, *Proditio*, against that same enemy. *Horde Prime*.

—He…

—He created me— Hordak interrupted. —I am a clone of his, the last remnant of the ancient threat… A vulture like he was.

—I see— Adora nodded, pensive. —But how does that work? Why do you say Mara incarnated loyalty and you, treason?

—To put it simply, Chief, Mara was loyal to Etheria, to her people, and the mortals. In the same way, I only betrayed Horde Prime, my creator and my people, by allowing his defeat and abandoning his mission.

—I think I understand— she sighed, holding Catra's hand again. —So… how can it be fulfilled again? Horde Prime is no more, right?

—That much is true, yet this generation faces the same decision both Mara and I did back then— he insisted. —However, the protagonists, this time, will be you and that curious physician…

—That's why you have me protect her? To fulfill a prophecy?— Catra realized.

—She's key to it, yes— he confirmed. —I must admit, however, that I first thought she would be *Proditio* like I was, since it's a most logical conclusion to make that Adora, as Mara's descendant, shall be *Fides*…

—But?

—*But* I have noticed lately that both of you have equal chances of incarnating either.

—What does that *mean*?

This made no sense!

Or… did it?

—Seeing you as loyalty is simple: you're loyal to your morals, your beliefs, your friends, your partner… However, you *betray* the very essence of your powers and heritage, which are meant to eliminate vampires— Hordak further explained.

—Right…

—Meanwhile, I reckoned Castaspella's actions should be considered treason since she betrays her own brother and, centuries ago, would have been accused of betraying her kind too— he went on, serious. —Yet "betrayal" itself isn't why she does it. It isn't a conscious decision like I made, to go against my creator, or like you make to go against the purpose of your powers. No… Her treason is but a consequence of her loyalty to her partner too, to her morals, and her repudiation of the hunt's actions.

—She doesn't mean to betray anyone, she simply has no choice if she wishes to remain loyal. Is that what you mean, Judge?— Adora reflected.

—I knew you would understand, Chief— he smiled, pleased. He seemed about to add something else, yet his ears twitched as he paused for a second. With a low chuckle, he finally concluded —And it seems she's about to take the final step in what shall be considered "treason" despite being an act of sheer loyalty.

So he was… listening to the couple outside!? *From here*!?

—Last step? What do you mean? What will- What is Castaspella going to do?

—Yes. What will she do, indeed…— he calmly laughed again. —She wishes to become a vampire too— he revealed.

Adora and Catra looked at each other speechless, in utter shock.

She would really do that!?

—Judge…

—Let us return to what concerns *us*, Chief. What will *you* do?— he asked, solemn. —Merely transforming into She-Ra can *and will* kill any of my vampires if they aren't protected enough. Your powers, in fact, can exterminate us all, no matter what they do; even me, a vulture immune to sunlight…

Of course…

Her powers, tailored to kill those like her fiancée…

What will she do?

That's a great question…

—I know what I will do— Adora eventually replied, determined. —I swear I'll find a way to take down the Alliance, *without* using She-Ra, and by the proper means. I refuse to act like the hunters— she promised. —If I have to be Treason, then so be it.

Castaspella

—What are you doing? Why did you…

—It's to protect you— Shadow Weaver briskly replied.

—Why!?

—Because your dear fiancée's mere presence right now is akin to the sun for us…

Castaspella let out a sigh, frustrated.

What a way of learning that Adora's powers are a threat to her.

Couldn't she be a bit more gentle?

Her words of reproach died in her throat as her brother suddenly pushed past them, dragging Catra along.

—Micah!— she reacted, frozen in place by the conflicted feelings tightening her chest.

What the heck was he doing!?

Why was he doing this!?

How could he!?

And he *really* believes himself to be the good guy!?

Using a young woman, vampire or not, as some sort of leverage… *how* could he possibly justify this!?

—What the fuck!? Let go of me! Back off!— she growled, breaking free.

—Don't make me hurt you.

Castaspella's eyes went wide as she recognized the silver dagger he took out, and flashbacks of the dead Butcher Brothers overwhelmed her.

—Don't make *me* hurt you! You have *no idea* how many times I've saved your sorry ass, for Glimmer's sake!— Catra yelled back, extracting her from the memory.

She had been keeping Micah safe!?

The more she knew, the worse her feelings got.

How could she keep calling him her brother… when she hardly recognized this heartless man?

—Enough! I won't let you hurt her. Drop whatever you have in your hands— Adora promptly interrupted.

—Right. But I don't have to hurt her. You will.

—What!?

That damned son of a…

—Micah! Don't you dare!— Castaspella exclaimed. She didn't even waste time debating whether he could really remove Shadow Weaver's protection spell or not. Everything that had been happening was telling enough: he *would*, without a moment of hesitation. So she immediately warned —Adora, your powers!

—It's what you're supposed to do, Chief. It's what you're *meant* to do— Angella severely told her. Then, looking at Shadow Weaver, she added —Isn't that true? Isn't that why you convinced us not to recruit her?

It was no surprise she could put two and two together so easily, yet it was enraging.

How could she reproach the vampire as if *she* were the one at fault!?

Shadow Weaver did a *lot* of awful things, but keeping them from recruiting Adora is probably the *only* good thing she did without someone else begging for it…

—You never cared about keeping the secrecy. It was just to save your own skin. Admit it!— Micah added, with a tone that sent chills down Castaspella's spine.

No… he was not her brother…

He was not the man with whom she grew up.

Just a stranger sharing her blood.

Her attention then turned to Shadow Weaver as she solemnly admitted —It is true. Also part of why I'm a *free* vampire.

—That's why you aren't part of the Horde.

—And now you aren't part of the Alliance anymore— Angella pointed out, saying it as if it were some sort of disgrace… Good fucking riddance! Castaspella's body tensed with anger, yet it was soon replaced by utter disbelief as the Queen casually said —But let us focus on what's important now: why don't we settle this in a civilized manner?

—You two are such hypocrites!

Catra was *so* right.

How could Angella keep a straight face while saying that, as if they weren't literally threatening to kill the vampire!?

How shameless could they be!?

The answer soon came, as Micah explicitly threatened —I can always get rid of the spell protecting you, *miss*.

—What!?

—It's the only reason why we aren't charred already— Shadow Weaver promptly explained.

It seemed like Adora had forgotten; the situation was dire, after all…

With a sigh, the Chief transformed back and the sword disappeared.

It was her only choice…

—I reckon I don't need those powers if you *really* intend to solve this diplomatically. Am I right, your Majesty?

—Of course, Adora.

Castaspella's nails were digging into her palms now, but a hand on her shoulder promptly distracted her and dissipated her rage.

Shadow Weaver silently gestured at her to follow, and she complied while attentive to the argument stalling the inevitable.

—Bullshit!— Catra scoffed, disgusted.

—What did they do to you?

—What they were *going* to do to me, actually— she clarified, briefly looking at Adora. She meant the torture, of course. Glaring at Micah, the vampire reproached him —Will you pretend you weren't gonna burn me with silver and holy water too?

—What!?

—Adora, I had to watch as he did that to his *Master*!— she exclaimed. —"Civilized" my ass!

Castaspella glanced at Shadow Weaver's hands without thinking, and her chest tightened in pain again.

About a month before, she had told Catra that she couldn't pretend Micah isn't her brother, but… *this*!? It was impossible to overlook; blood-relationship be damned!

—Holy *shit*!— Adora immediately reacted, her sight on Shadow Weaver as they both finally joined them. —You're coming with me. I'm charging you with Torture and Illegal Deprivation of Liberty— she sentenced, having drawn her gun.

The physician looked down, shaking her head slightly.

They deserved it.

All of them…

All the hunters, even the trainees.

Which reminded her of the pair they had followed inside.

Castaspella looked back at the desk for a moment and cursed under her breath as they weren't there.

Had they gone for the others!?

Oh, no…

Bow!

—You cannot do that, Chief— Angella calmly replied.

—I can. And I *must*. It's my duty— she heard Adora counter, right as the group of trainees rushed out of the forbidden section.

And the one leading the group was none other than the young archer…

—Adora!?

—Oh, shit— Catra swore, looking away.

Castaspella gasped and instinctively grabbed Shadow Weaver's arm, her heart hammering in her chest.

He dropped something he was carrying and rushed to his friends, leaving his fellows frozen in place.

Would they dare do something?

—What are you doing here!? Why…

—You must remember your duty, Bow— she heard Micah tell him.

Castaspella was about to turn back and reproach him, but one of the trainees suddenly rushed to pick up what Bow had dropped: could it be the thing Shadow Weaver told her about? The one that made her attack her that fateful night?

It had to be, since both vampires immediately exclaimed —No!

—Fuck!

The physician couldn't even think.

She cast a pair of shields, not around her or the Chief and Bow, but rather around Shadow Weaver and Catra, trapping them.

It was the only way.

Were they *insane*!?

They could have caused Catra to kill Bow!? He *barely* escaped her claws, jumping back right in time!

—Stop this!— she pleaded, struggling to keep up the shields and looking back at Micah.

But he didn't make a move, nor did the Queen.

—You need to understand how dangerous they are— Angella insisted. Then, with a commanding tone, she simply said —Bow.

The order was implicit…

Gasping from the effort, Castaspella could still see how he prepared an arrow while the Chief remained frozen in place.

Adora wouldn't stop him…

Any more pressure against the shields would break them…

Pointing at the ground, he seemed to mutter something before raising to aim for the trainees instead. And before anyone could react, an electric arrow had fried the device.

He chose his friends…

Castaspella let the shields fall, exhausted, and glanced back at Micah just as he and Angella exclaimed —What have you done!?

That seemed to snap Adora out of her trance, and she once again pointed her gun at them.

—That's enough— she sentenced, briefly glancing at Catra, who was back to her senses. —I cannot let your hunt continue. You *all* are coming with me, willingly, or I'll return with a whole squad.

Please do!

—Adora, your powers are meant to *fight* vampires, not *defend them*!— the Queen reproached her, finally losing her composure.

—*I* get to decide what my powers are for! Now *don't* make me repeat myself!

—Wait! Wait— Micah pleaded, appeasingly raising his hands in front of her. Scared now, huh? —Let us make a deal.

—I have no reasons to accept any deals.

—Just listen— he insisted. —We'll let you all go. Alright? We won't… hunt them down, we *promise* to leave your fiancée in peace, *as long as* you stay out of our way and let us do our *jobs*.

He had to be joking.

Desperate or not, he couldn't *really* think she would accept…

—And ignore the manslaughter you have been carrying out for who-knows-how-long!?

Exactly!

—We have the means to eliminate them both right now, no matter what you do— Angella warned her, earning a growl from Catra.

Like they would allow that!

Castaspella immediately moved protectively in front of Shadow Weaver, whom she could see was still weakened by the *torture*, and Adora probably thought the same as she got between Catra and the regents, keeping her aim on them.

Yet she… hesitated.

—I…

She couldn't be *considering it*, right!?

It would be…

Ah…

It would be the only way to keep them *safe*.

But there had to be *some other way*!

Castaspella looked back at Shadow Weaver, seeking her help, yet the vampire had her eyes closed and frowned as if concentrating hard.

Soon, something that looked like electricity reached all the hunters, and knocked them out the second the vampire exclaimed —Enough!

—Bea!— Castaspella exclaimed, barely catching her before she hit the ground, her heart skipping a beat as she seemed about to pass out.

—I'm fine— she groaned.

That fool…

It was right in time, but… damn it, she pushed herself too far!

Yet her stubbornness knows no limits, and she didn't wait to have recovered enough before struggling to get up.

—Well, shit— Catra breathlessly laughed. —That was close.

—You're welcome— the vampire mockingly said, managing to stand up on her own.

The Chief sighed in relief and exchanged a glance with Bow, nodding respectfully at him.

They all looked at ease now… It was over.

They could breathe…

For a moment, albeit brief, until an unexpected voice called their attention, even startling the Chief, whose hand reached up for her gun.

—Mom! Dad!

—Glimmer!?

Bow, Catra, and Adora reacted immediately.

—What happened here!?

—Glim…— he uttered, unsure what to say. This wouldn't be easy. —It's…

—It's a lot to explain— Castaspella interceded, supposing he was too ashamed to speak.

The princess rushed to her parents, realized they were only knocked out, and insisted —Auntie, *what* happened!?

The physician opened her mouth to reply, yet Shadow Weaver interrupted her —Let her friends tell her. We have *other* things to do.

—What do you mean?— Adora asked, confused.

—Making a deal with them won't protect your fiancée. Wiping everyone's memory, on the other hand, surely will— she ominously answered, making Castaspella roll her eyes. Goodness… No need to make it sound like *that*! —You all probably have a lot to talk about, don't you?

Of course they do…

Shadow Weaver didn't wait for a reply. She just gestured at the physician, and they both cast levitation spells to carry the group of hunter trainees back into the forbidden section.

—Follow me— Castaspella told her, aiming for that room to the left where she had heard them earlier.

The room was quite simple: a table, some chairs, cupboard and shelves stashed with snacks… Nothing fancy.

—Ah, yes, leaving them here is quite smart; they will think they only fell asleep while awaiting orders— the vampire nodded. Once they accommodated the seven trainees on the chairs, she proceeded to wipe their minds one by one.

—Please make sure they also forget Catra, alright?

—Sure— she sighed, rolling her eyes. —Go find whatever hard evidence they might have on the girl and me in the meantime— she then suggested.

Right.

Good idea.

But where to begin…

Anywhere, as long as she does it *fast*!

The physician had no idea how they handled evidence, where they stored it, and Doctor Weaver wasn't being of much help…

But she had observed them for so long! There had to be a way of finding this!

Well, this *was* a library, after all… maybe the shelves back there are organized like the ones outside?

It took her a bit to find everything, yet once Castaspella figured out the system, just like with the "code" the hunters used for their written orders, it was all pretty easy! She got rid of a few documents, some rumours records that probably tipped Catra's cover off, and the copy of the same order the physician had first deciphered.

No evidence remained…

—There's no one else back here, so we're just missing Micah and Angella— she told Shadow Weaver, once they reunited. —And I got rid of all the compromising records they had.

—Good. Then we should return for the regents now… Better bring them in here, lest someone finds them "asleep" out there.

Right…

Once they had their memories wiped, they would be safe…

Castaspella took a deep breath as she followed Doctor Weaver out of the forbidden section, and stepped out right in time to hear Catra warning Glimmer —So you have to promise not to tell your parents that you know, Sparkles.

—Right… Pretend I don't know, *sure*. How hard can it be?— Glimmer let out, laughing nervously.

—It'll be alright, Glim. I swear— Bow told her, stepping closer to comfort her.

Right after, they all looked back at them, so Shadow Weaver proudly announced —All trainees' memories have been erased and there are no other hunters currently here. Only the Regents are left.

—And we got rid of all the evidence they had of either her or Catra being vampires, so you should be safe— Castaspella added, giving them a gentle look. —We just have to leave Angella and Micah somewhere inside the forbidden section to avoid suspicions, so…

—Will they be alright?— Glimmer asked, frowning in concern.

—Of course, Dear— Castaspella assured her, stopping by her side and keeping her from watching as Doctor Weaver wiped her parents' memories.

Once done, a tense silence settled.

The physicians used spells like before to take Micah and Angella into the forbidden section, and left them in a room at the back.

—They sometimes come here to take a break, it's the most inconspicuous place they could have fallen asleep in…

—Whatever you say— Castaspella replied, unable to hide how unwell she felt.

—Good.

With that settled, she followed the vampire back outside and let her handle the rest.

—Now…— Doctor Weaver began. —I should probably erase your memory too, young man — she told Bow, who immediately went pale while Glimmer grabbed his arm, probably afraid. —However…— she then said, with a mischievous tone Castaspella knew well. —If you *really* want to do what's best for your future wife, then I have a proposal— she explained. —It's highly unlikely that Chief Adora will manage to prosecute the whole organization, much as she wants, so we both should *remain* here and dismantle it from the inside.

—You… want me to help you undermine the hunters?

—Correct.

—But I can't let them continue with this as if I didn't know!— Adora quickly reacted. —The-the King tortured you!

She couldn't agree more with her! But, convincing Shadow Weaver… well, that's simply unfeasible.

—While it's not impossible, subjecting the Queen to a trial will be close to unattainable, Chief.

—But…

—Trust us, Adora— Bow interrupted her. —I will do it— he told the vampire. —I'll… handle everything here. When they wake up, I can tell them we had captured, uh, some vampires that were sorcerers and they… they knocked everyone out except you and me. I'll tell them you are after their tracks.

—Clever. I approve— Doctor Weaver replied, smirking. —I suppose I can say I lost their trail on the way to Salineas… That should do the trick.

—Ah… Alright. I'll let you do it— Adora accepted. —But I'll try to gather evidence of their crimes and find a way to file charges against them— she insisted.

—As you wish— the vampire conceded. Then, with a look at Castaspella, she suggested — We should go now.

—Yes— Bow agreed. —You better leave before they wake up.

Hesitant, the physician offered Shadow Weaver some help, noticing the use of magic had weakened her even more, and they slowly made their way out.

—We can go to my place— Castaspella suggested, once outside. —It's closer, and we don't have to worry about the broken door.

—What happened with my door?— the vampire asked, suspicious.

—I fixed it as much as I could, but I can't really trust it's enough…

—Right. I suppose… I can check it tomorrow— she sighed, resigned. —Can you teleport us, or…

—You shouldn't keep exerting yourself— Castaspella quickly interrupted. —I'll try to teleport us, yeah— she nodded.

It took her a few attempts and some corrections but, eventually, they appeared in the physician's small apartment.

—I need to lay down— the vampire sighed, using the last of her strength, it seemed, to reach the bed.

—I'll extract some blood for you…— she decided, refusing to acknowledge the messy feelings fighting within her. She sat in silence for a while, alone in the kitchen, drew about a hundred milliliters, and once patched up, she returned with Shadow Weaver, who opened her eyes as soon as she reached the bed. —Here…

Humming, the vampire downed the bowl with ease, returned it to her, and rested back on the pillow while Castaspella took it to the kitchen.

The sound of her steps made the silence all the more unbearable, so the physician tried to think of something to say, *anything*…

But what could be said?

—Will you stand there all night?— Doctor Weaver suddenly asked, making her realize she was standing in the door frame between the kitchen and the main room.

—I… don't know… what else to do. I don't want to bother you but…

—Right— she smirked. —In a three-room apartment, there aren't many options— she breathlessly laughed.

—Are you *seriously* going to start with that again? *Now*!?— Castaspella indignantly asked. —I-I know it's strange *not* having a bedroom, but this place has always been for *me* alone! As long as I can sleep comfortably, I don't care *where* the bed is!

—I can't believe I was missing your verbosity— the vampire snickered, making an effort to sit up.

—You just… said that to make me talk?

—And it worked— she smirked again. —Come here…

Castaspella let out a long sigh, approached and sat next to her.

—Is it that obvious?

—That this whole deal affected you more than me? Yes.

—Bea… I-I'm sorry you have to… I mean, *I* should be comforting you, not the other way around…

—Forget that— she dismissively said. —I'm unwilling to revisit what happened tonight, anyways…

—But you should- Don't you think speaking about it can help, maybe?

—Help with what? The trauma? There's no "trauma" I can't simply erase from my mind— Shadow Weaver assured her, rolling her eyes.

—Bea, don't do that— she pleaded, taking her hands. Feeling the uneven skin under her fingers suddenly reminded her —Let me clean up your wounds, and then we'll… talk. If not for you, then do it for me…

—Ah… As you wish.

After a long while inside the small bathroom, where Castaspella made the vampire take a bath and helped her wash away the filth of the hunter's cell, they returned to the main room and sat on the bed again.

—It's a good thing you heal so quickly… but the cuts on your face are taking a while— the young physician noticed. —What did he do to you?

—Nothing…

—Beatrix, I'm *seeing* your skin torn open on your left cheek and between your brows! Did he hit you!? Cut you!? *What* happened!?

—Why do you want to know?— she asked back, sounding tired.

—I'm already beyond love and hate regarding Micah. I don't care anymore about him, but I care about *you*. So, can you *please* tell me?

—You just want me to speak about it… Didn't I say…

—I *know* what you said— Castaspella interrupted. —But I can't bear the idea of you stubbornly bottling it all up… Trust me.

—I trust you. But you don't need that picture of your brother…

—Nothing you can tell me can be worse than what I imagine— she insisted, looking down with a somber expression. —I can only see him wickedly beating you, and I…— she tried to say, but interrupted herself to swallow hard. —I'm… so disgusted…

—Ah… Alright— Shadow Weaver sighed. —He hit me with silver knuckles. That's why I bled. Those are polished, so no silver remains in my skin, but it will still take some time for the cuts to fully close.

—Why hit you?— Castaspella asked, holding herself tightly and looking away. —For information? For… vengeance?

—I kept provoking him. He got fed up and punched me a few times— the vampire finally explained. —I must admit I didn't think he would…

—Even if he felt betrayed… I can't believe he did that.

—It's what I taught him. Can't blame anyone but myself— Shadow Weaver scoffed.

—What about burning your hands? Why use both silver and holy water?

—Once again, I provoked him. The first attempts were actually to "prove" I'm a vampire because he couldn't believe it. Then came the knuckles. And back to burning me again… He wanted "information", *anything*, didn't really have anything specific to ask— she replied. —So I mocked his pathetic attempt at an interrogation. When he took out the silver knives, I

thought he'd threaten to kill me but, instead, he pressed them against my hands and demanded "answers"— she went on. —Like I said, he didn't ask any questions, so I reckon my "answers" weren't what he expected.

—Why anger him on purpose? He could have killed you before I arrived! What did you say, Bea?— Castaspella inquired, sorrowful.

—I told him you'd be disappointed in him… And that he's as guilty as me; as much of a threat to humanity as me. That's when he used the holy water, arguing only monsters sizzle and burn…— Doctor Weaver concluded.

—I'm sorry I couldn't arrive sooner— the young woman let out, her voice broken. She hugged herself tighter and shrank a bit as she sobbed —I'm so sorry.

—I told you *not* to do anything foolish and to remain *safe*— the vampire reminded her. —At the very least, you took precautions when completely ignoring that, so you can save the apology— she added, probably trying to sound funny. But Castaspella was in tears, shaking, sinking into a pit of sorrow… After what felt like an eternity, she felt a hand on her back, comfortingly caressing up and down, and an unusually gentle tone brought her back to reality, saying —Casta. You saved me. And that magicat girl. You have *nothing* to apologize for.

Still trembling, the physician leant onto her, and tried to calm down. Yet it was *so* difficult to stop crying…

However, Shadow Weaver didn't complain nor did she tell her to "calm down" or anything. Quietly, she let her cry as much as she needed, holding her close.

The sky was starting to get light by the time Castaspella's tears subsided.

—Thank you— she whispered.

—I should be thanking you…

—Bea… what will we do now?— she immediately asked, sitting up again, not even wasting time arguing. —They may not remember anything, but… we all narrowly escaped.

—I know— she nodded, taking a deep breath. —That's why we're going to use my last resort: We'll talk to Hordak.

—What?

—We have no other choice. I'll make a new deal with him— she insisted. —He already has you protected, but I'll make sure that, if anything happens to me, he'll also take action to ensure your safety.

—Wait- What does that mean!?

—After what happened… after what we discussed, actually, I've come to the conclusion that I can't trust Micah to spare you if he learns the truth again— Shadow Weaver admitted. —I don't care what he does to me, but *you*?

—I don't understand. What kind of deal will you make?

—Whichever ensures your safety— she smirked. —Now…— she promptly went on, standing up and offering her hand to help her up too. —What about some breakfast? We have a few hours before the court opens.

—Bea… are *you* alright?— Castaspella softly asked, taking her hand.

The vampire pulled her closer, grabbed her chin, and tilted her face upwards as she replied —I'm alive, by your side, and we're both safe and sound. I'm better than I thought I'd be after getting caught last night.

—That doesn't answer my question, but I won't pressure you anymore— she sighed. —Just know I won't judge you.

—But I judge myself…— Shadow Weaver countered. Before Castaspella could further argue, she briefly kissed her and pleaded —Can we *please* drop the matter now? Let me prepare you something to eat.

—Alright— she agreed, with a sad smile.

As soon as the court opened, and without any sleep, the physicians walked inside and requested an audience with the Judge. Afterwards, they were taken further inside and invited to wait "for a short while".

—Casta… why don't you sit down? Walking up and down is *clearly* not easing your nerves, and only driving me insane— Shadow Weaver pointed out, obviously annoyed.

—I just can't stand still…

—You can, and you *should*— she insisted, holding the young physician by the arms. —We've gone over this since breakfast: you've already spoken with Judge Hordak before; you have nothing to fear, and everything will be alright.

—But you're here to make a deal! It's not like our conversation over tea…— Castaspella argued, making no effort to continue pacing. —I'm scared, Bea…

—For absolutely *no* reason. There are no reasons to fear the Judge, there are no threats at all, we even have a solid excuse to be here if any hunter were to ask… and, in fact, look at that— she began, until something behind the physician called her attention. —You wanted to know how they were doing? There you have them, safe and sound…

Turning around immediately, Castaspella let out a relieved sigh upon seeing the Chief and her fiancée approaching.

—Oh, you're here too— Adora noticed, surprised. —Have you come to speak with Judge Hordak?

—That's right— she nervously smiled. —It's quite a relief to see you here!

She tried to hide her anxiety now, but it was evident she failed since the Chief replied —That's good. But… you have nothing to fear, alright?

—Yeah, he's actually pretty reasonable— Catra supported, sounding surprised to be saying that.

Right, right.

She knew that.

But, *ugh*!

She simply couldn't calm down!

—I'm sure, of course— she nodded, looking away.

—Don't waste your energy. She won't calm down— Shadow Weaver interceded. —I've been trying all morning…

Normally, she'd be offended, but… she was right.

—Why are you so nervous, though?— Catra then asked, confused. —Like a month ago, he *told you* that you have his respect.

—Yes, but… I don't even know what I did to deserve it, and I'm- Well, I suppose I fear losing that respect…

—Oh, right— Adora sighed. —I'm sure there's no need to worry, really— she insisted, smiling gently.

—Agreed— her fiancée nodded.

It was actually heartwarming to hear them try to comfort her.

Perhaps she *really* had nothing to fear?

However, before anyone could say anything else, a young woman approached them, perhaps Hordak's secretary or something, and all her nervousness returned.

—Ahem… Judge Hordak will receive you now— she solemnly said. —A couple at a time, though. So, who's going first?

The women exchanged silent glances for a moment until Adora, perhaps due to Castaspella's hesitation, suggested —Why don't we go first so you get ready?

—O-oh, alright. Yes, thank you— the physician quickly agreed without thinking.

—We're going then. Thanks, Lonnie— Catra told her.

As the three left, walking towards a pair of large wooden doors at the back of the main hall of the court, she let out a relieved sigh.

She was *so* not ready yet.

Once they walked in, Lonnie closed from outside and sat behind a desk next to the doors.

—Will you stare much longer?— Shadow Weaver suddenly asked, snickering.

—I wasn't staring?

—You were.

—Whatever…

The women remained silent for a while.

They just kept waiting in quiet company.

It let Castaspella dive into her thoughts uninterrupted…

Eventually, however, Shadow Weaver scoffed in amusement.

—You keep changing your weight from one leg to the other— she pointed out. —Want to sit down instead?

—No— Castaspella denied, shaking her head. Holding her arms, almost hugging herself, she muttered —I don't know what I want…

Or did she?

—Casta, what scares you so much? I *swear* I can't understand, and it's driving me insane, just like your pacing before…— the vampire admitted, concerned now. —Do you want me to speak alone with him?

—No. No…

—Do you have something to tell him, then? Besides what happened last night? Or something to ask?

She *does* know what she wants…

—Perhaps. But- I-I'm… so scared— she whined. —Bea…

—What is it? Tell me.

…And if she really wants it, perhaps it *is* better to let her know before formally speaking to the Judge.

—I- Um, I want…— she began, but interrupted herself to take a deep breath. —I want to… be… *turned*.

Shadow Weaver froze for a second.

—You- So, you want him to turn you!?

—No, that's the thing… I want *you* to turn me— Castaspella clarified. —But I reckon… I should first ask for his permission or something.

The vampire let out a hearty laugh and nodded —You're quite right, indeed. And that, well… that certainly explains why you've been so nervous…

—I've… been thinking about this for a while. Or, well, I just toyed with the idea before, but- I don't know how to put it. I'm *sure* now.

—What are you sure about? What do you want?

—I want to stay with you, Bea. I *need* to make sure my mortality won't- I just don't want to leave you alone— Castaspella managed to explain.

—You'd forfeit your mortality for me?— Shadow Weaver asked, incredulous. —You need to consider all the complications that come with being a vampire…

—I have. I-I will need some time to prepare everything, mainly blood reserves but, with some spells, I'm sure I can manage— the physician stammered. —I've thought about this for a few weeks now…

Doctor Weaver seemed about to say something else, yet only sighed resignedly as she heard the doors to Hordak's office open again. From behind the desk, the young woman, Lonnie, gestured at them to approach and enter the office.

Once inside, doors closed again, Castaspella took a deep breath and smoothed down her dress, pushing back her nerves.

—Welcome, Ladies— the Judge formally greeted them. —I would ask what brings you here today, but I believe I've heard enough— he went on, smirking a bit. Making eye contact with each of them in turn, he said —You, *old friend*, want to make a new deal. And you, young mortal, want to become a vampire… I'm certainly intrigued…

—Are you *sure* about that, Castaspella?— Catra dared ask, glancing briefly over at Adora.

—I am— she nodded, confident. —I know I have nothing to fear. I can handle most risks with magic, and we *are* going to take down the Alliance, so vampires can finally exist freely.

—But *why* do you want to do this? Some sort of revenge against your brother?

—No, Chief. I couldn't care less about Micah— Castaspella denied. —I just want to make sure I can stay with her— she clarified, looking at Shadow Weaver and gently holding her arm. —As a mortal, I'm bound to die eventually… but I don't want to leave her alone.

—It's a… display of loyalty— Adora nodded.

—I know I'm technically betraying my own family, but… If there was any other way, I'd take it. There just isn't.

Right after, the physician noticed how the Chief and Judge Hordak exchanged a look, so fleeting she could have missed it, yet said nothing. Only awaited an answer in silence.

—Alright, here's the thing— Catra decided to speak up instead, stepping closer to Adora. —We have been discussing and, chances are, we won't be so lucky next time. If we're not careful, a full-on war could break out.

—Which means, we need a contingency plan in case that happens before your friend and I can take down the Alliance— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Perhaps more than just a "contingency plan"— Adora clarified. —For my part, I will build a case against the Alliance, against the regents, to put them on trial for *everything* they have been doing.

—I can help with that— Castaspella immediately replied. —I-I have all the investigation I did…— she began explaning, but hesitated a bit. —The *stalking* I did…

—That would actually be of great use. I can find a way to legally use it— the Chief nodded.

—But I… Um, I'll only hand it in if the judge allows Bea- Shadow Weaver to turn me— the physician bargained, making Hordak laugh slightly.

—A fair price— he agreed, joining his hands behind his back as he stood behind his desk. —This leaves us with you— he went on, fixing his gaze on Doctor Weaver. —What are the terms of the new deal?

—It's pretty simple: protect her, at any cost, and I'll do as you command.

Castaspella looked back at the vampire, shocked, and opened her mouth to speak. Yet no words came out.

—You would join the Horde in exchange for something I'm already providing her for free?— he questioned her, seemingly suspicious.

—I'm talking about going one step further: If anything were to happen to me, you *must* intervene to keep her from being caught by the Alliance— Shadow Weaver clarified.

—Bea…

—Hmm… I see— the Judge hummed, pensive. —You believe the King would hurt her?

—After last night? Yes— she immediately nodded.

—I agree— Catra seconded her. —If Castaspella is turned… he won't stop next time.

With that, Hordak finally looked pleased.

—Well, then… Catra: Get the documents for her to sign— he commanded. —And I'll have to ask you two to leave, Chief, Castaspella…

—Alright— Adora nodded, slightly bowing her head in a respectful manner.

—Sure— the physician followed, heading to the door with her after briefly kissing Doctor Weaver.

Once outside, they quietly headed for the closest window and rested there, looking outside.

—Thank you— the Chief eventually exhaled. —For coming to me last night, and helping Catra out of there before… you know…

—Of course, Adora. I hope she's alright.

—A bit shaken from… watching and hearing the torture… But physically fine— she nodded.

—Nightmares?

—Yeah… We slept, like, two hours— she admitted, letting out a sad smile. —She kept waking up gasping and crying.

—We couldn't sleep either— Castaspella admitted. —I suppose I kept her awake…

—I'm pretty sure she'd have trouble sleeping on her own, probably even worse than Catra— the Chief assured her, presumably trying to comfort her.

—I just hope they will… be fine. With time, but…

—I'm sure they will.

Coincidentally, they both took a deep breath and let out a long sigh at the same time.

—I'm glad you both came here today, Chief— Castaspella decided to tell her.

—Me too. I wouldn't blame you if you wanted to go back to "normal", trusting the memory wipe would be enough… so seeing you here was a good sign.

—I hoped as much. After all… The well-being of vampires, the future of those we love… It is in our hands now…

Chapter End Notes

Well, that's everything the Muse is willing to share for this fic
I am so so sorry for pretty much literally reaching no conclusion and leaving it open, but I swear if I ever manage to get anything from that pesky Muse, I shall write a second part XD

In the meantime, how things continued from then on shall be left to your imagination :D So if you wanna picture Adora raining hell on the Alliance, putting everyone in jail save for Bow and SW who got a deal to testify against the hunters, etc, be my guest hahah

ANYWAYS
Thank you so much for reaching the end with me, I certainly hope you enjoyed the Big Bang fanfics, and their art, and I hope to see you again in some other fic! ^_^

Bye everyone!!

Notice!

Guess what!?

It’s live!

There’s officially a continuation to this!

And you get what you wanted!

A trial!!

Feel free to read here!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!